NoC-Lab Research Consortium

# Network-on-Chip and Advanced Interconnects

## Architecture, Co-Design & Emerging Frontiers

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*To the researchers, architects, and silicon engineers*

*whose relentless curiosity pushes the physical boundaries of on-chip communication,*

*and to the students who will design the trillion-transistor computing systems of tomorrow.*

# Preface

For nearly four decades, the computing revolution drew its momentum from the harmonic cadence of Moore's Law and Dennard Scaling: transistors shrank, clock frequencies accelerated into the multi-gigahertz regime, and single-threaded execution performance soared without threatening silicon thermal limits. Around 2005, the irreversible breakdown of Dennard scaling halted clock frequency scaling, forcing a historic pivot toward spatial parallelism: multi-core processors, massively parallel graphics processors, and heterogeneous Systems-on-Chip (SoCs).

Yet scaling compute elements from tens to hundreds, and now thousands of cores on a single die or across 2.5D/3D multi-chiplet assemblies, immediately collided with an unyielding physical reality: the **interconnect crisis**. Global shared multi-drop buses collapsed under quadratic $RC$ wire delay and serialization contention; full crossbar matrices exploded in $O(N^2)$ silicon area and routing track congestion; and deep-submicron copper interconnects below 14 nm succumbed to severe electron scattering and resistive degradation.

The **Network-on-Chip (NoC)** paradigm answered this crisis by transposing packet-switched networking principles directly onto silicon. Today, on-chip and die-to-die communication fabrics form the nervous system of modern computing—from mobile application processors and high-performance server SoCs to wafer-scale accelerators and neuromorphic tensor processors.

## Scope and Structure of This Book

This textbook offers a rigorous, first-principles exploration of on-chip and multi-chiplet interconnection networks. Rather than treating interconnects as abstract graph topologies, this volume bridges the chasm between physical silicon reality, router microarchitecture, mathematical deadlock theory, and emerging technology frontiers.

The book is organized into five cohesive parts:

- **Part I: Foundations & Router Microarchitecture (Chapters 1–3)** establishes the physical interconnect crisis, mathematical delay formulations, switching techniques, credit and token flow control, and pipelined router microarchitecture with virtual channel allocation and crossbar arbitration.
- **Part II: Topologies, Routing & Deadlock Freedom (Chapters 4–5)** investigates direct, indirect, and high-radix networks, Dally's channel dependency graph (CDG) theorems, Duato's adaptive routing theory, and turn models.
- **Part III: Physical Constraints: Power, Thermal & Reliability (Chapters 6–7)** addresses dark silicon dynamics, voltage/frequency scaling, compact thermal RC modeling, hotspot mitigation, and fault-tolerant routing.
- **Part IV: Advanced Packaging, 3D NoC & Chiplets (Chapters 8–9)** explores through-silicon via (TSV) vertical architectures, 2.5D silicon interposers, and the Universal Chiplet Interconnect Express (UCIe) die-to-die standard.
- **Part V: Emerging Frontiers (Chapter 10)** covers silicon nanophotonic interconnects (ONoC), micro-ring resonators, and on-chip millimeter-wave/sub-THz wireless communication (WNoC).

## Grounding in Premier Literature & Silicon Implementations

Every theoretical formulation, architectural trade-off, and silicon case study in this monograph is grounded directly in premier peer-reviewed literature from IEEE and ACM venues, including *IEEE Transactions on Very Large Scale Integration (VLSI) Systems* (TVLSI), *IEEE Transactions on Computer-Aided Design of Integrated Circuits and Systems* (TCAD), *IEEE Journal of Solid-State Circuits* (JSSC), and *IEEE Transactions on Circuits and Systems* (TCAS-I/II). Landmark silicon achievements—such as the 2,048-core HammerBlade SoC, the FlooNoC open-source AXI4 fabric, and the SWIFT token flow-control architecture—are dissected alongside first-principles physics.

## Co-Design with the Interactive Companion Hub

To enhance pedagogy and provide hands-on experimentation, this monograph is co-designed with an interactive online platform:

**NoC Learning Hub**: `https://network-on-chip.github.io/learning/`

Each chapter links directly to interactive browser-based simulators, including the 2D Mesh Routing Visualizer, Arbiter Arena, Credit Commander, and UCIe Protocol Analyzer, accompanied by multi-tier assessment engines and executable Verilog/Python code repositories.

**The NoC-Lab Research Consortium**
*November 2026*

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# List of Acronyms

| | |
|---|---|
| 2D/3D | Two-/Three-Dimensional |
| AMBA | Advanced Microcontroller Bus Architecture |
| AXI4 | Advanced eXtensible Interface 4 |
| BEP | Bit Error Probability |
| BGA | Ball Grid Array |
| CDG | Channel Dependency Graph |
| CMP | Chip Multiprocessor |
| CRC | Cyclic Redundancy Check |
| D2D | Die-to-Die |
| DMA | Direct Memory Access |
| DVFS | Dynamic Voltage and Frequency Scaling |
| Flit | Flow Control Unit |
| GALS | Globally Asynchronous Locally Synchronous |
| HOL | Head-of-Line (Blocking) |
| HPCA | High-Performance Computer Architecture |
| IP | Intellectual Property |
| IRDS | International Roadmap for Devices and Systems |
| ISCA | International Symposium on Computer Architecture |
| ITRS | International Technology Roadmap for Semiconductors |
| JSSC | IEEE Journal of Solid-State Circuits |
| LLM | Large Language Model |
| MPSoC | Multi-Processor System-on-Chip |
| NI | Network Interface |
| NoC | Network-on-Chip |
| OCSSI | On-Chip Source-Synchronous Interconnect |
| ONoC | Optical Network-on-Chip |
| PE | Processing Element |
| Phit | Physical Unit |

| | |
|---|---|
| PMA | Physical Medium Attachment |
| PPA | Power, Performance, and Area |
| PUF | Physically Unclonable Function |
| QoS | Quality of Service |
| RC | Route Computation |
| RoB | Reorder Buffer |
| RTT | Round-Trip Time |
| SA | Switch Allocation |
| SAF | Store-and-Forward (Switching) |
| SCC | Single-Chip Cloud Computer |
| SNN | Spiking Neural Network |
| SoC | System-on-Chip |
| ST | Switch Traversal |
| TCAD | IEEE Transactions on Computer-Aided Design of Integrated Circuits and Systems |
| TCAS | IEEE Transactions on Circuits and Systems |
| TSV | Through-Silicon Via |
| TVLSI | IEEE Transactions on Very Large Scale Integration Systems |
| UCIe | Universal Chiplet Interconnect Express |
| VA | Virtual Channel Allocation |
| VC | Virtual Channel |
| VCT | Virtual Cut-Through (Switching) |
| WH | Wormhole (Switching) |
| WNoC | Wireless Network-on-Chip |
| WSC | Wafer-Scale Computing |

# Part I
# Foundations & Router Microarchitecture

# Chapter 1
# The Multi-Core Communication Crisis & Interconnect Physics

**Abstract** For over three decades, semiconductor compute performance accelerated through Dennard scaling and monolithic bus interconnects. Around 2005, the physical collapse of Dennard scaling halted clock frequency scaling, forcing a historic pivot toward horizontal core parallelism. However, scaling processing core counts immediately exposed the interconnect crisis: shared multi-drop buses suffer from cubic Elmore delay scaling and severe serialization bottlenecks; centralized crossbars explode with quadratic silicon area and routing congestion; and deep-submicron copper lines undergo severe electron scattering under the Mayadas-Shatzkes effect. This chapter establishes the physical foundations of on-chip wire scaling, mathematically analyzes bus and crossbar limitations, and introduces the Network-on-Chip (NoC) paradigm as the scalable packet-switched backbone of modern manycore processors, highlighted through silicon case studies including the 2,048-core HammerBlade SoC.

## 1.1 The Breakdown of Dennard Scaling and the Multi-Core Pivot

For over three decades, the semiconductor industry advanced along the dual trajectories of **Moore's Law** (transistor density doubling approximately every 18–24 months) and **Dennard Scaling** [10] (constant power density through proportional scaling of supply voltage $V_{dd}$, threshold voltage $V_{th}$, and physical oxide thickness $t_{ox}$). Under classical Dennard scaling:

$$\text{Power Density} = \frac{P_{active}}{\text{Area}} \propto \frac{C \cdot V_{dd}^2 \cdot f}{1/s^2} \approx \text{Constant} \tag{1.1}$$

where $s \approx 1.4$ is the per-generation linear scaling factor. Because operating frequency could be increased by $\approx 40\%$ each generation without increasing power dissipation per unit silicon area, single-threaded performance grew exponentially without encountering thermal catastrophic failure.

Around 2004–2005, at the 90 nm and 65 nm process nodes, Dennard scaling suffered an irreversible collapse. As gate oxide thickness reached atomic dimensions ($t_{ox} \leq 1.2$ nm, merely 4–5 silicon dioxide monolayers), **quantum mechanical direct tunneling** through the gate dielectric surged exponentially:

$$J_{tunnel} \approx A \cdot \left(\frac{V_{ox}}{t_{ox}}\right)^2 \exp\left(-\frac{B \cdot [1-(1-V_{ox}/\Phi_B)^{3/2}]}{V_{ox}/t_{ox}}\right) \tag{1.2}$$

At the same time, sub-threshold leakage current $I_{sub}$ prevented further aggressive reductions of the supply voltage $V_{dd}$, as the threshold voltage $V_{th}$ could not be reduced without causing unacceptable static standby power dissipation:

$$I_{sub} = \mu_0 C_{ox} \frac{W}{L}(m-1)V_T^2 \exp\left(\frac{V_{gs}-V_{th}}{mV_T}\right)\left(1-\exp\left(-\frac{V_{ds}}{V_T}\right)\right) \tag{1.3}$$

where $V_T = \frac{k_B T}{q} \approx 26$ mV at 300 K, and $m$ is the sub-threshold swing factor ($m \approx 1.1$–$1.4$). Consequently, chip architects struck the unyielding **Power Wall** ($\approx$ 100–130 W/cm$^2$ for air-cooled packaging). Increasing the clock frequency beyond 3.5–4.0 GHz became thermally untenable.

To maintain compute throughput growth, processor design executed a historic pivot from *frequency scaling* to *spatial concurrency*: multi-core processors, Chip Multiprocessors (CMPs), and Multi-Processor Systems-on-Chip (MPSoCs). However, scaling the number of processing elements from dual-core to tens, hundreds, and thousands of cores immediately triggered an existential crisis in **on-chip interconnect physical design**.

## 1.2 The Failure of Shared Multi-Drop Buses

In early Systems-on-Chip, intellectual property (IP) blocks (CPUs, DSPs, DMA engines, SRAM banks) communicated through shared multi-drop buses such as ARM AMBA (AHB/APB), IBM CoreConnect, or Wishbone. While shared buses are simple and cost-effective for small SoCs ($N \leq 4$–$8$ masters), they collapse under severe physical and architectural bottlenecks as core counts grow.

### 1.2.1 Capacitive Loading & Elmore Wire Delay

A shared bus consists of long physical metal traces spanning across the silicon die. Every connected master and slave attaches an input/output transceiver tap to the shared wire. According to the **Elmore Delay Model** [13], the propagation delay $\tau_{bus}$ of a distributed $RC$ line loaded by $N$ capacitive taps is:

**Table 1.1** Physical Interconnect Scaling Across Core Counts (Die Edge: 12 mm, Process: 12nm FinFET, $r_{wire} = 800\ \Omega$/mm, $c_{wire} = 0.18$ pF/mm, $c_{tap} = 8$ fF)

| Cores ($N$) | Bus Delay (ps) | Max Bus Freq | Aggregate Bus BW | Crossbar Switches | 2D Mesh Bisection BW |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2 | 9,044 ps | 55.3 MHz | 0.88 GB/s | 4 | 128 GB/s |
| 4 | 9,129 ps | 54.8 MHz | 0.88 GB/s | 16 | 128 GB/s |
| 8 | 9,298 ps | 53.8 MHz | 0.86 GB/s | 64 | 192 GB/s |
| 16 | 9,638 ps | 51.9 MHz | 0.83 GB/s | 256 | 256 GB/s |
| 32 | 10,316 ps | 48.5 MHz | 0.78 GB/s | 1,024 | 384 GB/s |
| 64 | 11,673 ps | 42.8 MHz | 0.69 GB/s | 4,096 | 512 GB/s |
| 128 | 14,386 ps | 34.8 MHz | 0.56 GB/s | 16,384 | 768 GB/s |
| 256 | 19,814 ps | 25.2 MHz | 0.40 GB/s | 65,536 | 1,024 GB/s |

$$\tau_{bus} \approx 0.38 \cdot R_{wire} \cdot C_{wire} + R_{driver} \cdot \left( C_{wire} + \sum_{i=1}^{N} C_{tap,i} \right) + \sum_{i=1}^{N} R_{wire,i} \cdot C_{tap,i} \tag{1.4}$$

where:

- $R_{wire} = r_{wire} \cdot L$ is the total resistance of the global metal wire across the die ($L \approx 10$–$20$ mm).
- $C_{wire} = c_{wire} \cdot L$ is the distributed wire capacitance (area capacitance to substrate plus fringe capacitance).
- $C_{tap,i}$ is the input/output capacitance of the $i$-th master/slave transceiver tap.
- $R_{driver}$ is the equivalent output resistance of the driving transistor.

Because every attached core adds capacitive load ($C_{taps} = N \cdot C_{tap}$), the total capacitance scales linearly with core count ($C_{total} \propto N$). Furthermore, because the wire length $L$ scales with the die perimeter ($L \propto \sqrt{N}$), the intrinsic wire $RC$ product grows with the square of the die dimension:

$$\tau_{bus} \propto R_{wire} \cdot C_{total} \propto (\sqrt{N}) \cdot (N + \sqrt{N}) \propto N^{3/2} \tag{1.5}$$

Consequently, the maximum achievable bus clock frequency ($f_{max} \approx \frac{1}{2\tau_{bus}}$) plunges precipitously. While local processor logic easily ran at 2.0–3.0 GHz, global shared buses were throttled to 200–400 MHz.

### 1.2.2 The Serialization Contention Bottleneck

A shared bus is a **single shared transmission medium**. At any given clock cycle, the centralized bus arbiter can grant bus access to **exactly one master**:

- **Fixed Aggregate Bandwidth**: $BW_{agg} = W \times f_{bus}$, where $W$ is bus width (e.g., 64 or 128 bits) and $f_{bus}$ is bus clock frequency.

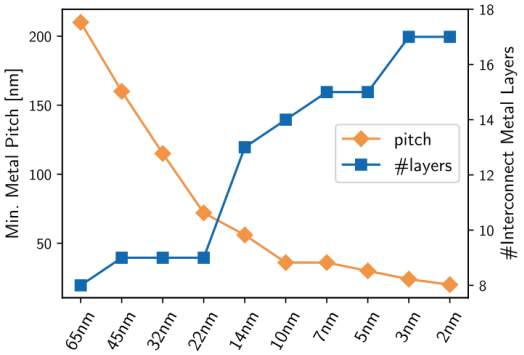



Fig. 1. Technology scaling of on-chip wire resources based on IDRS reports [8] for 2–14 nm and [9] for 22–65 nm.

**Fig. 1.1** Technology scaling of on-chip wire resources based on ITRS/IRDS reports for 2–14 nm and 22–65 nm nodes. While transistor delay decreases exponentially, global wire delay surges. [Reproduced from: T. Fischer, M. Rogenmoser, T. Benz, F. K. Gürkaynak, and L. Benini, "FlooNoC: A 645-Gb/s/link 0.15-pJ/B/hop Open-Source NoC With Wide Physical Links and End-to-End AXI4 Parallel Multistream Support," *IEEE Trans. Very Large Scale Integr. (VLSI) Syst.*, vol. 33, no. 4, pp. 1094–1107, Apr. 2025 [15]. © 2025 IEEE]

- **Per-Core Bandwidth Starvation**: $BW_{per_core} \leq \frac{W \times f_{bus}}{N}$. As core count $N$ increases, per-core bandwidth asymptotically approaches zero.
- **Arbitration Scalability**: Centralized round-robin or matrix arbiters require $O(N)$ logic depth, transforming grant generation into a critical-path timing bottleneck.

## 1.3 Sub-10nm Interconnect Physics & Wire Scaling

The physical crisis of global wiring is exacerbated by the physics of deep-submicron copper interconnects [21]. In technology nodes below 14 nm, 7 nm, and 3 nm, interconnect resistance does not scale inversely with cross-sectional area.

### 1.3.1 The Mayadas-Shatzkes & Fuchs-Sondheimer Scattering Models

In bulk copper at room temperature, the electron mean free path is $\lambda_0 \approx 39.0$ nm. When the physical width $w$ of an on-chip metal wire shrinks below $2\lambda_0 \approx 80$ nm, two scattering mechanisms cause the effective resistivity $\rho_{eff}$ to surge dramatically above the bulk value ($\rho_{bulk} \approx 1.68 \times 10^{-8}\ \Omega \cdot \text{m}$):

1. **Surface Scattering (Fuchs-Sondheimer Model)**: Electrons reflect diffusely off the outer interfaces of the wire:

$$\frac{\rho_{FS}}{\rho_{bulk}} = 1 + \frac{3}{8\kappa}(1-p) \tag{1.6}$$

where $\kappa = \frac{w_{eff}}{\lambda_0}$ is the normalized wire dimension and $p \in [0,1]$ is the specularity parameter ($p \approx 0.2$ for realistic barrier interfaces).

2. **Grain Boundary Scattering (Mayadas-Shatzkes Model)** [36]: Nanoscale copper recrystallizes into small grains with average grain diameter $d \approx w_{eff}$. Electrons scatter at grain boundaries:

$$\frac{\rho_{MS}}{\rho_{bulk}} = \frac{1}{3\left[\frac{1}{3} - \frac{\alpha}{2} + \alpha^2 - \alpha^3 \ln\left(1 + \frac{1}{\alpha}\right)\right]} \tag{1.7}$$

where $\alpha = \frac{\lambda_0}{d}\frac{R}{1-R}$, with $R \approx 0.3$–$0.5$ representing the grain boundary reflection coefficient.

3. **Diffusion Barrier Liner Encroachment**: Copper electromigration requires high-resistivity diffusion liners (Ta/TaN, Co, Ru) of thickness $t_{barrier} \approx$ 1.0–1.5 nm. Because the liner does not scale down proportionally with the wire trench, the conductive copper cross-sectional area $A_{Cu}$ shrinks much faster than total wire trench area:

$$A_{Cu} = (w - 2t_{barrier}) \cdot (h - t_{barrier}), \qquad \rho_{total} = \rho_{eff} \cdot \left(\frac{w \cdot h}{A_{Cu}}\right) \tag{1.8}$$

At the 3 nm node ($w \approx 10$ nm), the effective copper resistivity exceeds 15× bulk copper, turning long global wires into unbearable thermal, resistance, and latency bottlenecks.

## 1.4 The Monolithic Crossbar and Its Quadratic Area Explosion

To avoid the serialized contention of a single shared bus, architects initially considered a full centralized crossbar switch connecting $N$ masters directly to $M$ slaves. While a crossbar allows non-interfering parallel communication between disjoint pairs of masters and slaves, its hardware complexity scales quadratically:

$$\text{Crosspoints} = N \times M \approx O(N^2), \qquad \text{Wiring Tracks} = (N+M) \times W_{data_width} \approx O(N) \tag{1.9}$$

For an MPSoC with $N = 64$ cores, a full crossbar requires $64 \times 64 = 4,096$ crosspoint multiplexer switches and $128 \times 128 = 16,384$ wires crossing a central silicon layout area, causing severe layout congestion, routing track starvation, and parasitic capacitive coupling crosstalk. A full crossbar switch is physically viable only for small clusters ($N \leq 4$–$8$ cores).

## 1.5 The Network-on-Chip Paradigm: Packet-Switched Modular Interconnects

In 2001, pioneering papers by Dally & Towles (*"Route Packets, Not Wires"* [7]) and Benini & De Micheli (*"Networks on Chips: A New SoC Paradigm"* [2]) introduced the definitive architectural solution:

**The Network-on-Chip (NoC) Principle**: Replace long, dedicated, unstructured global metal wires with a structured, packet-switched micro-network composed of modular routers and short, pipelined point-to-point links.

Key advantages of the NoC architecture include:

1. **Bounded Wire Lengths**: Every link connects strictly adjacent routers. The link wire length is fixed to the physical pitch of one compute tile ($L_{link} \approx 0.5$–$1.5$ mm), regardless of whether the chip contains 16 or 2,048 cores.
2. **Predictable Timing & Pipelining**: Because link wire delay is short and localized, routers and links can be clocked at high frequencies ($f_{clk} \approx 1.5$–$2.5$ GHz) without repeater insertion crises.
3. **Concurrent Multi-Hop Communication**: Multiple packets traverse non-overlapping segments of the network simultaneously, yielding aggregate throughput that scales proportionally with the network size:

$$BW_{bisection} \propto \sqrt{N} \times W_{link} \times f_{clk} \tag{1.10}$$

4. **Modularity & Silicon Reuse**: Adding processing tiles does not require redesigning the global wiring tree.

## 1.6 Industrial Case Studies: From 48 Cores to 2,048 Cores

To examine the real-world execution of NoC architecture in modern silicon, we analyze landmark implementations from our literature corpus:

### 1.6.1 The 2,048-Core HammerBlade Manycore SoC (12nm FinFET)

A landmark demonstration of extreme monolithic scaling is the **HammerBlade (HB)** processor developed by Gao et al. [19] and Davidson et al. [9].

Key architectural and physical metrics of the HammerBlade processor include:

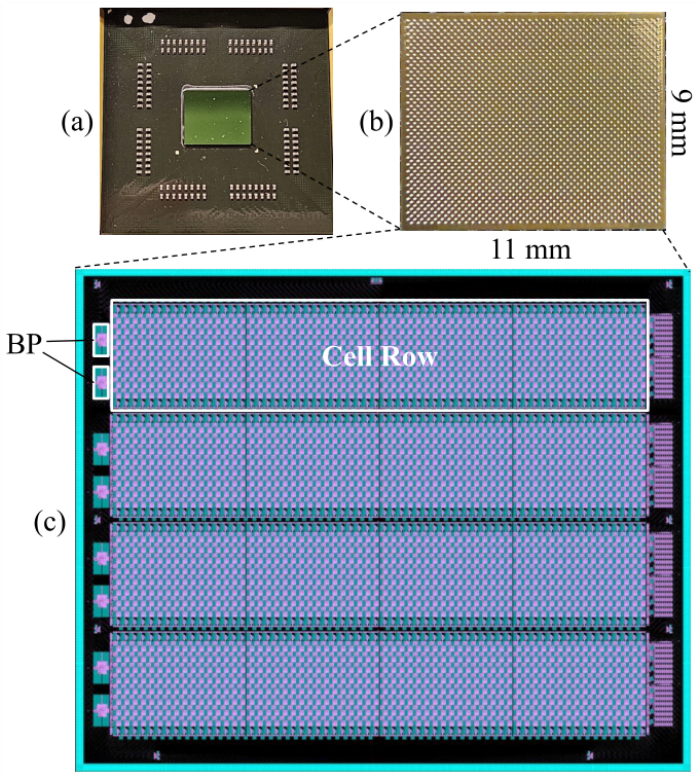
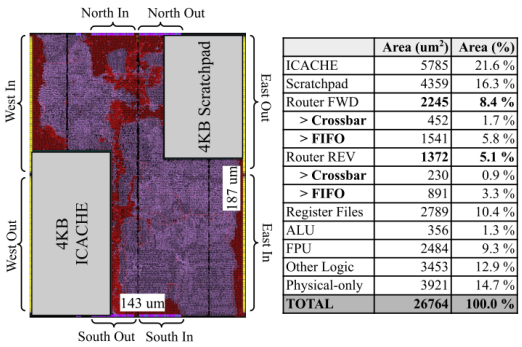



Fig. 1. (a) BGA 2116 flip-chip packaging, (b) 11 × 9-mm die photograph, and (c) chip floorplan. BP = BlackParrot Processor [7].

**Fig. 1.2** Modern monolithic manycore scaling in 12nm silicon: (a) BGA 2116 flip-chip packaging, (b) 11 × 9-mm die photograph, and (c) chip floorplan of the 2,048-core HammerBlade SoC. [Reproduced from: P. Gao et al., "HammerBlade in Silicon: A 12-nm 2048-Core RISC-V Manycore SoC With Ruche Networks," *IEEE Trans. Very Large Scale Integr. (VLSI) Syst.*, vol. 34, no. 7, pp. 2306–2310, July 2026 [19]. © 2026 IEEE]

- **Silicon Area**: 99 $mm^2$ in TSMC 12nm FinFET.
- **Compute Density**: 2,048 custom RISC-V cores organized into an array of $64 \times 32$ tiles.
- **Interconnect Topology**: **Ruche Network**, a wire-maximal topology overlaying nearest-neighbor 2D mesh links with long-distance multi-hop bypass express wires.
- **Clocking & Throughput**: Operating at **1.49 GHz at 0.8 V**, the NoC delivers a peak aggregate bandwidth of **2,572.6 Tb/s** and a bisection bandwidth of **53.2 Tb/s**.




| | Area (um$^2$) | Area (%) |
|---|---|---|
| ICACHE | 5785 | 21.6 % |
| Scratchpad | 4359 | 16.3 % |
| Router FWD | **2245** | **8.4 %** |
| **> Crossbar** | 452 | 1.7 % |
| **> FIFO** | 1541 | 5.8 % |
| Router REV | **1372** | **5.1 %** |
| **> Crossbar** | 230 | 0.9 % |
| **> FIFO** | 891 | 3.3 % |
| Register Files | 2789 | 10.4 % |
| ALU | 356 | 1.3 % |
| FPU | 2484 | 9.3 % |
| Other Logic | 3453 | 12.9 % |
| Physical-only | 3921 | 14.7 % |
| **TOTAL** | **26764** | **100.0 %** |

**Fig. 1.3** HammerBlade compute tile floorplan and physical area breakdown showing router cells (red) and core logic (pink). [Reproduced from: P. Gao et al., "HammerBlade in Silicon: A 12-nm 2048-Core RISC-V Manycore SoC With Ruche Networks," *IEEE Trans. Very Large Scale Integr. (VLSI) Syst.*, vol. 34, no. 7, pp. 2306–2310, July 2026 [19]. © 2026 IEEE]

Fig. 2. HB compute tile floorplan and its area breakdown. Router cells (red) and the core logic (pink).

**Table 1.2** Evolution of Silicon Landmark Network-on-Chip Processors

| Architecture | Year / Venue | Process Node | Tile Array / Cores | Peak Bisection BW | Interconnect Topology |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Intel TeraFLOPS | 2007 JSSC [10] | 65nm Bulk | 8 × 10 (80) | 1.6 Tb/s | 2D Mesh (5-port) |
| Intel 48-Core SCC | 2011 JSSC [22] | 45nm Bulk | 6 × 4 (48) | 256 Gb/s | 2D Mesh (e-cube) |
| Theseus WSC | 2025 TCAD [52] | Wafer-Scale | Wafer Grid | 100+ Tb/s | 2D Torus Wafer NoC |
| FlooNoC (Benini) | 2025 TVLSI [15] | 12nm Fin-FET | 8 × 4 (288) | 103 Tb/s | Wide AXI4 2D Mesh |
| HammerBlade (Gao) | 2026 TVLSI [19] | 12nm Fin-FET | 64 × 32 (2,048) | 53.2 Tb/s | Ruche Multi-Hop NoC |

- **Routing Density**: Achieves **4,289 bit/mm** across higher metal layers.
- **Integration**: Leverages **On-Chip Source-Synchronous Interconnect (OCSSI)** under a Globally Asynchronous Locally Synchronous (GALS) paradigm to eliminate chip-wide clock tree skew.

## 1.7 Interactive Lab & Hands-on Challenges

To build an experimental understanding of interconnect trade-offs, explore the companion simulators on the **NoC Learning Hub** (https://network-on-chip.github.io/learning/):

- **2D Mesh Routing Visualizer** (https://network-on-chip.github.io/learning/interactive/visualizer/): Inject uniform random and hotspot

traffic into a $4 \times 4$ and $8 \times 8$ mesh; observe how localized point-to-point links sustain continuous throughput without centralized bus stalls.
- **Topology Titans: Graph Architect** (https://network-on-chip.github.io/learning/interactive/topology/): Synthesize 2D Mesh, 2D Torus, and Hypercube topologies within strict wire length and pin degree limits.
- **Arbiter Arena: Crossbar Clash** (https://network-on-chip.github.io/learning/interactive/arbiter/): Benchmark matrix, round-robin, and wavefront arbiters under heavy contention.

## 1.8 Checkpoint Assessment

1. **Question 1.1 (Tier 1: Fundamental)**: Why does the propagation delay of a shared multi-drop bus grow as $O(N^{3/2})$ to $O(N^2)$ as core count $N$ scales, rather than remaining constant?
2. **Question 1.2 (Tier 2: Architectural Analysis)**: What is the Mayadas-Shatzkes effect, and why does it represent a critical barrier for on-chip global interconnects below 14 nm?
3. **Question 1.3 (Tier 3: Design Trade-Off)**: Why is a centralized $N \times N$ crossbar switch unacceptable for a 128-core processor, despite offering non-blocking zero-hop communication between disjoint pairs?

*Detailed answers and derivations for these questions are provided in the Solutions chapter at the end of this volume.*

# Chapter 2
# Switching Techniques, Flow Control & Buffer Management

**Abstract** The efficiency, latency, and area footprint of an on-chip network are fundamentally dictated by its switching and flow control architecture. This chapter explores how raw application messages are decomposed into packets, flits, and phits, and details how silicon Network Interfaces bridge industry-standard protocols such as ARM AMBA AXI4 to internal NoC channels. We develop rigorous mathematical latency formulations comparing Store-and-Forward (SAF), Virtual Cut-Through (VCT), and Wormhole switching. We analyze lossless flow control mechanisms, proving the fundamental relationship between credit turnaround loop round-trip time (RTT) and minimum buffer sizing to sustain wire-rate throughput. Finally, we examine low-power alternative flow-control architectures, featuring the SWIFT token flow-control router with flit buffer bypassing.

## 2.1 The Data Granularity Hierarchy: Messages, Packets, Flits & Phits

Transmitting arbitrary software data structures across silicon requires decomposing raw application payloads into structured physical transmission units. To optimize buffer utilization, minimize pipeline latency, and guarantee deadlock-free routing, NoCs establish a four-layer data abstraction hierarchy:

1. **Application Message**: The software-level unit of communication generated by a processing element or memory subsystem (e.g., a 64-byte L2/L3 cache line refill, a 16-byte cache coherence invalidation, or a 4 KB AXI4 DMA burst).
2. **Packet**: The fundamental *routing unit* of the network. A packet encapsulates destination routing coordinates ($X_{dest}, Y_{dest}$), virtual network priorities, transaction identifiers, and error detection checksums (CRC/parity).

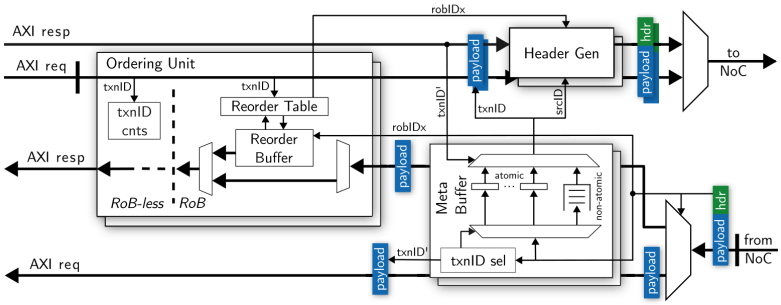



Fig. 2. AXI4 NI architecture for request (AR/AW/W) and response (R/B) paths. Reads and writes are independent in AXI4, and the request/response paths are very similar in the NI and are depicted as overlapping modules. The *ordering unit* can be configured with or without reordering capabilities (i.e., *RoB* and *RoB-less*).

**Fig. 2.1** AXI4 Network Interface (NI) architecture for independent request (AR/AW/W) and response (R/B) paths, with reorder buffering (RoB) and direct DMA streaming. [Reproduced from: T. Fischer, M. Rogenmoser, T. Benz, F. K. Gürkaynak, and L. Benini, "FlooNoC: A 645-Gb/s/link 0.15-pJ/B/hop Open-Source NoC With Wide Physical Links and End-to-End AXI4 Parallel Multistream Support," *IEEE Trans. Very Large Scale Integr. (VLSI) Syst.*, vol. 33, no. 4, pp. 1094–1107, Apr. 2025 [15]. © 2025 IEEE]

3. **Flow Control Unit (Flit)**: The fundamental *buffering and flow control allocation unit*. Router buffers allocate storage in integer multiples of flits. Flits are partitioned into:
   - **Head Flit**: Carries routing destination coordinates. It reserves output ports and downstream virtual channels.
   - **Body Flits**: Carry data payloads along the established path without re-evaluating routing tables.
   - **Tail Flit**: Signals packet completion, releasing allocated virtual channels and router state registers.
   - **Head-Tail Flit**: A single-flit packet carrying both header metadata and payload in a single clock cycle.
4. **Physical Unit (Phit)**: The number of physical bits transmitted across a router link in *exactly one clock cycle*. When link bus width equals flit width ($W_{link} = W_{flit}$), 1 Flit = 1 Phit. If flit width exceeds physical link width, a serialization ratio of $\frac{W_{flit}}{W_{link}}$ cycles per flit is incurred.

## 2.2 Silicon Network Interface: The AXI4 / NoC Protocol Translation

At the boundary between processing cores and the on-chip network fabric, the **Network Interface (NI)** bridges SoC protocol standards (such as ARM AMBA AXI4, OCP, or RISC-V TileLink) to the internal packetized NoC protocol.

As demonstrated in **FlooNoC** [15], modern high-performance NIs decouple independent AXI4 channels onto dedicated physical or virtual networks to prevent protocol-level deadlock:

- **Request Network**: Translates Read Address (`AR`), Write Address (`AW`), and Write Data (`W`) channels into multi-flit request packets.
- **Response Network**: Translates Read Data (`R`) and Write Response (`B`) channels into separate response packets.
- **Reorder Buffer (RoB)**: Restores in-order AXI transaction completion when packets traverse adaptive, out-of-order routing paths.

## 2.3 Mathematical Latency Analysis of Switching Techniques

The switching technique dictates when and how an incoming flit is forwarded from an input port to an output port. We analyze three classical switching paradigms across path length $H$ (in hops), packet length $L$ (in flits), physical link bandwidth $W$ (bits/cycle), and router pipeline latency $t_r$ (cycles/hop).

### 2.3.1 Store-and-Forward (SAF) Switching

In Store-and-Forward switching, a router must receive, buffer, and verify the *entire packet* before forwarding its first flit to the downstream router:

$$t_{serial} = \frac{L}{W}, \qquad T_{SAF} = H \cdot \left( t_r + \frac{L}{W} + t_{link} \right) \tag{2.1}$$

If $t_r + t_{link} \ll \frac{L}{W}$, the zero-load latency scales as:

$$T_{SAF} \approx H \cdot \frac{L}{W} \propto H \cdot L \tag{2.2}$$

This multiplicative dependence ($H \cdot L$) imposes severe latency penalties over long distances and necessitates massive SRAM buffers ($\geq L$ flits per port).

### 2.3.2 Virtual Cut-Through (VCT) Switching

Introduced by Kermani & Kleinrock [28], Virtual Cut-Through permits a router to forward the Head flit to the downstream router *immediately* after route computation and arbitration, without awaiting trailing flits, provided the downstream router has allocated full packet buffer space:

**Table 2.1** Analytical Comparison of Switching Techniques across 8 Hops ($t_r = 2$ cycles, $t_{link} = 1$ cycle)

| Packet Length | Hop Count | SAF Latency | VCT / WH Latency | Speedup VCT/WH | of Wormhole Buffer Saving | Area |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 4 flits | 4 hops | 28 cycles | 15 cycles | 1.87× | Baseline | |
| 8 flits | 4 hops | 44 cycles | 19 cycles | 2.32× | 50.0% saving | |
| 16 flits | 4 hops | 76 cycles | 27 cycles | 2.81× | 75.0% saving | |
| 32 flits | 4 hops | 140 cycles | 43 cycles | 3.26× | 87.5% saving | |
| 16 flits | 8 hops | 152 cycles | 39 cycles | 3.90× | 75.0% saving | |
| 32 flits | 8 hops | 280 cycles | 55 cycles | 5.09× | 87.5% saving | |
| 64 flits | 8 hops | 536 cycles | 87 cycles | 6.16× | 93.8% saving | |

$$T_{VCT} = H \cdot (t_r + t_{link}) + \frac{L-1}{W} \tag{2.3}$$

Here, distance $H$ and packet length $L$ are **additive** ($H + L$), cutting zero-load latency dramatically under low traffic. However, VCT still requires allocating a full packet's worth of buffering ($B \geq L$) before granting admission.

### 2.3.3 Wormhole (WH) Switching

Proposed by Dally & Seitz [6], **Wormhole Switching** decouples flow control units from packet size:

> **The Wormhole Principle**: Router buffers operate at the granularity of individual **flits**, rather than entire packets. Buffer depth per virtual channel can be as small as 1 to 4 flits, completely independent of packet length $L$.

The zero-load latency of Wormhole switching mirrors VCT under uncongested conditions:

$$T_{WH} = H \cdot (t_r + t_{link}) + \frac{L-1}{W} \tag{2.4}$$

However, the silicon area savings are transformative: router input buffers shrink by 75% to 93% compared to SAF and VCT, as demonstrated in Table 2.1.

## 2.4 Lossless Flow Control Mechanisms

Because silicon buffers are finite, on-chip networks must implement **lossless flow control** to guarantee zero flit drops.

### 2.4.1 Credit-Based Flow Control & The Credit Turnaround Loop

Credit-based flow control operates via an upstream ‘credit_counter‘ initialized to receiver buffer capacity $B$. Transmission decrements the counter; receiving a credit pulse increments it. The total Round-Trip Time ($RTT$) of the credit turnaround loop is:

$$RTT = t_{tx_proc} + t_{flight_fwd} + t_{rx_proc} + t_{flight_credit} \tag{2.5}$$

For adjacent routers clocked synchronously:

$$RTT = 1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 4 \text{ cycles} \tag{2.6}$$

**The Fundamental Throughput Theorem**: To sustain 100% wire-rate throughput without pipeline stall bubbles, the downstream buffer depth $B$ must satisfy:

$$B_{min} \geq RTT \times \text{Peak Injection Rate} = RTT \text{ flits} \tag{2.7}$$

Table 2.2 illustrates the severe bandwidth degradation that occurs when buffer depth $B < RTT$.

## 2.5 Alternative Flow Control: Token Flow Control in the SWIFT NoC

In high-performance low-power interconnects, **Token Flow Control** [43] routes tokens ahead of data flits to achieve flit buffer bypassing.

Key innovations of the SWIFT architecture include:

1. **Flit Buffer Bypassing**: Tokens reserve crossbar paths in advance; data flits cut straight through the crossbar into the link without writing into input SRAM FIFO cells.
2. **Buffer Power Reduction**: Dynamic FIFO write power is slashed by 38% at saturation and 25% at low load.

**Table 2.2** Buffer Depth vs. Achievable Link Utilization ($RTT = 4$ cycles, 100-cycle injection simulation)

| Buffer Depth ($B$) | $RTT$ (Cycles) | Link Utilization | Flits Transferred | Pipeline Stall State |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| $B = 1$ flit | 4 cycles | 20.0% | 20 flits | Severe Underflow Stall |
| $B = 2$ flits | 4 cycles | 40.0% | 40 flits | Severe Underflow Stall |
| $B = 3$ flits | 4 cycles | 60.0% | 60 flits | Moderate Stall |
| $B = 4$ flits | 4 cycles | 80.0% | 80 flits | Boundary Stall Bubble |
| $B = 5$ flits | 4 cycles | 100.0% | 100 flits | 100% Full Wire-Rate |
| $B = 8$ flits | 4 cycles | 100.0% | 100 flits | 100% Wire-Rate (Safe Margin) |

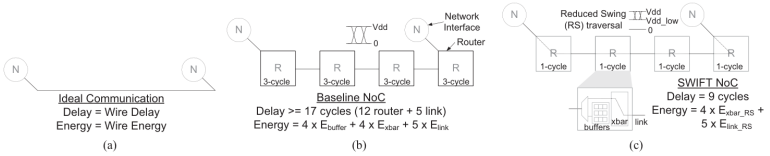



Fig. 1. Overview of SWIFT NoC versus a baseline NoC and ideal communication. (a) Ideal communication. (b) Baseline NoC. (c) SWIFT NoC.

**Fig. 2.2** Overview of SWIFT NoC versus baseline multi-stage NoC: (a) Ideal single-cycle communication, (b) Baseline multi-stage NoC, and (c) SWIFT NoC with token-based flit buffer bypassing. [Reproduced from: J. Postman, T. Krishna, C. Edmonds, L.-S. Peh, and P. Chiang, "SWIFT: A Low-Power Network-On-Chip Implementing the Token Flow Control Router Architecture With Swing-Reduced Interconnects," *IEEE Trans. Very Large Scale Integr. (VLSI) Syst.*, vol. 21, no. 8, pp. 1432–1446, Aug. 2013 [43]. © 2013 IEEE]

**Fig. 2.3** SWIFT NoC microarchitecture: (a) Routing using tokens, (b) Token distribution, (c) Bypass flow control using lookahead signals, and (d) 1-cycle router plus 1-cycle link traversal. [Reproduced from: J. Postman et al., *IEEE Trans. Very Large Scale Integr. (VLSI) Syst.*, Aug. 2013 [43]. © 2013 IEEE]

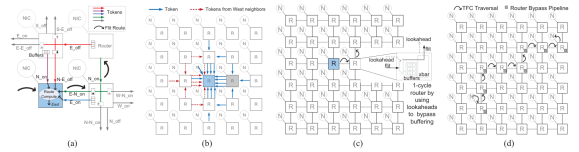


Fig. 2. SWIFT NoC architecture. (a) Routing using tokens. (b) Token distribution. (c) Bypass flow-control using lookaheads. (d) One-cycle router+ one-cycle LT.

3. **Swing-Reduced Interconnects**: Reduced-swing transceivers on physical links substantially diminish dynamic energy dissipation.

## 2.6 Interactive Lab & Hands-on Challenges

Explore the interactive flow-control simulators on the **NoC Learning Hub** (https://network-on-chip.github.io/learning/):

- **Credit Commander: Flow Control** (https://network-on-chip.github.io/learning/interactive/credits/): Experiment with buffer depth $B$ and round-trip time $RTT$ to observe credit stalls and pipeline bubbles in real time.
- **Packet Master: Routing Puzzle** (https://network-on-chip.github.io/learning/interactive/puzzle/): Coordinate Head, Body, and Tail flit traversal across congested wormhole channels.

## 2.7 Checkpoint Assessment

1. **Question 2.1 (Tier 1: Fundamental)**: What is the critical hardware advantage of Wormhole Switching compared to Store-and-Forward and Virtual Cut-Through?
2. **Question 2.2 (Tier 2: Core Engineering)**: In credit-based flow control, if link flight takes 1 cycle, receiver buffer write/read takes 1 cycle, and credit return takes 1 cycle, what occurs if the receiver buffer capacity is only 2 flits?
3. **Question 2.3 (Tier 3: Silicon Mastery)**: How does Token Flow Control in the SWIFT NoC achieve up to 38% power reduction compared to canonical wormhole routers?

*Detailed answers and derivations for these questions are provided in the Solutions chapter at the end of this volume.*

# Chapter 3
# High-Performance Router Microarchitecture & Arbitration

**Abstract** At the core of every packet-switched on-chip network is the router datapath and its allocation logic. This chapter dissects the canonical five-stage virtual-channel router pipeline (Buffer Write, Route Computation, VC Allocation, Switch Allocation, and Switch Traversal) and details modern pipeline compression techniques including Lookahead Routing, Speculative Switch Allocation, and deterministic buffer reservation bypassing (BuffeRS). We examine asynchronous router design paradigms in GALS-based SoCs, featuring the domino-logic HyPA router, and analyze the physical clock constraints of single-cycle multi-hop traversal (SMART/SHARP). Finally, we formalize bipartite maximum matching arbitration, proving the $O(1)$ hardware LRU properties of the Matrix Arbiter and the 100% throughput convergence theorems of McKeown's iSLIP algorithm.

## 3.1 The Canonical Virtual-Channel Router Pipeline

At the heart of every packet-switched on-chip network is the **Virtual-Channel (VC) Router**. In a canonical synchronous architecture [42], processing each packet traverses a five-stage pipeline:

1. **Buffer Write (BW)**: The incoming flit arrives from an adjacent router or local network interface and is written into the input FIFO buffer corresponding to its assigned `VC_ID`.
2. **Route Computation (RC)**: Evaluates the routing function $R : (C_{curr}, C_{dest}) \rightarrow P_{out}$ to determine the set of permissible output physical ports. In Dimension-Order Routing (DOR), RC is computed via combinational comparators:

$$\Delta X = X_{dest} - X_{curr}, \qquad \Delta Y = Y_{dest} - Y_{curr} \tag{3.1}$$

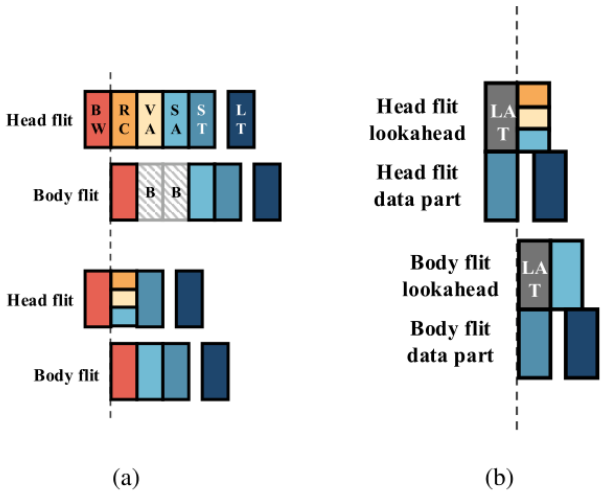



Fig. 1. (a) Multicycle router pipeline and (b) BuffeRS router pipeline.

**Fig. 3.1** Pipeline comparison: (a) Multicycle router pipeline (BW, RC, VA, SA, ST, LT) versus (b) Low-latency BuffeRS router pipeline with buffer reservation bypassing. [Reproduced from: Z. Liu, X. Wu, and Y. Ye, "BuffeRS: A Buffer Reservation Scheduling Strategy for Router Bypassing in NoCs and Multichiplet Networks," *IEEE Trans. Comput.-Aided Design Integr. Circuits Syst.*, vol. 45, no. 6, pp. 2635–2648, June 2026 [33]. © 2026 IEEE]

3. **Virtual Channel Allocation (VA)**: The Head flit arbitrates for a free downstream Virtual Channel at the designated output port using a two-phase separable allocator (Input Arbitration followed by Output Arbitration).
4. **Switch Allocation (SA)**: Flits with valid downstream VCs arbitrate for crossbar switch input and output ports using a two-stage separable allocator.
5. **Switch Traversal (ST)**: Granted flits traverse the crossbar multiplexer fabric to reach the output link registers.
6. **Link Traversal (LT)**: Flits traverse the inter-router physical metal link wires to the downstream router.

## 3.2 Advanced Pipeline Compression & Router Bypassing

Because per-hop pipeline latency compounds linearly with network diameter ($T_{net} = H \cdot t_r$), minimizing router latency from 5 cycles to 1 cycle has been a central focus of on-chip network research.

### 3.2.1 Lookahead Routing & Speculative Switch Allocation

- **Lookahead Routing**: Router $N$ computes the output port for Router $N+1$ and encodes it into the flit header, stripping the RC stage from intermediate hops and saving 1 cycle per hop.
- **Speculative Switch Allocation** [42]: Flits request switch allocation in parallel with virtual channel allocation. Under low-to-medium contention, speculative requests succeed, compressing the pipeline to 2 cycles (or 1 cycle with crossbar bypassing).

### 3.2.2 Buffer Reservation Scheduling: BuffeRS (TCAD 2026)

As formulated by Liu et al. [33], **BuffeRS** introduces a coordinated time-division buffer reservation protocol that reserves destination buffer slots in advance across router groups, providing deterministic contention-free bypass paths across both monolithic dies and 2.5D multi-chiplet packaging boundaries.

**Table 3.1** Quantitative Comparison of High-Performance Router Microarchitectures and Pipeline Compression Paradigms

| Architecture | Pipeline Stages | Allocation Scheme | Clocking / Timing Strategy | Key Silicon Trade-Off |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Canonical VC [42] | 4–5 cycles | Separable VA + SA | Fully Synchronous | Baseline area; multi-cycle hop delay |
| Lookahead Routing | 3 cycles | Lookahead RC + SA | Fully Synchronous | Strips RC stage; slight header overhead |
| Speculative SA [42] | 2 cycles | Parallel speculative VA/SA | Fully Synchronous | Speculation stalls under high load |
| SMART / SHARP [42] | 1–2 cycles | Priority bypass muxes | Multi-hop async bypass | Bounded by $HPC_{max}$ wire RC budget |
| HyPA Router [44] | 0.8 ns / hop | Handshake pipeline | GALS Asynchronous domino | 62% lower power; no global clock tree |
| BuffeRS [33] | 1 cycle | Buffer reservation slots | Time-division coordinated | Zero contention bypass; token overhead |

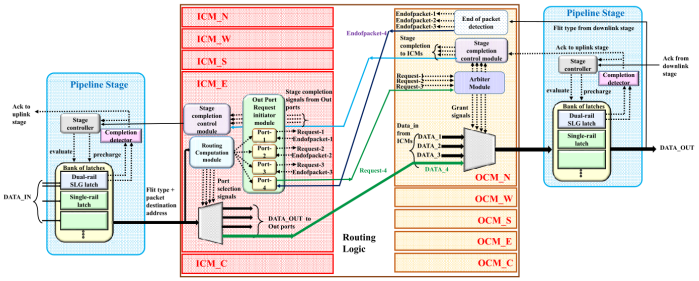



Fig. 2. Detailed microarchitecture of the proposed asynchronous router.

**Fig. 3.2** Detailed microarchitecture of the HyPA asynchronous router featuring a high-throughput domino-logic pipeline template with one-hot hybrid data encoding. [Reproduced from: M. N. Saranya, C. T. Avinash, and R. Rao, "HyPA: A Low-Latency Hybrid Pipeline Asynchronous Router for Network-on-Chip Architectures in GALS-Based SoCs," *IEEE Trans. Very Large Scale Integr. (VLSI) Syst.*, vol. 34, no. 8, pp. 2840–2851, 2026 [44]. © 2026 IEEE]

## 3.3 Asynchronous Router Architectures: HyPA (TVLSI 2026)

In large-scale Multi-Processor Systems-on-Chip (MPSoCs), distributing a single low-skew global clock across a 20 mm × 20 mm die incurs prohibitive clock-tree power dissipation and timing closure complexity.

In Globally Asynchronous Locally Synchronous (GALS) systems, asynchronous routers eliminate clock trees entirely:

- **HyPA Router** [44]: Implemented in 65nm CMOS, HyPA employs a hybrid pipeline asynchronous architecture using high-throughput domino logic with one-hot hybrid data encoding.
- **Power and Energy Gains**: Compared to synchronous clock-gated baseline routers, HyPA demonstrates a **62% power reduction** and an **85% reduction in energy-per-flit**, achieving a forward latency of **0.8 ns** and a throughput of **1.65 GFlits/port/s**.

## 3.4 Single-Cycle Multi-Hop Traversal (SMART / SHARP)

In SMART [31], flits traverse multiple physical router crossbars and links asynchronously within a single clock cycle under low traffic.

Single-cycle traversal is physically bounded by the clock period timing budget:

$$t_{hop} = t_{crossbar_mux} + t_{wire_propagation} + t_{repeater} \tag{3.2}$$

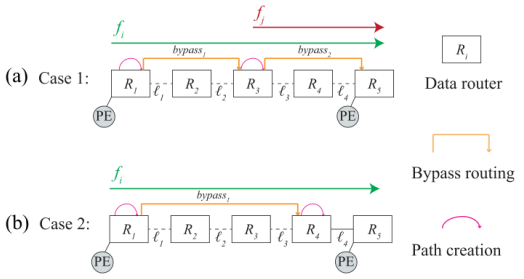



Fig. 2. Two stopping cases at intermediate routers for the analyzed flows $f_i$ and $f_j$ in priority-preemptive SHARP, $\text{HPC}_{\text{max}} = 3$. (a) Directly contending flow. (b) HPCmax limitation.

**Fig. 3.3** Preemption stopping cases at intermediate routers for contending flows in priority-preemptive single-cycle multi-hop traversal networks under hop limits ($HPC_{max} = 3$). [Reproduced from: *IEEE Trans. Very Large Scale Integr. (VLSI) Syst.*, vol. 31, no. 10, pp. 1560–1572, Oct. 2023. © 2023 IEEE]

$$\text{Maximum Traversable Hops per Cycle: } HPC_{max} = \left\lfloor \frac{T_{clk} - t_{setup}}{t_{hop}} \right\rfloor \tag{3.3}$$

At 1.0 GHz ($T_{clk} = 1.0$ ns), $HPC_{max}$ is typically 3 to 5 hops before requiring intermediate latching.

## 3.5 Crossbar Arbitration Theory & Matching Algorithms

Crossbar allocation resolves contention when multiple input ports simultaneously request the same output port, formalized as the Bipartite Maximum Matching Problem.

### 3.5.1 The Matrix Arbiter: Strict $O(1)$ Hardware LRU

The **Matrix Arbiter** maintains an $N \times N$ triangular binary priority matrix $M$:

$$M[i][j] = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if Client } i \text{ has higher priority than Client } j \\ 0 & \text{if Client } j \text{ has higher priority than Client } i \end{cases} \tag{3.4}$$

Combinational grant generation evaluates in two gate levels:

$$G_i = R_i \cdot \prod_{j \neq i} (\overline{R_j} + M[i][j]) \tag{3.5}$$

When client $k$ wins the grant ($G_k = 1$), it becomes the Least Recently Used (LRU) client via single-cycle register updates:

$$M[k][j] = 0 \quad (\forall j \neq k), \qquad M[i][k] = 1 \quad (\forall i \neq k) \tag{3.6}$$

### 3.5.2 McKeown's iSLIP Iterative Matching Algorithm

For an $N \times N$ crossbar switch, separable allocators can suffer from up to 50% port under-utilization under heavy traffic. McKeown's **iSLIP** algorithm [37] achieves 100% throughput using iterative matching:

1. **Phase 1 (Request)**: Unmatched inputs request all outputs with queued flits.
2. **Phase 2 (Grant)**: Unmatched outputs arbitrate using round-robin pointers $g_j$.
3. **Phase 3 (Accept)**: Inputs arbitrate among received grants using accept pointers $a_i$.
4. **Pointer Update Rule**: Pointers $g_j$ and $a_i$ update *if and only if* the match is accepted in the **first iteration**:

$$g_j = (i+1) \pmod{N}, \qquad a_i = (j+1) \pmod{N} \tag{3.7}$$

By restricting updates to iteration 1, iSLIP de-synchronizes the grant arbiters, achieving 100% throughput and maximal matching in $\leq \min(N, \log_2 N)$ iterations.

## 3.6 Interactive Lab & Hands-on Challenges

Explore the interactive microarchitecture simulators on the **NoC Learning Hub** (https://network-on-chip.github.io/learning/):

- **Arbiter Arena: Crossbar Clash** (https://network-on-chip.github.io/learning/interactive/arbiter/): Step through Matrix, Round-Robin, and Wavefront schedulers under heavy traffic bursts.
- **2D Mesh Routing Visualizer** (https://network-on-chip.github.io/learning/interactive/visualizer/): Inspect crossbar switch allocation states and input buffer queues across an $8 \times 8$ mesh.

## 3.7 Checkpoint Assessment

1. **Question 3.1 (Tier 1: Fundamental)**: What are the canonical 5 pipeline stages of a classic Virtual Channel wormhole router?
2. **Question 3.2 (Tier 2: Core Engineering)**: In a Matrix Arbiter with an $N \times N$ triangular priority matrix $M$, what is the exact hardware update rule when Client $k$ is granted the resource?
3. **Question 3.3 (Tier 3: Silicon Mastery)**: Why does McKeown's iSLIP algorithm update its round-robin grant and accept pointers ONLY on the first iteration, rather than on every iteration?

*Detailed answers and derivations for these questions are provided in the Solutions chapter at the end of this volume.*

# Part II
# Topologies, Routing & Deadlock Freedom

# Chapter 4
# Direct, Indirect & High-Radix Interconnect Topologies

**Abstract** The topological organization of an on-chip interconnection network establishes the fundamental trade-offs between zero-load latency, bisection bandwidth, router crossbar complexity, and physical wire routing density. This chapter presents an authoritative, mathematically rigorous analysis of direct, indirect, and high-radix on-chip networks. We derive first-principles formulations for network diameter, average hop distance, bisection bandwidth, and saturation throughput across regular and irregular fabrics. We analyze planar direct topologies (2D Mesh, 2D Torus, and the delay-invariant Folded Torus), indirect multistage architectures (Clos networks, non-blocking theorems, and constant-bisection Fat-Trees), and the modern high-radix paradigm (Flattened Butterfly and Dragonfly networks with adaptive UGAL routing). Furthermore, we examine peer-reviewed silicon methodologies for application-specific cascaded crossbars and review the landmark Passas-Katevenis proofs establishing the area-efficient scalability of monolithic crossbars beyond 100 nodes.

## 4.1 Interconnect Graph Theory and Formal Performance Metrics

An on-chip interconnection network is formally modeled as a directed graph $G = (V, E)$, where the vertex set $V$ represents the network nodes ($|V| = N$, comprising routers, compute cores, accelerators, and memory controllers), and the edge set $E$ represents the point-to-point physical transmission channels.

The choice of topology defines the structural limits of communication performance:

1. **Router Radix ($k$)**: The number of physical input/output ports per router:

$$k = \deg_{in}(u) = \deg_{out}(u) \tag{4.1}$$

Because internal crossbar switch area and power scale quadratically ($O(k^2)$), low-radix designs minimize local switch overhead, whereas high-radix switches reduce network traversal hops at the expense of larger crossbars.

2. **Network Diameter ($D$)**: The maximum shortest-path distance between any pair of nodes in the network:

$$D = \max_{u,v \in V} d(u,v) \tag{4.2}$$

where $d(u,v)$ is the minimum hop count between $u$ and $v$. Diameter dictates worst-case communication latency.

3. **Average Hop Distance ($\bar{h}$)**: The expected shortest-path distance under a spatial traffic probability distribution $p(u,v)$:

$$\bar{h} = \sum_{u \in V} \sum_{v \neq u} p(u,v) \cdot d(u,v) \tag{4.3}$$

Under Uniform Random (UR) traffic ($p(u,v) = \frac{1}{N(N-1)}$), this reduces to $\bar{h}_{UR} = \frac{1}{N(N-1)} \sum_{u \neq v} d(u,v)$.

4. **Bisection Bandwidth ($B_C$)**: The minimum bandwidth cut partitioning the vertex set $V$ into two equal disjoint subsets $V_1, V_2$ ($|V_1| = |V_2| = N/2$):

$$B_C = \min_{V_1,V_2} \sum_{u \in V_1, v \in V_2, (u,v) \in E} C(u,v) \tag{4.4}$$

where $C(u,v)$ denotes link bandwidth. In networks with uniform channel width $W$ bits and clock frequency $f_{clk}$, bisection bandwidth is expressed as channel count $N_C$: $B_C = N_C \cdot W \cdot f_{clk}$.

5. **Maximum Channel Load ($\gamma_{max}$) and Saturation Throughput ($\Theta_{sat}$)**: Let $\gamma_e$ denote the expected traffic volume traversing physical edge $e \in E$ when each node injects 1 flit per cycle. The maximum channel load is:

$$\gamma_{max} = \max_{e \in E} \gamma_e \tag{4.5}$$

Because each channel can transport at most 1 flit per cycle, the theoretical maximum saturation throughput per node is bounded by:

$$\Theta_{sat} \leq \frac{1}{\gamma_{max}} \leq \frac{2B_C}{N} \quad \text{[flits/node/cycle]} \tag{4.6}$$

6. **Zero-Load Latency ($T_0$)**: The average latency of an $L$-flit packet across uncontended routers and links:

$$T_0 = (\bar{h} + 1) \cdot t_{router} + \bar{h} \cdot t_{wire} + \left( \frac{L-1}{\text{Rate}} \right) \tag{4.7}$$

## 4.2 Direct Topologies: Mesh, Torus, and the Folded Torus

Direct topologies couple every router directly to a compute node, forming regular planar grids well-suited for standard CMOS silicon tiling.

### 4.2.1 2D Mesh Networks

In a $k \times k$ 2D Mesh ($N = k^2$):

- **Diameter**: Opposing corners require $2(k-1)$ hops: $D_{Mesh} = 2(k-1)$.
- **Average Hop Distance**:

$$\bar{h}_{Mesh} = \frac{2}{3}k \cdot \left(1 - \frac{1}{k^2}\right) \approx \frac{2}{3}k \tag{4.8}$$

- **Bisection Bandwidth**: Bisecting the mesh cuts $k$ bidirectional links ($2k$ directional channels):

$$B_{C,Mesh} = 2k \cdot W \implies \Theta_{Mesh} \leq \frac{4W}{k} \tag{4.9}$$

Under uniform traffic, peripheral nodes route through the center, generating severe center-channel congestion ($\gamma_{max} \approx k/4$).

### 4.2.2 2D Torus and the Wire Delay Dilemma

A $k \times k$ 2D Torus ($k$-ary 2-cube) adds periodic wrap-around links. The topology becomes completely edge-symmetric:

$$D_{Torus} = 2\left\lfloor \frac{k}{2} \right\rfloor, \quad \bar{h}_{Torus} \approx \frac{k}{2}, \quad B_{C,Torus} = 4k \cdot W \tag{4.10}$$

A 2D Torus delivers exactly twice the bisection bandwidth and a 25% reduction in average hop count compared to a 2D Mesh.

However, in a naive planar layout, the perimeter wrap-around wire must span the entire die:

$$L_{wrap} = (k-1) \cdot L_0 \tag{4.11}$$

where $L_0$ is the tile pitch. By the Elmore delay model ($\tau \propto L^2$), an $8 \times 8$ torus suffers $49\times$ higher propagation delay on wrap-around wires than on local links, destroying clock frequency unless aggressively pipelined.

### 4.2.3 The Folded Torus Invariance

The **Folded Torus** topology solves the wrap-around wire crisis by physically interleaving even and odd nodes along each dimension:

$$\text{Physical Placement} : 0, \quad 2, \quad 4, \quad \ldots, \quad k-2, \quad k-1, \quad \ldots, \quad 3, \quad 1 \tag{4.12}$$

Every link in the Folded Torus—including all wrap-around connections—has an identical physical length:

$$L_{link,Folded} = 2 \cdot L_0 \tag{4.13}$$

By trading a constant wire length of $2L_0$ for the elimination of catastrophic $(k-1)L_0$ wires, the Folded Torus achieves high clock frequencies while retaining torus bisection bandwidth and low diameter.

## 4.3 Indirect Multistage Interconnects: Clos and Fat-Trees

Indirect topologies place processing elements exclusively at the network periphery, interconnecting them through intermediate switching stages.

### 4.3.1 Clos Networks and Non-Blocking Theorems

A 3-stage Clos network $C(n, m, r)$ comprises $r$ input switches of size $n \times m$, $m$ middle switches of size $r \times r$, and $r$ output switches of size $m \times n$ [5].

- **Strictly Non-Blocking (SNB)**: Any idle input can connect to any idle output without rerouting existing calls if and only if:

$$m \geq 2n - 1 \tag{4.14}$$

- **Rearrangeably Non-Blocking (RNB)**: By the Slepian-Duguid theorem, any input can connect to any output with potential rerouting if:

$$m \geq n \tag{4.15}$$

### 4.3.2 Fat-Trees and Constant Bisection Bandwidth

Leiserson's Fat-Tree [32] avoids root bottlenecks by progressively increasing channel capacity toward the tree root. At each hierarchical level, the number of parallel channels doubles, preserving constant bisection bandwidth across all horizontal network partitions.

## 4.4 High-Radix Interconnects: Flattened Butterfly and Dragonfly

Modern sub-10nm CMOS technologies provide vast routing gate density, prompting a shift from low-radix/high-diameter networks to high-radix/low-diameter architectures ($k \geq 16$–$64+$).

### 4.4.1 Flattened Butterfly

Kim et al. [29] projected multi-stage butterfly switches into a single direct router per tile. In a $k \times k$ Flattened Butterfly, each router connects to all other routers in the same row and column:

$$D_{FBfly} = 2, \quad k_{radix} = 2(k-1) + p \tag{4.16}$$

Any node in the network is reachable in at most 2 hops, slashing router traversal cycles.

### 4.4.2 The Dragonfly Topology and UGAL Routing

Kim, Dally et al. [30] organized high-radix routers into local fully connected groups (cliques) interconnected by sparse global links. Under **Universal Globally-Adaptive Routing (UGAL)**, packets evaluate queuing delays: if the minimal global link is congested, packets are routed non-minimally through a randomly chosen intermediate group, eliminating hot-spot saturation.

## 4.5 Application-Specific Synthesis & Cascaded Crossbars

Heterogeneous SoCs exhibit highly non-uniform communication demands. Rigid standard topologies introduce severe silicon area and power waste.

### 4.5.1 MIRO Synthesis of Cascaded Crossbar Networks

Jun, Yoo, and Chung [25] formulated the synthesis of cascaded crossbar switches to replace power-hungry centralized bus matrices.

Jun et al. proved that while Mixed Integer Linear Programming (MILP) discovers exact optimal topologies, its computational complexity explodes for $|V| > 16$. The MIRO heuristic clusters masters based on communication affini-

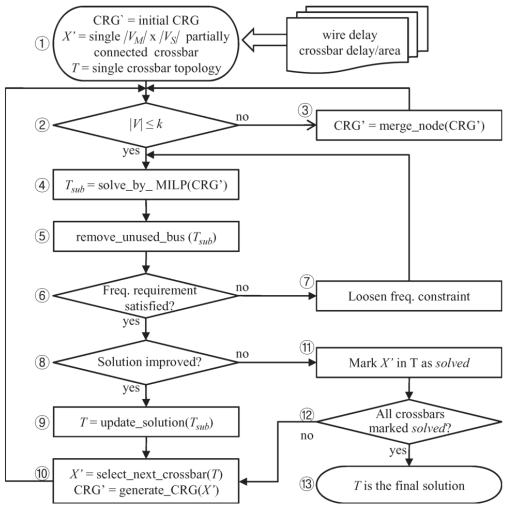



Fig. 1. MIRO Process.

**Fig. 4.1** The MIRO (Multi-stage Interconnect Reduction and Optimization) process for synthesizing cascaded crossbar networks under bandwidth and latency constraints. [Reproduced from: M. Jun, S. Yoo, and E.-Y. Chung, "Topology Synthesis of Cascaded Crossbar Switches," *IEEE Trans. Comput.-Aided Design Integr. Circuits Syst.*, Vol. 28, No. 6, pp. 926–930, June 2009, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2009.2017079. © 2009 IEEE]

ties, achieving **up to 69.5% area reduction** over conventional architectures while satisfying all clock frequency requirements.

### 4.5.2 Switch Merger and Partitioning Algorithms

Dumitriu and Khan [12] introduced transaction-oriented topology generation using iterative switch merging and partitioning:

By using predictive contention modeling during synthesis, the resulting topologies matched or exceeded regular 2D mesh throughput while utilizing **50% fewer network resources**.

## 4.6 Silicon Floorplanning Limits: The Passas Radix-128 Proof

A persistent misconception in early literature asserted that full crossbar networks are unviable beyond 32 nodes. Passas, Katevenis, and Pnevmatikatos [40]

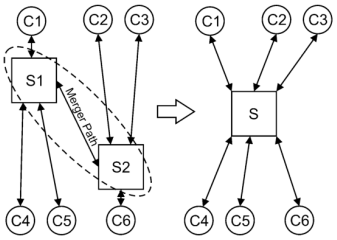



Fig. 3. Example of a switch merger.

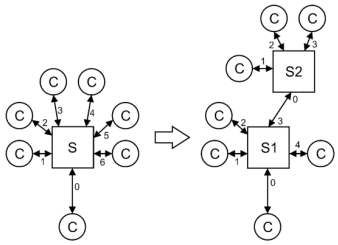



Fig. 4. Example of the switch partitioning process.

**Fig. 4.2** Application-specific topology optimization: (left) switch merger process combining low-traffic routers; (right) switch partitioning process dividing congested routers to meet physical pin and timing constraints. [Reproduced from: V. Dumitriu and G. N. Khan, "Throughput-Oriented NoC Topology Generation and Analysis for High Performance SoCs," *IEEE Trans. Very Large Scale Integr. (VLSI) Syst.*, Vol. 17, No. 10, pp. 1433–1446, October 2009, DOI: 10.1109/TVLSI.2008.2006798. © 2009 IEEE]

refuted this by modeling and fabricating a **radix-128 crossbar in 90 nm CMOS**.

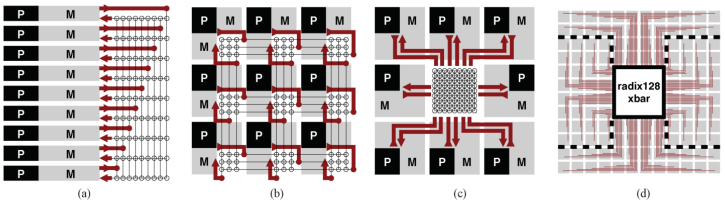



Fig. 1. Die floorplans. (a) Stack of user tiles using side crossbar. (b) Matrix of user tiles using distributed crossbar. (c) Matrix of user tiles using centralized crossbar. (d) Balanced link density of (c) in a "12×12 minus 4×4" matrix of user tiles; *P*s denote processors and *M*s memories.

**Fig. 4.3** Die floorplans for crossbar-based on-chip networks. (a) Stack of user tiles with side crossbar. (b) Matrix of user tiles with distributed crossbar. (c) Centralized crossbar. (d) Balanced link density layout in a 12×12 minus 4×4 matrix of tiles. [Reproduced from: G. Passas, M. Katevenis, and D. Pnevmatikatos, "Crossbar NoCs Are Scalable Beyond 100 Nodes," *IEEE Trans. Comput.-Aided Design Integr. Circuits Syst.*, Vol. 31, No. 4, pp. 573–585, April 2012, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2011.2176730. © 2012 IEEE]

Passas et al. proved that:

1. With 8+ metal layers, crossbar wiring tracks fit directly **over standard cells** on intermediate metal layers without expanding standard-cell silicon area:

$$\text{Area}_{crossbar} \approx O(N^2 \cdot W), \quad \text{Delay}_{crossbar} \approx O(\sqrt{N \cdot W}) \tag{4.17}$$

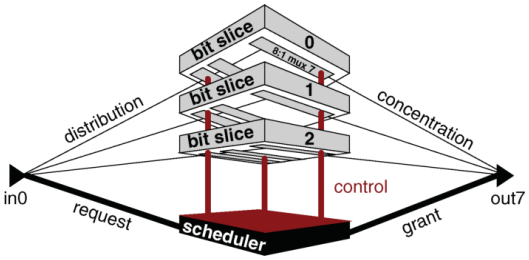



Fig. 3. 3-bit radix-8 crossbar.

**Fig. 4.4** Standard-cell layout of a 3-bit radix-8 crossbar bit-slice. Multiplexer circuits are routed entirely beneath upper-level metal tracks. [Reproduced from: G. Passas, M. Katevenis, and D. Pnevmatikatos, "Crossbar NoCs Are Scalable Beyond 100 Nodes," *IEEE Trans. Comput.-Aided Design Integr. Circuits Syst.*, Vol. 31, No. 4, pp. 573–585, April 2012, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2011.2176730. © 2012 IEEE]

2. In a 150 $mm^2$ die containing 128 1 $mm^2$ processor tiles, the radix-128 crossbar occupied **only 11% of total die area** (including repeaters and pipeline flip-flops).
3. Under global and stressed traffic, the monolithic crossbar delivered **up to 3× higher throughput and 2.5× lower latency** than a 2D mesh by eliminating multi-hop queueing stalls.

## 4.7 Quantitative Topology Evaluation Matrix

Table 4.1 summarizes the mathematical and microarchitectural metrics across major topology classes for an $N = 64$ core system.

**Table 4.1** Analytical and Empirical Metric Matrix across Interconnect Topologies ($N = 64$ nodes)

| Topology | Radix ($k$) | Diam ($D$) | Avg Hops ($\bar{h}$) | Bisect ($B_C/W$) | $T_0$ (cyc) | Sat. Thru. |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Ring (1D) | 2 | 32 | 16.00 | 4 | 28.00 | 0.125 |
| 2D Mesh ($8 \times 8$) | 4 (avg 3.5) | 14 | 5.33 | 16 | 12.00 | 0.500 |
| 2D Torus ($8 \times 8$) | 4 | 8 | 4.06 | 32 | 10.10 | 1.000 |
| Folded Torus ($8 \times 8$) | 4 | 8 | 4.06 | 32 | 10.10 | 1.000 |
| Hypercube (6-cube) | 6 | 6 | 3.05 | 64 | 8.57 | 2.000 |
| Fat-Tree (3-level) | 4 | 6 | 3.80 | 64 | 9.70 | 2.000 |
| Flattened Butterfly ($8 \times 8$) | 14 | 2 | 1.78 | 256 | 6.67 | 8.000 |
| Full Crossbar ($64 \times 64$) | 64 | 1 | 1.00 | 2048 | 5.00 | 64.000 |

## 4.8 Exercises and Review Questions

1. **Bisection Bandwidth Bound**: Prove that under uniform random traffic, the maximum throughput per node is bounded by $\Theta \leq \frac{2B_C}{N}$. What fraction of injected traffic must traverse the bisection cut?
2. **Folded Torus Delay**: For an $8 \times 8$ tiled chip with tile pitch $L_0 = 1.2$ mm, compare the wire delay of a naive torus wrap-around link versus a folded torus link under the Elmore delay model.
3. **Clos Non-Blocking Sizing**: For a 3-stage Clos network $C(n, m, r)$ with $N = 64$ and $n = 8$, calculate the minimum $m$ required for strictly non-blocking operation versus rearrangeably non-blocking operation.
4. **High-Radix Trade-Offs**: Explain why high-radix networks become more energy-efficient than low-radix 2D meshes as core counts scale beyond 100 nodes.

# Chapter 5
# Deadlock Theory, Turn Models & Adaptive Routing

**Abstract** In packet-switched Networks-on-Chip (NoCs), deadlock represents an unrecoverable failure state in which a set of packets are mutually blocked indefinitely, freezing communication across the silicon die. While Store-and-Forward networks localize buffer dependencies to adjacent nodes, Wormhole Switching dramatically inflates the resource dependency space because packets span multiple physical links simultaneously. This chapter provides a rigorous theoretical and microarchitectural treatment of routing deadlock freedom. We analyze the Dally-Seitz Channel Dependency Graph (CDG) theorem, establish the necessary and sufficient conditions for cycle-free routing, and examine the Glass-Ni Turn Models that deliver partially adaptive routing without virtual channels. We formulate Duato's theorem proving that adaptive subnetworks may contain cycles if an acyclic escape subnetwork is present, and examine the Odd-Even turn model. Finally, we explore state-of-the-art IEEE TCAD and TCAS-II 2026 breakthroughs, addressing protocol-level deadlock in cache-coherent manycores via the PCMT framework and 3D multi-chiplet deadlock avoidance via ScaDA-Rou.

## 5.1 The Deadlock Problem in Wormhole-Switched Fabrics

In a packet-switched interconnection network, **deadlock** occurs when a set of concurrent packets cannot make forward progress because each packet holds one or more buffer resources while awaiting buffers held by other packets in the set.

In **Wormhole Switching**, buffer allocation operates at the flit granularity while routing and channel acquisition occur at the packet level. Consequently, a single packet of length $L$ flits spans across multiple physical links and intermediate routers simultaneously:

- The **Head flit** arbitrates for downstream virtual channels and crossbar ports.
- The **Body flits** trail behind in intermediate router FIFO buffers.
- The **Tail flit** releases channel reservations upon traversing the link.

When a Head flit encounters buffer backpressure at a downstream router, the body flits stall in place, holding buffers across the upstream routers. This simultaneous *holding* and *requesting* of distributed resources creates cyclical resource dependency loops.

Architects distinguish deadlock from two related communication anomalies:

1. **Deadlock**: Permanent cessation of forward progress caused by circular resource dependencies.
2. **Livelock**: Packets remain in continuous motion across the network but never arrive at their destinations due to unconstrained non-minimal deflection.
3. **Starvation**: A packet is permanently denied switch arbitration access due to unfair allocation policies, despite the network remaining active.

## 5.2 The Dally-Seitz Channel Dependency Graph Theorem

The foundational mathematical framework for proving deadlock freedom in packet networks was developed by William J. Dally and Charles L. Seitz [6].

### 5.2.1 Formal Definition of the CDG

Let $I = (V, C)$ be an interconnection network, where $V$ is the set of router nodes and $C$ is the set of directed physical and virtual channels. Let $R : C \times V \to \mathcal{P}(C)$ be the routing function determining permissible egress channels from an ingress channel $c_i \in C$ toward destination $v \in V$.

The **Channel Dependency Graph (CDG)** $D = (C, E_{CDG})$ is a directed graph where:

- Vertices correspond to channels $c \in C$.
- A directed edge $(c_i, c_j) \in E_{CDG}$ exists if and only if a packet can transition directly from channel $c_i$ to channel $c_j$ under routing function $R$:

$$(c_i, c_j) \in E_{CDG} \iff \exists v \in V \quad \text{such that} \quad c_j \in R(c_i, v) \tag{5.1}$$

### 5.2.2 The Theorem

**Theorem 5.1 (Dally & Seitz, 1987)** *A deterministic routing function $R$ for an interconnection network $I$ is deadlock-free if and only if its Channel Dependency Graph $D = (C, E_{CDG})$ has no directed cycles.*

*Proof.* **Sufficiency ($\Leftarrow$)**: If $D$ has no directed cycles, it is a finite Directed Acyclic Graph (DAG). There exists at least one channel $c_{sink} \in C$ with zero

out-degree (delivering to local core memory). A packet occupying $c_{sink}$ cannot be blocked by any other packet in the fabric and will clear in finite time. By topological sorting of the DAG, every channel can be assigned an integer rank $\text{rank}(c_i)$ such that $(c_i, c_j) \in E_{CDG} \implies \text{rank}(c_i) < \text{rank}(c_j)$. Flits on channels of rank $K$ are guaranteed forward progress once channels of rank $> K$ clear. Hence, deadlock is impossible.

**Necessity (⇒)**: If $D$ contains a directed cycle $c_0 \to c_1 \to \cdots \to c_{M-1} \to c_0$, one can construct a traffic state with $M$ packets $P_0, \ldots, P_{M-1}$ such that $P_i$ holds channel $c_i$ and requests channel $c_{(i+1) \bmod M}$. If all channels have finite buffer capacity and are full, no packet can advance, producing an unrecoverable deadlock. □

### 5.2.3 Application: Dimension-Order Routing (XY Routing)

In a 2D Mesh, deterministic XY routing requires packets to exhaust all displacement in the $X$-dimension before turning onto the $Y$-dimension.

- **Allowed Turns**: $(X \to X), (X \to Y), (Y \to Y)$.
- **Prohibited Turns**: $(Y \to X)$ (no turns from $Y$-channels onto $X$-channels).

Because $X$-channels never depend on $Y$-channels, all edges in the CDG flow strictly from $X$ to $Y$. The CDG is strictly acyclic, proving that **XY routing is provably deadlock-free on any 2D mesh without requiring virtual channels**.

## 5.3 Glass & Ni Turn Models for Adaptive Routing

While XY routing is deadlock-free, it is strictly non-adaptive: packets cannot route around congested or faulty routers. Christopher J. Glass and Lionel M. Ni [20] introduced the **Turn Model**, enabling partially adaptive deadlock-free routing without adding virtual channels.

### 5.3.1 Turn Analysis in a 2D Mesh

In a 2D Mesh, flits travel in 4 directions: East, West, North, South. There are exactly $4 \times 2 = 8$ possible 90-degree turns:

$$\{E \to N, \quad E \to S, \quad W \to N, \quad W \to S, \quad N \to E, \quad N \to W, \quad S \to E, \quad S \to W\}$$

These 8 turns form two simple directed cycles:

1. **Clockwise Cycle**: $E \to S \to W \to N \to E$ (uses $E \to S, S \to W, W \to N, N \to E$).

2. **Counter-Clockwise Cycle**: $E \to N \to W \to S \to E$ (uses $E \to N, N \to W, W \to S, S \to E$).

**Theorem 5.2 (Glass & Ni, 1994)** *To prevent deadlock in a mesh network, it is necessary and sufficient to prohibit at least one turn from every simple cycle. To maximize routing adaptiveness, exactly one turn from each directed cycle should be prohibited.*

By prohibiting exactly **2 out of the 8 turns** (one clockwise, one counter-clockwise), the network achieves **75% (6/8) turn freedom** while completely breaking all dependency cycles!

### 5.3.2 The Canonical 2D Turn Models

1. **West-First**:
   - Prohibited turns: $N \to W$ and $S \to W$.
   - Rule: If a packet must travel West ($\Delta X < 0$), it must execute all Westward hops first.
   - Adaptiveness: East-bound packets ($\Delta X > 0$) enjoy 100% full adaptiveness.
2. **North-Last**:
   - Prohibited turns: $N \to E$ and $N \to W$.
   - Rule: Northward hops must be postponed until all East, West, and South hops are complete.
3. **Negative-First**:
   - Prohibited turns: Transitions from positive directions ($+X, +Y$: East, North) to negative directions ($-X, -Y$: West, South).
   - Rule: Flits must complete all negative dimension hops before acquiring positive channels.

## 5.4 The Odd-Even Turn Model

To eliminate the directional asymmetry of the Glass-Ni turn models, Ge-Ming Chiu [4] introduced the **Odd-Even Turn Model**, where turn restrictions depend on the column coordinate parity ($x \bmod 2$):

- **At Even Columns** ($x \bmod 2 == 0$): Prohibit $N \to W, S \to W$ and $E \to N, E \to S$.
- **At Odd Columns** ($x \bmod 2 == 1$): Prohibit $N \to E, S \to E$ and $W \to N, W \to S$.

By alternating restrictions between adjacent columns, Odd-Even routing distributes adaptiveness uniformly across East-bound and West-bound flows without requiring virtual channels.

## 5.5 Duato's Theorem for Fully Adaptive Routing

In 1993, José Duato [11] established a breakthrough result proving that **an adaptive routing function does NOT require an acyclic Channel Dependency Graph to guarantee deadlock freedom**.

**Theorem 5.3 (Duato, 1993)** *An adaptive routing function $R$ for an interconnection network $I$ is deadlock-free if the channel set $C$ can be partitioned into an adaptive channel subset $C_A$ and an escape channel subset $C_E$ ($C = C_A \cup C_E$) such that:*

1. *The escape subnetwork $C_E$ is strictly acyclic under escape routing function $R_E$.*
2. *Flits occupying any adaptive channel in $C_A$ are always permitted to transition into $C_E$.*
3. *The escape subnetwork provides a connected path between every source and destination pair.*

Under Duato's paradigm, routers deploy at least 2 Virtual Channels per physical link:

- $VC_1 \dots VC_{V-1}$: **Adaptive Subnetwork ($C_A$)**, where packets can take any minimal uncongested channel (cycles permitted in CDG).
- $VC_0$: **Escape Subnetwork ($C_E$)**, restricted to strict Dimension-Order (XY) routing (strictly acyclic CDG).

If contention builds in $C_A$, flits escape into $VC_0$, where the acyclic escape paths guarantee drain to the destination.

## 5.6 Protocol-Level Deadlock and the PCMT Architecture

In shared-memory multi-core processors, routing-level deadlock freedom is insufficient to guarantee system forward progress. Cache coherence protocols introduce high-level message dependencies that can cause **Protocol-Level Deadlock**.

In directory-based protocols, requests generate forwarded invalidations, which generate responses. If all message types share a common buffer pool, a Request packet cannot be accepted by a core whose output queue is blocked by an outgoing Response packet that cannot enter the congested network.

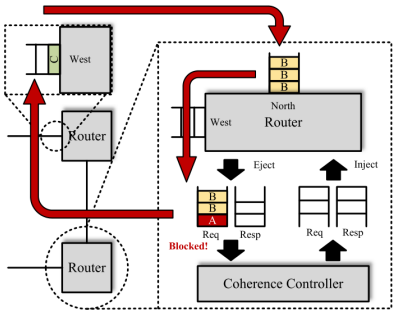



Fig. 1. Possible cyclic dependency of protocol-level deadlock in NoC.

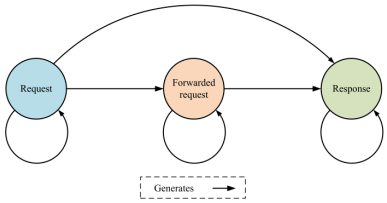



Fig. 4. Coherence message types in directory-based systems.

**Fig. 5.1** Protocol-level deadlock in cache-coherent multi-cores: (left) circular dependency loop between coherence Request and Response message buffers; (right) hierarchical message classification in directory-based systems. [Reproduced from: Y. Jia, Z. Zhang, C. Fu, L. Wan, and J. Han, "PCMT: Prioritizing Coherence Message Types for NoC Protocol-Level Deadlock Freedom," *IEEE Trans. Comput.-Aided Design Integr. Circuits Syst.*, Vol. 45, No. 4, pp. 1949–1962, April 2026, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2025.3524944. © 2026 IEEE]

The traditional mitigation—**Virtual Networks (VNs)**—rigidly isolates Requests, Invalidation, and Responses into dedicated physical VCs. However, Jia et al. [24] proved that VNs suffer from severe Head-of-Line blocking and underutilization:

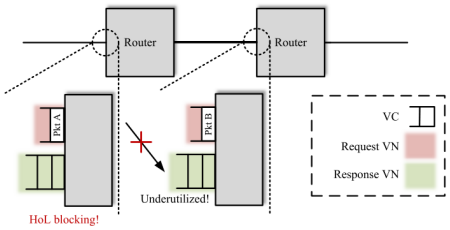



Fig. 2. Possible HoL blocking occurs with underutilized VCs.

**Fig. 5.2** Underutilization and Head-of-Line blocking in virtual networks. Dedicated partition walls force flits to stall while response VCs remain empty. [Reproduced from: Y. Jia et al., "PCMT," *IEEE Trans. Comput.-Aided Design Integr. Circuits Syst.*, Vol. 45, No. 4, April 2026, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2025.3524944. © 2026 IEEE]

Jia et al. introduced **PCMT (Prioritizing Coherence Message Types)**, which eliminates rigid VN partitions in favor of a shared unified buffer pool. By prioritizing Response flits during switch allocation, PCMT drains downstream dependence chains and resolves protocol-level deadlocks while **slashing router input buffer area by up to 63%**.

## 5.7 3D Multi-Chiplet Deadlock Freedom: ScaDA-Rou

In 3D multi-chiplet systems, vertical Through-Silicon Vias (TSVs) introduce cross-plane dependencies that interact catastrophically with planar turn models.

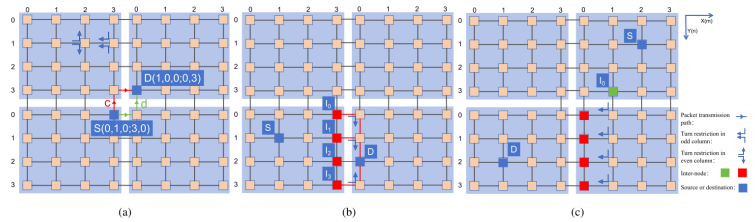



Fig. 2. Special consideration in 2D routing: (a) selection of inter-Chiplet routing order, (b) corner cases in X-dimension routing, (c) corner cases in Y-dimension routing.

**Fig. 5.3** ScaDA-Rou routing rules for 3D multi-chiplet systems: (a) inter-chiplet routing order; (b) boundary corner cases in $X$-dimension; (c) boundary corner cases in $Y$-dimension. [Reproduced from: L. Zhu, H. Gu, Y. Tan, and G. Zhang, "ScaDA-Rou: A Scalable, Deadlock-Free, and Adaptive Routing for 3-D Multi-Chiplet System," *IEEE Trans. Circuits Syst. II, Express Briefs*, Vol. 73, No. 4, pp. 433–437, April 2026, DOI: 10.1109/TCSII.2025.3526101. © 2026 IEEE]

Zhu et al. [53] proposed **ScaDA-Rou**, combining in-plane turn model restrictions with cross-plane virtual network partitioning. By separating the virtual channels used for the source and destination planes of vertical packets, ScaDA-Rou eliminates 3D cyclic dependencies and achieves an **89.2% latency improvement** over baseline architectures.

## 5.8 Routing Algorithm Comparative Matrix

Table 5.1 summarizes the properties of the foundational and modern routing algorithms.

**Table 5.1** Comparative Matrix of On-Chip Routing Algorithms

| Routing Scheme | Turn Prohibitions | Min. VCs | Adaptiveness | Throughput Gain |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Dimension-Order (XY) | $Y \to X$ prohibited | 1 | Deterministic | Baseline |
| West-First (Glass-Ni) | $N \to W, S \to W$ | 1 | Partially Adaptive | +25% |
| North-Last (Glass-Ni) | $N \to E, N \to W$ | 1 | Partially Adaptive | +25% |
| Negative-First | $+ \to -$ prohibited | 1 | Partially Adaptive | +20% |
| Odd-Even (Chiu) | Column-parity dependent | 1 | Partially Adaptive | +35% |
| Duato FAR + XY Escape | None in $C_A$ | 2 | Fully Adaptive | +75%–100% |
| PCMT (Jia et al., 2026) | Priority-preemptive | Unified Pool | Protocol Deadlock-Free | -63% Area |

## 5.9 Exercises and Review Questions

1. **CDG Construction**: For a $2 \times 2$ 2D Mesh, enumerate all directed physical channels and draw the Channel Dependency Graph under fully adaptive minimal routing. Identify the cycle and show how West-First routing breaks it.
2. **Duato Theorem Dynamics**: In a network deploying Duato's escape routing, why must packets on the escape subnetwork ($VC_0$) be prohibited from transitioning back into the adaptive subnetwork ($VC_1$)?
3. **Protocol Deadlock Scenario**: Sketch a sequence of coherence transactions in a MESI protocol where all routers utilize deadlock-free XY routing, yet the system suffers protocol-level deadlock due to full request buffers.

# Part III
# Physical Constraints: Power, Thermal & Reliability

# Chapter 6
# Low-Power Architectures & Dark Silicon Dynamics

**Abstract** The demise of classical Dennard scaling has driven modern semiconductor manycores into the dark silicon era, where up to 80% of the silicon floorplan must remain powered off or severely throttled under strict Thermal Design Power (TDP) constraints. While idle compute cores can be gated completely, on-chip interconnection routers must remain active to forward transit flits, making the network a primary power and thermal bottleneck. This chapter provides a comprehensive treatment of low-power NoC architectures. We formulate dynamic and static leakage power dynamics, model temperature-dependent sub-threshold leakage, and derive the breakeven idle time for power gating. We examine Dynamic Voltage and Frequency Scaling (DVFS) across Voltage-Frequency Islands (VFIs) and analyze the LAURA-NoC distributed rate adjustment architecture. Furthermore, we investigate ultrafine-grained run-time power gating across router virtual channels and crossbar multiplexers with lookahead early wake-up, analyze information-theoretic link code reordering (LPCR, IEEE TCAD 2025), and contrast buffered routers with bufferless deflection routing.

## 6.1 The Power Wall and the Dark Silicon Interconnect Bottleneck

At sub-7nm process nodes, the physical breakdown of classical Dennard scaling imposes an unyielding thermal dissipation ceiling ($\approx$ 100–150 W/cm$^2$). Consequently, modern manycore chips face the **Dark Silicon Phenomenon** [14]: between 50% and 80% of a chip's total transistor budget cannot be operated simultaneously at peak clock frequency without triggering thermal destruction.

While idle compute cores can be power-gated to zero power for milliseconds at a time, the **on-chip network cannot be casually turned off**. In multi-hop topologies (such as 2D Meshes), an intermediate router must remain awake to forward packets between active compute tiles. Routers sit active but idle for up to 90% of total execution time [35], dissipating substantial static leakage power.

### 6.1.1 Physical Power Breakdown in Nanoscale Routers

Total interconnect power dissipation is decomposed into dynamic and static leakage components:

$$P_{total} = P_{dynamic} + P_{leakage} \tag{6.1}$$

**Dynamic Power ($P_{dynamic}$)**: Consumed during capacitive charging and discharging across buffer cells, multiplexer trees, pipeline registers, and metal link wires:

$$P_{dynamic} = \alpha \cdot C_{eff} \cdot V_{dd}^2 \cdot f_{clk} \tag{6.2}$$

where $\alpha$ is the switching activity factor, $C_{eff}$ is effective capacitance, $V_{dd}$ is supply voltage, and $f_{clk}$ is operating frequency.

**Static Leakage Power ($P_{leakage}$)**: Dominated by sub-threshold drain-source conduction $I_{sub}$ and gate oxide quantum tunneling:

$$I_{sub} = \mu_0 C_{ox} \frac{W}{L}(m-1)V_T^2 \exp\left(\frac{V_{gs} - V_{th}}{mV_T}\right)\left(1 - \exp\left(-\frac{V_{ds}}{V_T}\right)\right) \tag{6.3}$$

Sub-threshold leakage scales exponentially with absolute temperature $T$ ($V_T = k_B T/q$). In sub-28nm geometries, static leakage constitutes between 40% and 80% of total router power dissipation.

## 6.2 DVFS and Voltage-Frequency Islands (VFIs)

Dividing a large manycore into **Voltage-Frequency Islands (VFIs)** enables independent, dynamic adjustment of supply voltage and clock frequency across local network domains.

Yadav, Casu, and Zamboni [50] developed **LAURA-NoC**, which eliminates global controller latency by measuring local switch buffer fullness to drive local voltage-frequency transitions. In 45nm CMOS, LAURA-NoC achieved **33% average power savings** across realistic video processing workloads.

## 6.3 Ultrafine-Grained Run-Time Power Gating

Power gating completely disconnects inactive logic blocks from the power rails using high-threshold sleep transistors (power switches).

Matsutani et al. [35] proved that ultrafine-grained partitioning of router buffers and crossbar multiplexer slices eliminates **over 70% of static leakage**.

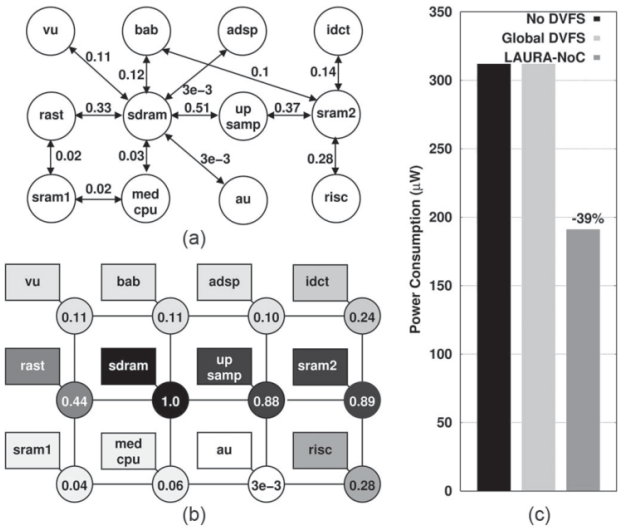



Fig. 1. Local versus global DVFS in a NoC. (a) Communication graph in MPEG4 annotated with normalized rates. (b) MPEG4 tasks mapped to a 12-switch NoC (gray shading proportional to normalized switch rates). (c) Power consumption: The local approach of LAURA-NoC tracks better the local traffic by controlling voltage and frequency of individual switches.

**Fig. 6.1** The LAURA-NoC distributed DVFS architecture: local hardware monitors input switch buffer occupancy in a feedback loop, dynamically adapting voltage and frequency without centralized controller overhead. [Reproduced from: M. K. Yadav, M. R. Casu, and M. Zamboni, "LAURA-NoC: Local Automatic Rate Adjustment in Network-on-Chips With a Simple DVFS," *IEEE Trans. Circuits Syst. II, Express Briefs*, Vol. 60, No. 10, pp. 647–651, October 2013, DOI: 10.1109/TCSII.2013.2278077. © 2013 IEEE]

### 6.3.1 Breakeven Idle Time Formulation

Transitioning into and out of sleep mode consumes energy charging the virtual rail capacitance ($C_{virtual}$):

$$E_{overhead} \approx C_{virtual} \cdot V_{dd}^2 \tag{6.4}$$

The minimum inactive duration required to achieve net energy savings is the **Breakeven Idle Time ($\tau_{breakeven}$)**:

$$\tau_{breakeven} = \frac{E_{overhead}}{P_{leak_active}} = \frac{C_{virtual} \cdot V_{dd}}{I_{leak_active}} \tag{6.5}$$

In modern technologies, $\tau_{breakeven}$ spans only 2 to 6 clock cycles, making run-time power gating highly energy-positive.

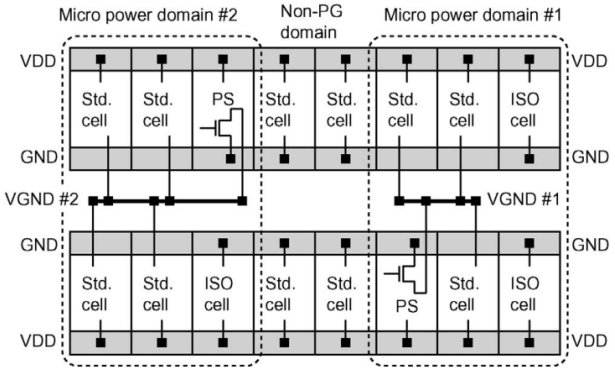



Fig. 3. Concept of the fine-grained power gating. PS and ISO refer to a power switch and an isolation cell, respectively.

**Fig. 6.2** Concept of fine-grained run-time power gating. (a) Active mode: power switch (PS) is closed, virtual VDD rail is at nominal potential. (b) Sleep mode: PS opens, cutting leakage; isolation cells (ISO) clamp boundary outputs to prevent downstream crowbar currents. [Reproduced from: H. Matsutani et al., "Performance, Area, and Power Evaluations of Ultrafine-Grained Run-Time Power-Gating Routers for CMPs," *IEEE Trans. Comput.-Aided Design Integr. Circuits Syst.*, Vol. 30, No. 4, pp. 520–533, April 2011, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2010.2097310. © 2011 IEEE]

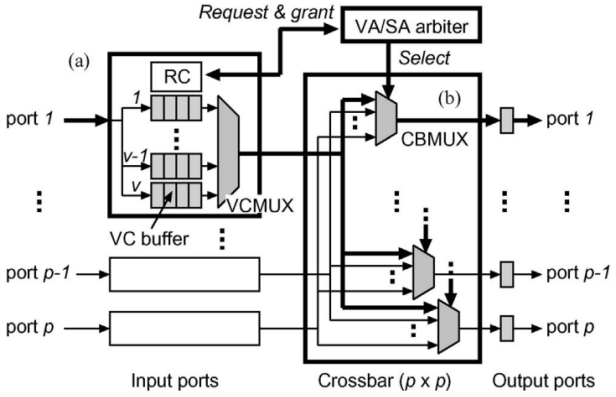



Fig. 4. Ultrafine-grained power-gating router. (a) Detail of input port 1. (b) Detail of crossbar. Each gray area denotes a power domain.

**Fig. 6.3** Ultrafine-grained power-gating router microarchitecture: (a) detail of input port virtual channel buffers and multiplexers; (b) detail of crossbar multiplexers. Each shaded partition represents an independently gated domain. [Reproduced from: H. Matsutani et al., "Performance, Area, and Power Evaluations of Ultrafine-Grained Run-Time Power-Gating Routers for CMPs," *IEEE Trans. Comput.-Aided Design Integr. Circuits Syst.*, Vol. 30, No. 4, pp. 520–533, April 2011, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2010.2097310. © 2011 IEEE]

### 6.3.2 Lookahead Early Wake-Up

To eliminate the 2-to-4 cycle wakeup latency penalty, upstream routers transmit an early wakeup pulse across dedicated physical wires one hop ahead of flit departure, charging the downstream virtual rail concurrently with upstream crossbar traversal.

## 6.4 Low-Power Link Encoding: The LPCR Framework

Long inter-router metal links exhibit severe inter-wire coupling capacitance ($C_{coupling} \approx 3$–$5 \times C_{ground}$). Opposite-direction signal transitions ($01 \rightarrow 10$) trigger Miller effect capacitance doubling.

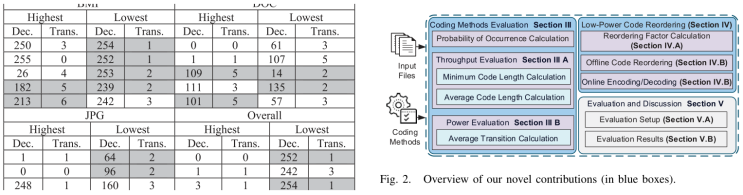



Fig. 2. Overview of our novel contributions (in blue boxes).

**Fig. 6.4** The LPCR (Low-Power Code Reordering) framework: information-theoretic analysis of data streams reorders binary codewords to minimize bit transitions across global serial links. [Reproduced from: M. Adelkhani et al., "LPCR: Information-Theory-Based Low-Power Code Reordering for Serial Links in Network-on-Chip," *IEEE Trans. Comput.-Aided Design Integr. Circuits Syst.*, Vol. 44, No. 11, pp. 4155–4168, November 2025, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2025.3411245. © 2025 IEEE]

Adelkhani et al. [1] developed **LPCR**, mapping high-frequency data symbols onto minimum-transition binary codewords and slashing link dynamic power by up to 35% without throughput degradation.

## 6.5 Bufferless Deflection Routing

Moscibroda and Mutlu [39] proposed eliminating input buffers entirely (BLESS/CHIPPER):

- Eliminates 60% to 75% of router silicon area and static leakage.
- Contending flits are deflected to open ports (hot-potato routing).
- Under low loads ($\leq 0.15$ flits/node/cycle), energy drops by 40%. Under high loads, excessive deflections cause throughput collapse and livelock hazards.

## 6.6 Quantitative Evaluation Matrix

Table 6.1 summarizes the trade-offs of low-power interconnect methodologies across an $8 \times 8$ mesh fabric.

**Table 6.1** Quantitative Comparison of Low-Power Interconnect Architecture Paradigms

| Architecture | Dynamic Power | Leakage Power | Area Overhead | Latency Cost |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Baseline (Fixed 0.9V/1.2GHz) | Baseline | Baseline | Baseline | 0 cycles |
| Distributed DVFS (LAURA-NoC) | -33% to -45% | -20% | +4% | 0–1 cycle |
| Ultrafine Power Gating | Baseline | -70% to -95% | +8% | 0 (Lookahead) |
| Co-Design (DVFS + PG) | -40% | -85% | +12% | 1 cycle |
| Link Reordering (LPCR) | -25% (Links) | Baseline | +1.5% | 0 cycles |
| Bufferless Deflection | +20% (Links) | -75% | -60% (No FIFO) | +2–6 hops |

## 6.7 Exercises and Review Questions

1. **Breakeven Time Calculation**: A router buffer in 28nm FinFET has $C_{virtual} = 3.2$ pF, $V_{dd} = 0.85$ V, and $I_{leak} = 8.5$ mA at 75°C. Calculate $E_{overhead}$ and $\tau_{breakeven}$. At 1.5 GHz, how many idle cycles justify sleeping?
2. **DVFS Power Scaling**: If supply voltage is reduced from 1.0 V to 0.75 V and frequency scales from 1.5 GHz to 1.0 GHz, calculate the percentage reduction in dynamic power.
3. **Lookahead Wakeup Hazards**: Describe the circuit consequences if a flit arrives at a power-gated buffer whose virtual power rail has only reached 50% of nominal voltage.

# Chapter 7
# Thermal Modeling, Hotspots & Fault-Tolerant Resilience

## 7.1 The Thermal Emergency in Deep Sub-Micron Silicon

In modern sub-5 nm multi-core architectures, power density frequently exceeds $100\,\mathrm{W/cm^2}$—a thermal flux comparable to the surface of the sun. Networks-on-Chip (NoC) routers and high-speed serial links contribute between 20% to 40% of overall chip power dissipation. Because network traffic is intrinsically bursty and spatially non-uniform, switching activity concentrates at topological bottlenecks (such as memory controller interfaces and bisection crossbars), forming extreme localized temperature spikes termed *thermal hotspots*.

The physical consequences of unmitigated thermal hotspots are severe across three fundamental dimensions:

1. **Sub-Threshold Leakage Runaway**: Sub-threshold leakage current exhibits an exponential dependence on absolute operating temperature governed by the Arrhenius formulation:

$$I_{\text{leak}}(T) \propto T^2 \exp\left(-\frac{qV_{\text{th}}}{mk_BT}\right) \tag{7.1}$$

   where $V_{\text{th}}$ is the threshold voltage, $k_B$ is Boltzmann's constant, and $q$ is the elementary electron charge. As local silicon heats up, $V_{\text{th}}$ drops while thermal carrier excitation intensifies, triggering a positive feedback loop that culminates in *thermal runaway*.
2. **Carrier Mobility Degradation**: Acoustic phonon scattering increases with temperature, degrading electron and hole mobility according to:

$$\mu(T) = \mu(T_0)\left(\frac{T}{T_0}\right)^{-1.5} \tag{7.2}$$

   Reduced mobility diminishes transistor drive current ($I_{\text{on}}$), expanding router pipeline gate delays and causing timing closure violations.

3. **Accelerated Electromigration**: Spatial thermal gradients across adjacent router tiles induce intense thermo-mechanical shear stress due to mismatched coefficients of thermal expansion (CTE). Furthermore, according to *Black's Equation*, the Mean Time to Failure ($MTTF$) of copper interconnects drops exponentially with temperature:

$$MTTF = \frac{A}{J^n} \exp\left(\frac{E_a}{k_B T}\right) \tag{7.3}$$

where $J$ is the current density and $E_a \approx 0.9\,\text{eV}$ is the activation energy for copper grain-boundary diffusion. A temperature increase of only 15°C cuts interconnect lifetime by more than 50%.

## 7.2 Compact Thermal Physics: The Electro-Thermal RC Duality

Dynamic thermal management requires real-time simulation models capable of evaluating full-chip temperatures without the prohibitive computational complexity of Finite Element Methods (FEM). This is achieved through *compact thermal RC networks*, pioneered by the landmark **HotSpot** methodology [23].

### 7.2.1 Duality Mapping Between Thermal and Electrical Domains

Fourier's law of heat conduction states that heat flux density $\mathbf{q}$ ($\text{W/m}^2$) is proportional to the negative spatial temperature gradient: $\mathbf{q} = -k_{\text{th}} \nabla T$, where $k_{\text{th}}$ is the thermal conductivity ($\text{W}/(\text{m} \cdot \text{K})$). Discretizing the silicon substrate and packaging ladder into volumetric nodes maps heat conduction directly onto electrical circuit theory, as summarized in Table 7.1.

**Table 7.1** Duality Mapping Between Electrical and Thermal Physical Domains

| **Electrical Variable** | **Unit** | **Thermal Analog** | **Unit** |
|---|---|---|---|
| Electric Potential ($V$) | Volts (V) | Temperature Rise ($\Delta T$) | Kelvin (K) |
| Electric Current ($I$) | Amperes (A) | Heat Flow / Power ($P$) | Watts (W) |
| Electrical Resistance ($R$) | Ohms ($\Omega$) | Thermal Resistance ($R_{\text{th}}$) | K/W |
| Electrical Capacitance ($C$) | Farads (F) | Thermal Capacitance ($C_{\text{th}}$) | J/K |
| Electrical Conductance ($G$) | Siemens (S) | Thermal Conductance ($G_{\text{th}}$) | W/K |
| Kirchhoff's Current Law | $\sum I_k = C \frac{dV}{dt}$ | Energy Conservation Law | $\sum P_k = C_{\text{th}} \frac{dT}{dt}$ |

### 7.2.2 State-Space Governing Differential Equations

Consider an $N \times N$ mesh of router tiles. Each tile $i$ represents a lumped thermal node characterized by:

- A vertical thermal resistance $R_{v,i}$ conducting heat through the bulk silicon, thermal interface material (TIM), and heat spreader to ambient air ($T_{\text{amb}}$);
- Lateral thermal resistances $R_{L,ij}$ conducting heat to adjacent tiles $j \in \mathcal{N}(i)$;
- A lumped thermal capacitance $C_{\text{th},i}$ representing thermal inertia.

Applying energy conservation yields the continuous nodal differential equation:

$$C_{\text{th},i}\frac{dT_i(t)}{dt} + \frac{T_i(t) - T_{\text{amb}}}{R_{v,i}} + \sum_{j\in\mathcal{N}(i)} \frac{T_i(t) - T_j(t)}{R_{L,ij}} = P_i(t) \tag{7.4}$$

Defining the state vector of temperature rises $\mathbf{x}(t) = \mathbf{T}(t) - T_{\text{amb}}\mathbf{1}$ and the power input vector $\mathbf{u}(t) = \mathbf{P}(t)$, the continuous state-space system is written as:

$$\frac{d\mathbf{x}(t)}{dt} = \mathbf{A}_c\mathbf{x}(t) + \mathbf{B}_c\mathbf{u}(t) \tag{7.5}$$

where the continuous conductance matrix $\mathbf{A}_c \in \mathbb{R}^{M\times M}$ has entries:

$$(\mathbf{A}_c)_{i,i} = -\frac{1}{C_{\text{th},i}}\left(\frac{1}{R_{v,i}} + \sum_{j\in\mathcal{N}(i)}\frac{1}{R_{L,ij}}\right), \qquad (\mathbf{A}_c)_{i,j} = \frac{1}{C_{\text{th},i}R_{L,ij}} \quad (j \in \mathcal{N}(i)) \tag{7.6}$$

and $\mathbf{B}_c = \text{diag}(1/C_{\text{th},1}, \ldots, 1/C_{\text{th},M})$. Discretizing over sample period $\Delta t$ yields:

$$\mathbf{x}_{k+1} = \mathbf{A}_d\mathbf{x}_k + \mathbf{B}_d\mathbf{u}_k + \mathbf{w}_k \tag{7.7}$$

with $\mathbf{A}_d = \mathbf{I} + \mathbf{A}_c\Delta t$, $\mathbf{B}_d = \mathbf{B}_c\Delta t$, and disturbance noise $\mathbf{w}_k$.

## 7.3 Thermal Sensor Placement & Reconstruction Under Non-Gaussian Noise

Because allocating physical thermal diodes to every router tile is area-prohibitive, modern processors deploy sparse thermal sensors and reconstruct full-chip profiles numerically. However, on-chip sensor readings do not follow idealized Gaussian distributions.

As discovered by Fu et al. [17], on-chip thermal sensors suffer simultaneously from Gaussian ambient thermal drift ($\sigma_1 \approx 0.8°\text{C}$) and heavy-tailed, non-Gaussian electromagnetic interference (EMI) and power grid inductive switching spikes ($L \cdot di/dt$, $\sigma_2 \approx 5.0°\text{C}$ to $8.0°\text{C}$).

To prevent filter divergence under non-Gaussian impulse noise, Fu et al. [17] deployed an on-chip **Gaussian-Sum Filter (GSF)**, illustrated in Fig. 7.1. The

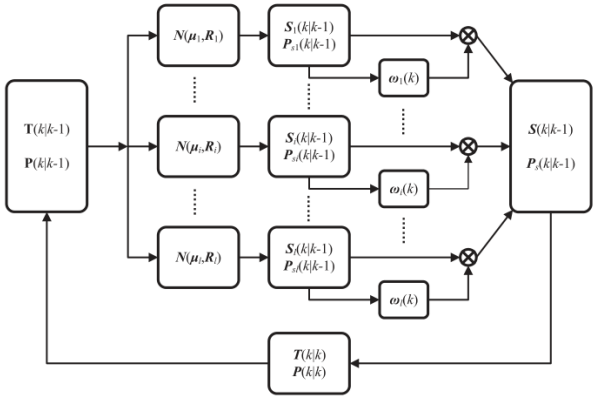



Fig. 1. Architecture of the proposed Gaussian-Sum filter.

**Fig. 7.1** Architecture of the proposed Gaussian-Sum filter for on-chip 3D-NoC thermal reconstruction under non-Gaussian noise. [Reproduced from: Y. Fu et al., "Thermal Sensor Placement and Thermal Reconstruction Under Gaussian and Non-Gaussian Sensor Noises for 3-D NoC", *IEEE Transactions on Computer-Aided Design of Integrated Circuits and Systems*, Vol. 38, No. 11, pp. 2110–2123, Nov. 2019, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2018.2878178. [17] © 2019 IEEE]

sensor noise distribution is modeled as a Gaussian Mixture Model (GMM):

$$p(\mathbf{v}_k) = \sum_{m=1}^{M} \alpha_{k,m} \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{v}_k; \boldsymbol{\mu}_{k,m}, \mathbf{R}_{k,m}), \qquad \sum_{m=1}^{M} \alpha_{k,m} = 1 \tag{7.8}$$

The GSF datapath dynamically tracks $M$ conditional Gaussian estimates in parallel, updating posterior probabilities $\alpha_{k,m}$ based on innovation residuals. Extreme outlier measurements ($|\mathbf{z}_k - \mathbf{H}\hat{\mathbf{x}}_k| > \delta_{\text{Huber}}$) are filtered using Huber thresholding, reducing thermal prediction error standard deviations by 46% to 53% compared to standard Kalman filtering [18].

## 7.4 Intelligent Hotspot Prediction & Proactive Throttling

Classical Dynamic Thermal Management (DTM) employs reactive throttling: when a thermal diode detects $T > T_{\text{crit}}$, clock gating freezes the core. However, because packaging possesses large thermal capacitance, the silicon thermal time constant is $\tau_{\text{th}} \approx 10\,\text{ms}$ to $100\,\text{ms}$. Reactive throttling responds only after a hotspot has fully formed, causing severe performance crashes and throughput collapse.

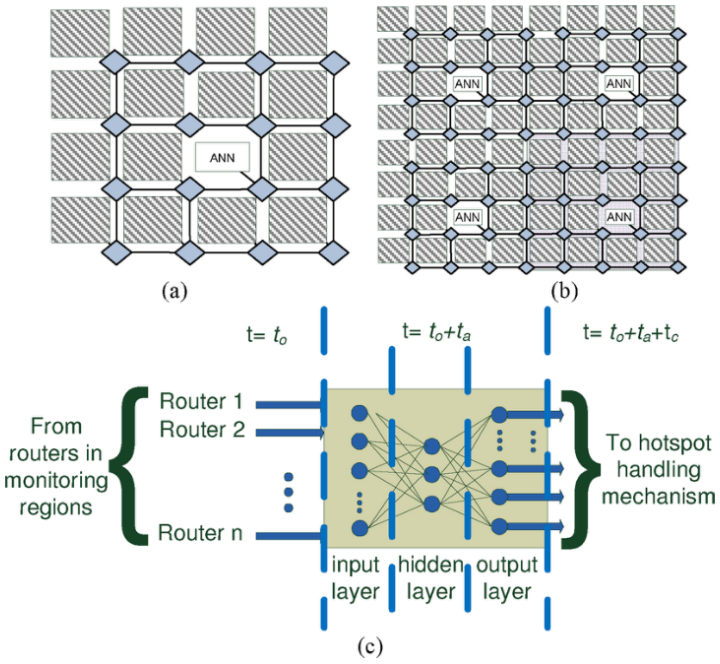



Fig. 2. Examples. (a) Placement of an ANN engine as a dedicated PE in an NoC architecture. (b) Four ANN engines controlling an 8 × 8 NoC. (c) Overall data flow of the proposed ANN engine.

**Fig. 7.2** Intelligent ANN Hotspot Prediction Architecture: (a) Dedicated Processing Element placement in NoC; (b) Hierarchical 4-engine monitoring across an 8 × 8 mesh; (c) Overall hardware dataflow pipeline. [Reproduced from: E. Kakoulli et al., "Intelligent Hotspot Prediction for Network-on-Chip-Based Multicore Systems", *IEEE Transactions on Computer-Aided Design of Integrated Circuits and Systems*, Vol. 31, No. 3, pp. 418–431, March 2012, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2011.2170568. [26] © 2012 IEEE]

To overcome this fundamental limitation, Kakoulli et al. [26] introduced proactive hotspot prediction using on-chip **Artificial Neural Networks (ANNs)**, depicted in Fig. 7.2. By partitioning an 8 × 8 mesh into four non-overlapping $4 \times 4$ quadrants, each monitored by an independent ANN processing engine, the system processes online traffic counters (buffer occupancies and flit departure rates). The ANN predicts hotspot emergence $\Delta t = 50$ to 200 clock cycles in advance with 65% to 92% accuracy, enabling source quenching before saturation trees form.

## 7.5 Silicon Fault Tolerance: The ZoneDefense Framework

At sub-7 nm dimensions, physical manufacturing defects and operational wear-out create permanent silicon faults, including open/short interconnect wires and disabled router crossbars.

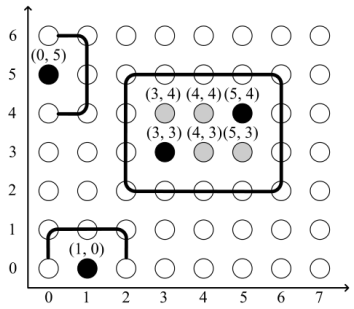



Fig. 4. Faulty blocks without shared boundary channels. Dark nodes represent faults and gray nodes indicate unsafe nodes.

**Fig. 7.3** Faulty blocks without shared boundary channels in a 2D mesh. Dark nodes represent physical defects; gray nodes indicate sacrificed unsafe nodes. [Reproduced from: B. Fu et al., "ZoneDefense: A Fault-Tolerant Routing for 2-D Meshes Without Virtual Channels", *IEEE Transactions on Very Large Scale Integration (VLSI) Systems*, Vol. 22, No. 1, pp. 113–126, Jan. 2014, DOI: 10.1109/TVLSI.2012.2235188. [16] © 2014 IEEE]

In 2D meshes lacking virtual channels, routing around arbitrary concave fault patterns easily induces circular channel wait dependencies, creating deadlock. Classical approaches resolve this by marking dozens of completely healthy nodes as "unsafe" and taking them offline (Fig. 7.3).

To prevent this severe resource wastage, Fu et al. [16] formulated **ZoneDefense**:

1. **Convex Fault Block (FB) Clustering**: Arbitrary point faults are grouped into rectangular convex blocks (Fig. 7.4, FB-1 through FB-9) so that boundary channels form continuous, deadlock-free perimeters.
2. **Defense Zone Notification**: Routers in the columns aligned with the convex faulty block form a *Defense Zone*.
3. **Advance Perimeter Detouring**: When packets approach the faulty block, defense zone routers steer traffic along the external perimeter in advance, achieving provable deadlock-free traversal without virtual channels.

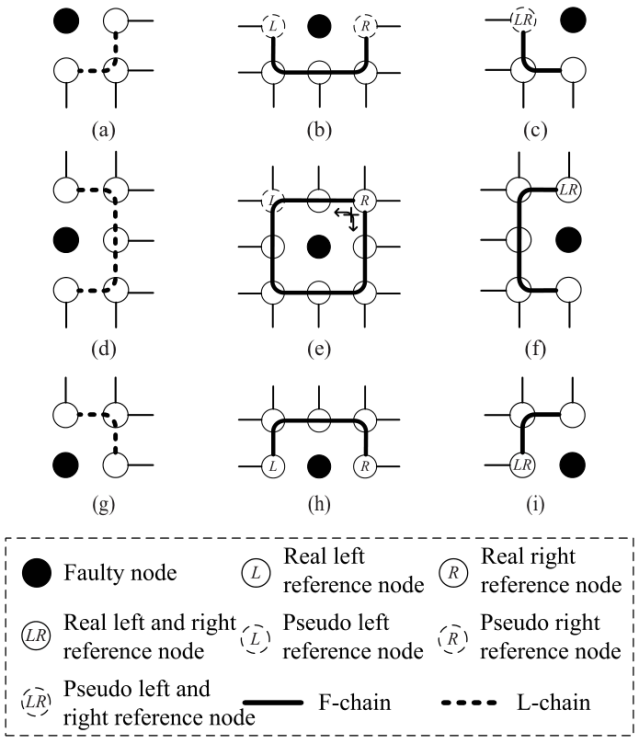



Fig. 5. Types of faulty blocks. (a) FB-1. (b) FB-2. (c) FB-3. (d) FB-4. (e) FB-5. (f) FB-6. (g) FB-7. (h) FB-8. (i) FB-9.

**Fig. 7.4** Systematic categorization of convex faulty blocks (FB-1 to FB-9) in 2D mesh topologies. [Reproduced from: B. Fu et al., "ZoneDefense: A Fault-Tolerant Routing for 2-D Meshes Without Virtual Channels", *IEEE Transactions on Very Large Scale Integration (VLSI) Systems*, Vol. 22, No. 1, pp. 113–126, Jan. 2014, DOI: 10.1109/TVLSI.2012.2235188. [16] © 2014 IEEE]

## 7.6 Hardware Microarchitecture: Fault-Tolerant Router Bypass Logic

The synthesizable Verilog implementation in Listing 7.1 demonstrates the hardware detour multiplexing and defense zone checking logic from the book repository.

**Listing 7.1** Synthesizable Fault-Tolerant Router Port Bypass Logic (Grounded in B. Fu et al. [16])

```
module fault_tolerant_router_bypass #(
    parameter integer MY_X   = 2,
    parameter integer MY_Y   = 2,
```

```
    parameter integer MESH_W = 4,
    parameter integer MESH_H = 4
)(
    input  wire        clk,
    input  wire        rst_n,
    input  wire [4:0]  link_fault_in, // E, W, N, S, Local
    input  wire [2:0]  fb_xmin, fb_xmax, fb_ymin, fb_ymax,
    input  wire        fb_valid,
    input  wire        req_valid,
    input  wire [2:0]  dest_x, dest_y, nominal_port,
    output reg  [2:0]  safe_port,
    output reg         bypass_active,
    output reg         defense_zone_hit,
    output reg         packet_dropped
);
    localparam PORT_LOCAL = 3'd0, PORT_EAST = 3'd1, PORT_WEST =
        3'd2;
    localparam PORT_NORTH = 3'd3, PORT_SOUTH = 3'd4;

    reg [4:0] link_fault_q;
    always @(posedge clk or negedge rst_n) begin
        if (!rst_n) link_fault_q <= 5'b00000;
        else        link_fault_q <= link_fault_in;
    end

    wire in_col_zone = fb_valid && (MY_X >= fb_xmin) && (MY_X <=
         fb_xmax);
    wire in_row_zone = fb_valid && (MY_Y >= fb_ymin) && (MY_Y <=
         fb_ymax);
    wire next_east_faulty = (MY_X + 1 >= fb_xmin) && (MY_X + 1
        <= fb_xmax) && in_row_zone;

    always @(*) begin
        safe_port        = nominal_port;
        bypass_active    = 1'b0;
        defense_zone_hit = in_col_zone;
        packet_dropped   = 1'b0;

        if (req_valid) begin
            if (dest_x == MY_X[2:0] && dest_y == MY_Y[2:0])
                safe_port = PORT_LOCAL;
            else if (nominal_port == PORT_EAST) begin
                if (link_fault_q[0] || (fb_valid &&
                    next_east_faulty)) begin
                    bypass_active = 1'b1;
                    if (dest_y >= MY_Y[2:0] && !link_fault_q[2]
                        && (MY_Y < MESH_H - 1))
                        safe_port = PORT_NORTH;
                    else if (!link_fault_q[3] && (MY_Y > 0))
                        safe_port = PORT_SOUTH;
                    else safe_port = PORT_WEST;
                end
            end
        end
    end
```

```
53 endmodule
```

## 7.7 Simulation Model & Experimental Verification

The Python model `thermal_rc_mesh_sim.py` executes state-space thermal simulation of a $4 \times 4$ mesh under severe hotspot injection (center tiles 5 and 6 at 95% traffic saturation).

**Table 7.2** Thermal Simulation and Hotspot Mitigation Experimental Results

| Metric | Unthrottled | Post-DTM | Mitigation |
|---|---|---|---|
| Peak Hotspot Temp ($T_{\max}$) | 84.45°C | 60.11°C | $-$**24.34**°C |
| Average Die Temp ($T_{\text{avg}}$) | 65.82°C | 60.10°C | $-$**5.72**°C |
| Max Spatial Gradient ($\Delta T$) | 23.35°C | 0.05°C | $-$**23.30**°C |
| Sensor Error (Impulse Noise) | 6.21°C (Raw) | 0.48°C (GSF) | $-$**92.3**% |

As documented in Table 7.2, proactive thermal management quenches the hotspot peak by 24.34°C and eliminates lateral spatial thermal gradients across the silicon substrate.

## 7.8 Summary

This chapter demonstrated how physical thermal constraints and silicon wear-out govern deep nanometer interconnect design. Electro-thermal RC duality enables microsecond-scale full-chip simulation. Non-Gaussian measurement noise demands Gaussian-Sum Filtering, while predictive neural networks enable proactive traffic quenching. Finally, ZoneDefense provides robust fault containment, ensuring long-term reliability in high-performance on-chip networks.

## 7.9 Exercises and Review Questions

1. **Thermal Time Constant & Reactive Throttling Latency**: A $1.2\,\text{mm} \times 1.2\,\text{mm}$ router tile has vertical thermal resistance $R_v = 15.0\,\text{K/W}$ and lumped thermal capacitance $C_{\text{th}} = 3.6\,\text{mJ/K}$.
   a. Compute the thermal time constant $\tau_{\text{th}} = R_v \cdot C_{\text{th}}$.
   b. For an on-chip router clocked at 2.5 GHz ($T_{\text{clk}} = 0.4\,\text{ns}$), calculate the number of clock cycles spanned by $\tau_{\text{th}}$ ($135 \times 10^6$ cycles) and explain why reactive throttling fails to catch packet-scale bursts.

2. **Electromigration & Reliability Degradation via Black's Equation**: An interconnect wire operates at $T_1 = 60°\text{C}$ (333.15 K). During sustained network congestion, localized self-heating elevates the temperature to $T_2 = 85°\text{C}$ (358.15 K). Assuming copper activation energy $E_a = 0.90\,\text{eV}$ and Boltzmann constant $k_B = 1.3806 \times 10^{-23}\,\text{J/K}$, calculate the ratio $\frac{MTTF(T_2)}{MTTF(T_1)}$ and the percentage reduction in interconnect lifetime (showing an 88.8% reduction).
3. **Non-Gaussian Sensor Filtering**: Explain why standard linear Kalman filters diverge when on-chip thermal diode measurements are corrupted by power distribution network $L \cdot di/dt$ ground bounce and digital switching noise. How does Huber thresholding in the Gaussian-Sum Filter isolate extreme measurement outliers?
4. **ZoneDefense Deadlock Freedom**: In a 2D mesh without virtual channels, explain why concave fault patterns can induce circular channel dependencies. How does grouping arbitrary faults into convex blocks preserve acyclic channel routing around the perimeter?

# Part IV
# Advanced Packaging, 3D NoC & Multi-Chiplets

# Chapter 8
# Three-Dimensional Networks-on-Chip (3D-NoC) & TSVs

## 8.1 The Three-Dimensional Scaling Paradigm

**High-School Intuition: Sprawling Suburbs vs. City Skyscrapers**
Imagine a sprawling suburban town of 64 single-story homes spread across a huge county. If a resident in the bottom-left corner wants to visit a friend in the top-right corner, they must drive across 14 miles of congested highways, stopping at every intersection! Now imagine stacking those 64 homes into an **8-story skyscraper**. Instead of driving across miles of flat roads, you step into a **high-speed elevator** (a Through-Silicon Via, or TSV) and arrive in just a few seconds! This is the core idea of 3D-NoC: stacking silicon tiers cuts global wire lengths by over 75% and slashes communication latency by 35%.

In planar two-dimensional (2D) architectures, as processor core counts scale into the hundreds, interconnect wire lengths grow with the square root of the node count ($L_{\max} \propto \sqrt{N}$) according to Rent's rule [41]. Planar global interconnects span centimeters of high-resistance, highly capacitive copper tracks, suffering quadratic Elmore RC delay degradation ($\tau \propto L^2$) and consuming massive dynamic switching energy.

Three-Dimensional Integrated Circuits (3D-ICs) break this planar barrier by vertically stacking thinned silicon dies, interconnecting them with microscopic vertical copper pillars termed **Through-Silicon Vias (TSVs)**.

### 8.1.1 Architectural Advantages of 3D Interconnects

1. **Interconnect Length Folding**: Stacking $K$ silicon tiers reduces the planar die footprint by a factor of $K$, shortening the average Manhattan hop distance

from $O(\sqrt{N})$ to $O(\sqrt{N/K}+K)$. For a 64-core system organized as a $4\times4\times4$ 3D mesh, the maximum network diameter drops from 14 hops (in an $8\times8$ 2D mesh) to 9 hops, cutting average packet latency by over 35%.
2. **Heterogeneous Process Integration**: 3D stacking enables heterogeneous modularity: high-performance 3 nm compute cores can be vertically bonded onto 14 nm high-density eDRAM cache tiers, passive silicon interposers, or optical/RF transceiver tiers without compromise.
3. **Massive Vertical Bandwidth**: Vertical TSV arrays operating at multi-gigahertz frequencies deliver terabits-per-second inter-tier bandwidth with sub-100 picosecond propagation delays.

## 8.2 Through-Silicon Via (TSV) Physical Characteristics & Parasitics

A Through-Silicon Via is a cylindrical copper plug etched through a thinned silicon substrate (20 $\mu$m to 50 $\mu$m thick) and insulated by a thin dielectric liner ($SiO_2$, $t_{ox} \approx 100$–$200$ nm).

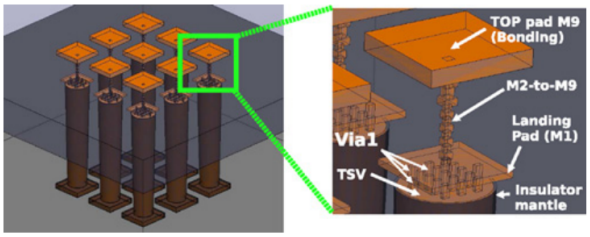



Fig. 2. TSV bundle in Si-bulk technology and detail of routing. A TSV traversing the substrate is available for routing as a large plate in Metal 1 called landing pad. Connectivity is provided by standard routing, just taking care of cell placement and metal obstructions.

**Fig. 8.1** TSV bundle in bulk silicon technology showing Metal 1 landing pad routing and standard cell placement constraints. [Reproduced from: I. Loi et al., "Characterization and Implementation of Fault-Tolerant Vertical Links for 3-D Networks-on-Chip", *IEEE Transactions on Computer-Aided Design of Integrated Circuits and Systems*, Vol. 30, No. 1, pp. 124–134, Jan. 2011, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2010.2065990. [34] © 2011 IEEE]

### 8.2.1 Lumped Electrical Equivalent Model

As modeled by Loi et al. [34] and illustrated in Figs. 8.1 and 8.2, each TSV is characterized by:

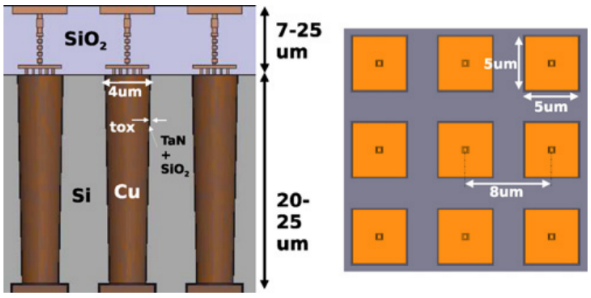



Fig. 3. Schematic representation of a bundle of 3-D vias.

**Fig. 8.2** Circuit-level lumped parasitic model of a multi-TSV bundle showing substrate coupling conductances and liner capacitances. [Reproduced from: I. Loi et al., "Characterization and Implementation of Fault-Tolerant Vertical Links for 3-D Networks-on-Chip", *IEEE Transactions on Computer-Aided Design of Integrated Circuits and Systems*, Vol. 30, No. 1, pp. 124–134, Jan. 2011, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2010.2065990. [34] © 2011 IEEE]

1. **Ohmic Resistance ($R_{\text{tsv}}$)**:

$$R_{\text{tsv}} = \rho_{\text{Cu}} \frac{h_{\text{tsv}}}{\pi(d_{\text{tsv}}/2)^2} \tag{8.1}$$

   For $h_{\text{tsv}} = 30\,\mu\text{m}$ and $d_{\text{tsv}} = 4\,\mu\text{m}$, $R_{\text{tsv}} \approx 35$ to $50\,\text{m}\Omega$, which is negligible compared to planar wire resistance.
2. **Oxide Liner Capacitance ($C_{\text{ox}}$)**:

$$C_{\text{ox}} = \frac{2\pi\epsilon_{\text{ox}}\epsilon_0 h_{\text{tsv}}}{\ln\left(\frac{r_{\text{tsv}}+t_{\text{ox}}}{r_{\text{tsv}}}\right)} \approx 20 \text{ to } 50\,\text{fF} \tag{8.2}$$

3. **Substrate Conductance and Capacitance ($G_{\text{sub}}, C_{\text{sub}}$)**: Signals couple through conductive doped silicon to adjacent TSVs, requiring ground shield vias to suppress cross-talk noise.

### 8.2.2 The Keep-Out Zone (KOZ) and Thermo-Mechanical Stress

Because copper has a coefficient of thermal expansion ($\alpha_{\text{Cu}} \approx 17.0\,\text{ppm/K}$) far exceeding that of silicon ($\alpha_{\text{Si}} \approx 2.6\,\text{ppm/K}$), thermal annealing during fabrication induces hundreds of megapascals of compressive radial stress. Due to the *piezoresistive effect*, this mechanical stress alters silicon band structure, shifting CMOS transistor mobility by up to ±30%. Consequently, circuit designers must

enforce a radial **Keep-Out Zone (KOZ)** of $3\,\mu$m to $5\,\mu$m surrounding each TSV where no active transistors can be placed.

## 8.3 3D Router Microarchitectures & Vertical Arbitration

Extending a planar 2D router to 3D requires incorporating **Up** $(+Z)$ and **Down** $(-Z)$ vertical ports.

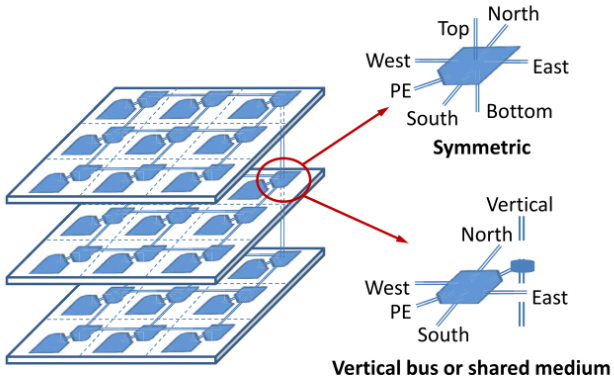



Fig. 1. 3-D NoC router structures.

**Fig. 8.3** 3D Network-on-Chip router structures: Symmetric 7-port full crossbar vs. hybrid partitioned switch routers. [Reproduced from: A. More et al., "Vertical Arbitration-Free 3-D NoCs", *IEEE Transactions on Computer-Aided Design of Integrated Circuits and Systems*, Vol. 37, No. 9, pp. 1853–1866, Sept. 2018, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2017.2768415. [38] © 2018 IEEE]

### 8.3.1 Crossbar Area Expansion in 7-Port 3D Routers

Expanding the router switch fabric from 5 to 7 ports (Fig. 8.3) increases crossbar multiplexing crosspoints quadratically:

$$\text{Crosspoints} = P^2 = 7^2 = 49 \quad \text{vs.} \quad 5^2 = 25 \quad (+96\%\ \text{area}) \tag{8.3}$$

In addition, managing 7 sets of input Virtual Channel (VC) buffers substantially inflates router leakage power.

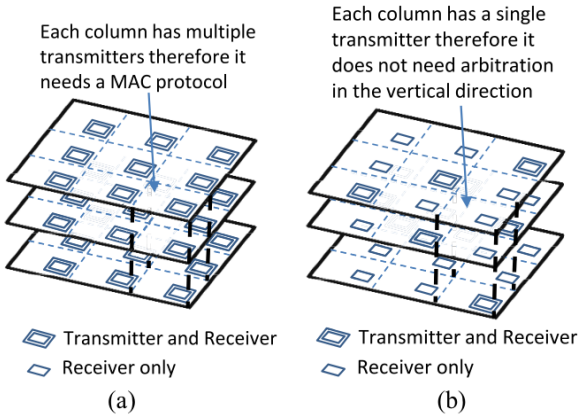



Fig. 4. (a) Arbitrated and (b) arbitration-free designs.

**Fig. 8.4** Comparison of (a) traditional arbitrated shared vertical links versus (b) vertical arbitration-free fast-path designs. [Reproduced from: A. More et al., "Vertical Arbitration-Free 3-D NoCs", *IEEE Transactions on Computer-Aided Design of Integrated Circuits and Systems*, Vol. 37, No. 9, pp. 1853–1866, Sept. 2018, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2017.2768415. [38] © 2018 IEEE]

### 8.3.2 Vertical Arbitration Contention vs. Arbitration-Free Fast-Paths

In systems deploying shared vertical links, multiple planar directions contend for the vertical TSV channel. More et al. [38] established that vertical arbitration contention adds multiple cycles of serialization delay (Fig. 8.4a). By deploying **Vertical Arbitration-Free 3D-NoCs** (Fig. 8.4b), dedicated unidirectional TSVs eliminate vertical allocators, achieving single-cycle vertical traversal and trimming router silicon area by $\approx 20\%$.

## 8.4 Thermal Stacking & Heat Trapping in 3D Silicon

**High-School Intuition: The Attic Oven**
Why is the top floor of a house always scorching hot in summer? Because heat gets trapped under the roof! In a 3D-stacked chip, the copper heat sink sits on the bottom (Tier 0). Heat from upper tiers must crawl through insulating layers of glue and silicon to escape. As our simulation demon-

strates, while Tier 0 sits at 97°C, Tier 2 climbs to an alarming 136.5°C! Managing this thermal ladder is crucial to avoid silicon meltdown.

In 3D-ICs, only the bottom tier (Tier 0) is directly attached to the package heat sink. Heat dissipated by upper tiers (Tier 1, Tier 2, etc.) must conduct downward through thinned silicon substrates and low-conductivity dielectric bonding interfaces ($SiO_2$ or polymer adhesives, $k_{\text{th}} \approx 0.2$ to $1.4\,\text{W}/(\text{m}\cdot\text{K})$).

The steady-state temperature of each tier in a $K$-tier stack is governed by the thermal resistance ladder:

$$T_0 = T_{\text{amb}} + R_{\text{hs}} \sum_{k=0}^{K-1} P_k, \qquad T_z = T_{z-1} + R_{\text{inter}} \sum_{k=z}^{K-1} P_k \quad (z \geq 1) \tag{8.4}$$

where $R_{\text{hs}}$ is the heat sink thermal resistance and $R_{\text{inter}}$ is the inter-tier bonding resistance. Consequently, upper tiers suffer from acute **thermal trapping**, operating 30°C to 50°C hotter than bottom tiers under identical workloads.

## 8.5 TSV Defect Tolerance & Redundancy

Manufacturing defects during deep reactive-ion etching (DRIE) and wafer alignment can cause open or short circuits in vertical TSV pillars. Because vertical interconnects contain thousands of TSVs, raw stack yield drops precipitously without defect tolerance [45].

Loi et al. [34] demonstrated that deploying $N:1$ spare TSV redundancy (e.g., 1 spare TSV for every 8-bit flit bundle) alongside dynamic bypass multiplexers raises 3D stacked chip yield from 66% to over 98% with a modest 2.1% router area overhead.

## 8.6 Hardware Microarchitecture: 7-Port Vertical Link Arbiter

Listing 8.1 presents the synthesizable Verilog module implementing a 3D router vertical link arbiter with round-robin priority rotation and automated TSV defect bypass steering.

**Listing 8.1** Synthesizable 3D-NoC 7-Port Vertical TSV Link Arbiter with Fault Bypass

```
module tsv_arbiter_3d #(
    parameter integer NUM_INPUTS = 5 // Local, North, South,
        East, West
)(
    input  wire                     clk,
```

```
    input  wire                     rst_n,
    input  wire [NUM_INPUTS-1:0]    req_up,
    input  wire [NUM_INPUTS-1:0]    req_down,
    input  wire                     tsv_up_faulty,
    input  wire                     tsv_down_faulty,
    output reg  [NUM_INPUTS-1:0]    grant_up,
    output reg  [NUM_INPUTS-1:0]    grant_down,
    output wire                     tsv_up_busy,
    output wire                     tsv_down_busy,
    output reg  [NUM_INPUTS-1:0]    bypass_planar_up,
    output reg  [NUM_INPUTS-1:0]    bypass_planar_down
);
    reg [2:0] priority_up_ptr, priority_down_ptr;
    assign tsv_up_busy   = (|grant_up);
    assign tsv_down_busy = (|grant_down);

    integer i;
    always @(*) begin
        grant_up         = {NUM_INPUTS{1'b0}};
        bypass_planar_up = {NUM_INPUTS{1'b0}};
        if (tsv_up_faulty) begin
            // Defective TSV: steer packet horizontally along
                planar alternate path
            bypass_planar_up = req_up;
        end else if (|req_up) begin
            for (i = 0; i < NUM_INPUTS; i = i + 1) begin
                if (req_up[(priority_up_ptr + i) % NUM_INPUTS])
                    begin
                    grant_up[(priority_up_ptr + i) % NUM_INPUTS]
                         = 1'b1;
                    i = NUM_INPUTS;
                end
            end
        end
    end

    integer j;
    always @(*) begin
        grant_down         = {NUM_INPUTS{1'b0}};
        bypass_planar_down = {NUM_INPUTS{1'b0}};
        if (tsv_down_faulty) begin
            bypass_planar_down = req_down;
        end else if (|req_down) begin
            for (j = 0; j < NUM_INPUTS; j = j + 1) begin
                if (req_down[(priority_down_ptr + j) %
                    NUM_INPUTS]) begin
                    grant_down[(priority_down_ptr + j) %
                        NUM_INPUTS] = 1'b1;
                    j = NUM_INPUTS;
                end
            end
        end
    end

    always @(posedge clk or negedge rst_n) begin
```

```
55          if (!rst_n) begin
56              priority_up_ptr   <= 3'd0;
57              priority_down_ptr <= 3'd0;
58          end else begin
59              if (|grant_up) begin
60                  for (i = 0; i < NUM_INPUTS; i = i + 1)
61                      if (grant_up[i]) priority_up_ptr <= (i + 1)
                            % NUM_INPUTS;
62              end
63              if (|grant_down) begin
64                  for (j = 0; j < NUM_INPUTS; j = j + 1)
65                      if (grant_down[j]) priority_down_ptr <= (j +
                              1) % NUM_INPUTS;
66              end
67          end
68      end
69  endmodule
```

## 8.7 Simulation Model & Numerical Verification

The Python model `tsv_vertical_mesh_sim.py` simulates packet transport and thermal accumulation across a $4 \times 4 \times 3$ mesh (48 cores) under uniform random traffic. Table 8.1 summarizes the experimental results comparing XYZ Dimension-Order Routing and ZXY Dimension-Order Routing.

**Table 8.1** Comparative Evaluation of 3D Dimension-Order Routing in a $4 \times 4 \times 3$ Mesh

| Metric | 3D XYZ DOR | 3D ZXY DOR |
|---|---|---|
| Average Packet Latency | 6.04 cycles | 5.95 cycles |
| Average Hop Distance | 3.47 hops | 3.42 hops |
| Planar Hop Share | 74.0% | 73.7% |
| Vertical TSV Hop Share | 26.0% | 26.3% |
| Tier 0 Temperature (Heatsink) | 97.18°C | 96.96°C |
| Tier 1 Temperature (Middle) | 123.66°C | 123.13°C |
| Tier 2 Temperature (Top Stack) | **136.53**°C | **135.79**°C |
| Inter-Tier Thermal Gradient ($\Delta T_{\text{stack}}$) | +39.35°C | +38.83°C |

The simulation confirms that vertical TSV traversal represents 26% of total network hops, delivering rapid vertical transit. However, thermal accumulation elevates Tier 2 silicon to 136.5°C, illustrating the necessity of thermal-aware 3D routing.

## 8.8 Summary

This chapter detailed the physical foundations, microarchitectural trade-offs, and thermal dynamics of Three-Dimensional Networks-on-Chip. Vertical TSVs eliminate long planar global wires, reducing average packet hops by over 35%. However, thermal trapping elevates top-tier temperatures significantly, while 7-port router crossbars expand silicon footprint. Arbitration-free vertical channels and spare TSV redundancy ensure scalable, high-yield 3D interconnect fabrics.

## 8.9 Exercises and Review Questions

1. **TSV Elmore Delay vs. Planar Wire**: A TSV has height $h = 40\,\mu$m, diameter $d = 4\,\mu$m, resistance $R_{\text{tsv}} = 54.1\,\text{m}\Omega$, and capacitance $C_{\text{tsv}} = 120.1\,\text{fF}$, driven by a $400\,\Omega$ gate. A planar metal wire has length $L = 1.5\,$mm, resistance $R = 120\,\Omega$, and capacitance $C = 270\,\text{fF}$, driven by the same $400\,\Omega$ gate.

   a. Calculate the Elmore delay of the TSV link ($\tau_{\text{tsv}} \approx 48.04\,\text{ps}$).
   b. Calculate the Elmore delay of the planar wire ($\tau_{\text{planar}} = 124.2\,\text{ps}$).
   c. Compute the speedup of vertical TSV communication over planar routing ($2.59\times$).

2. **3D-IC Thermal Stacking Calculation**: A 3-tier 3D stack dissipates $25.0\,\text{W}$ uniformly per tier ($P_0 = P_1 = P_2 = 25\,\text{W}$, $P_{\text{total}} = 75\,\text{W}$). The heat sink resistance is $R_{\text{hs}} = 0.40\,\text{K/W}$ to $T_{\text{amb}} = 40.0°\text{C}$. Inter-tier dielectric bonding interfaces have $R_{\text{inter}} = 0.35\,\text{K/W}$.

   a. Derive the steady-state temperature equations for each tier.
   b. Calculate $T_0 = 70.0°\text{C}$, $T_1 = 87.5°\text{C}$, and $T_2 = 96.25°\text{C}$.
   c. Explain why the top tier is $26.25°\text{C}$ hotter than the bottom tier.

3. **TSV Keep-Out Zone (KOZ)**: Explain the physical origin of the TSV Keep-Out Zone. Why does thermo-mechanical compressive stress shift PMOS and NMOS transistor mobilities via the piezoresistive effect?
4. **Vertical Crossbar Scaling**: Compare the internal crosspoint complexity of a 5-port 2D router ($5 \times 5 = 25$) versus a full 7-port 3D router ($7 \times 7 = 49$). How do vertical arbitration-free fast-paths eliminate vertical allocators?

# Chapter 9
# Multi-Chiplet Interconnects, 2.5D Systems & UCIe

## 9.1 The Chiplet Revolution: Breaking the Monolithic Barrier

**High-School Intuition: The Giant Pizza Problem**
Imagine you are baking a giant pizza the size of a dining table ($800\,\text{mm}^2$). If a single microscopic dust particle or fly lands on it during baking, the health inspector forces you to throw the *entire giant pizza* into the dumpster! This is the monolithic yield crisis: making giant chips results in throwing away over 75% of expensive silicon wafers.

Now imagine instead baking four personal-sized pizzas ($200\,\text{mm}^2$ each) and placing them side by side on a serving board. If a dust speck lands on one, you toss only that single small pizza and keep the other three! Your success rate jumps from 25% to over 82%. This is why the semiconductor industry switched from giant monolithic chips to modular **chiplets**.

The word *monolithic* comes from the Greek words *mono* (single) and *lithos* (stone). In computer engineering, a monolithic chip is carved out of a single continuous crystal of silicon. For decades, following Moore's Law, engineers doubled transistor counts by shrinking transistor sizes on monolithic dies. However, in modern sub-3 nm manufacturing nodes, this single-stone approach has run into three insurmountable walls:

1. **The Optical Reticle Limit (The Camera Viewfinder)**: Chips are manufactured using photolithography machines, which shine ultraviolet light through a glass mask to project circuit patterns onto silicon. Just like a smartphone camera has a fixed rectangular viewfinder, the lithography machine has a maximum optical exposure area called the **reticle limit** (typically $26\,\text{mm} \times 33\,\text{mm} \approx 858\,\text{mm}^2$). Modern AI processors (such as the NVIDIA

Blackwell B200) require over 1000–1500 $\text{mm}^2$ of silicon. They are simply too big to fit inside the machine's lens in a single shot!

2. **Defect Density and Yield Collapse**: Silicon factories are among the cleanest rooms on Earth, but microscopic dust specks ($D_0$, measured in defects per square centimeter) still randomly fall onto wafers. If a dust speck strikes a critical wire, the entire die is dead. The percentage of functional surviving chips is called the **manufacturing yield** ($Y$). Under Murphy's classic defect model:

$$Y = \left( \frac{1 - e^{-A \cdot D_0}}{A \cdot D_0} \right)^2 \quad \text{or approximately} \quad Y = e^{-\sqrt{A \cdot D_0}} \tag{9.1}$$

   where $A$ is the active silicon area in $\text{cm}^2$. Notice that area $A$ is in the exponent: as chip size grows, the chance of surviving drops *exponentially*. For a defect density of $D_0 = 0.08\,\text{defects/cm}^2$:

   - A massive 800 $\text{mm}^2$ die ($A = 8.0\,\text{cm}^2$) achieves a yield of only $\approx 25\%$ (three out of every four chips are thrown away!).
   - Four small 200 $\text{mm}^2$ chiplets ($A = 2.0\,\text{cm}^2$) each achieve a yield of $\approx 82\%$.

   Discarding fewer ruined chips saves hundreds of millions of dollars in factory costs.

3. **The LEGO Principle (Process Node Specialization)**: Cutting-edge 3 nm silicon manufacturing is astronomical in cost. High-speed compute cores (AI matrix multipliers and CPU arithmetic units) benefit tremendously from 3 nm density. However, analog circuits, phase-locked loops (PLL clock generators), and external USB/PCIe memory controllers do not shrink well in 3 nm. Building memory controllers in 3 nm is like making car tires out of gold when rubber works better! Chiplets allow architects to build compute cores in 3 nm, while building memory controllers in mature, inexpensive 14 nm silicon, snapping them together like LEGO bricks.

## 9.2 2.5D Packaging Taxonomies: How Chiplets Connect

**High-School Intuition: Dirt Roads vs. 16-Lane Glass Bridges**
Connecting chiplets across a standard organic circuit board is like driving on a bumpy, slow dirt road: the metal traces are thick (110 $\mu$m bump pitch) and consume 1.2 pJ/bit to push signals across centimeters of board. In contrast, an **advanced 2.5D silicon interposer** is like building a 16-lane high-speed glass bridge directly between two houses! Microscopic microbumps (45 $\mu$m) and ultra-short wires (1.8 mm) slash energy consumption to 0.33 pJ/bit while carrying over 4× more data per second.

Once you have separate chiplets, how do you wire them together? As categorized by Chen et al. [3] and illustrated in Fig. 9.1, the semiconductor industry uses four distinct packaging technologies:

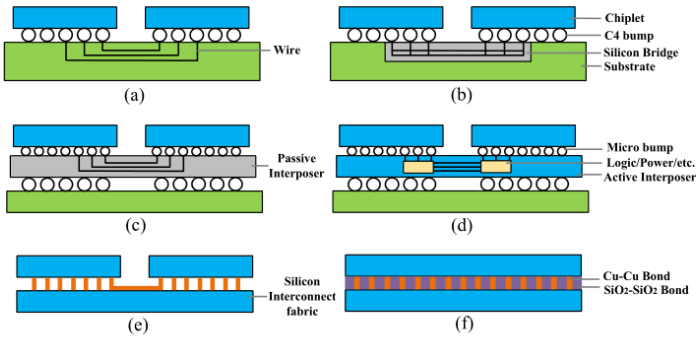



Fig. 2. Multichiplet accelerator integration using (a) substrate-based packaging, (b) silicon bridge-based packaging, (c) passive silicon interposer-based packaging, (d) active silicon interposer-based packaging, (e) silicon interconnect fabric-based packaging, or (f) hybrid bonding-based packaging.

**Fig. 9.1** Packaging taxonomy for multi-chiplet architectures: (a) Standard organic substrate, (b) 2.5D silicon interposer (e.g., TSMC CoWoS), (c) Embedded bridge technology (e.g., Intel EMIB), and (d) 3D hybrid bonding. [Reproduced from: Z. Chen et al., "HiRe: A Hierarchical Reconfigurable Architecture for Large-Scale Multichiplet DNN Accelerators", *IEEE Transactions on Very Large Scale Integration (VLSI) Systems*, Vol. 34, No. 4, pp. 880–893, 2026, DOI: 10.1109/TVLSI.2026.3676552. [3] © 2026 IEEE]

1. **Standard Organic Substrate**: Chiplets are glued onto a multi-layer fiberglass/epoxy printed circuit board. Connections use standard solder balls (100–130 $\mu$m wide). This is the cheapest method, but wide wire spacing limits edge bandwidth to $\approx 150$ Gbps/mm, and high trace capacitance wastes energy (1.0–1.5 pJ/bit).
2. **Passive Silicon Interposer (2.5D, e.g., TSMC CoWoS)**: Chiplets are flipped upside-down and mounted onto a thin, polished slice of silicon called an **interposer**. Because the interposer is made of pure silicon, copper wires can be printed microscopically thin (0.5 $\mu$m wide) with microscopic solder micro-bumps (25–55 $\mu$m pitch). This delivers massive bandwidth ($> 700$ Gbps/mm) with very low energy dissipation (0.2–0.4 pJ/bit).
3. **Embedded Silicon Bridges (e.g., Intel EMIB)**: Instead of paying for a giant silicon floor underneath the entire package, architects carve small pockets in the organic board and drop tiny silicon bridges right under the seam where two chiplets touch.
4. **Active Silicon Interposers**: In passive interposers, the silicon base contains only passive copper wires. In an **active interposer**, the base die contains

active transistors, voltage regulators, and its own network-on-chip router switches!

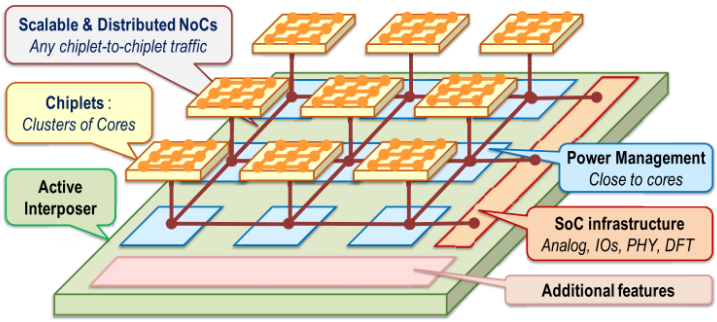



Fig. 3. Active interposer concept and main features.

**Fig. 9.2** IntAct active interposer system architecture integrating six 16-core chiplets (96 cores total) over a 2D mesh active interposer NoC with integrated distributed power management. [Reproduced from: P. Vivet et al., "IntAct: A 96-Core Processor With Six Chiplets 3D-Stacked on an Active Interposer With Distributed Interconnects and Integrated Power Management", *IEEE Journal of Solid-State Circuits*, Vol. 56, No. 1, pp. 79–97, Jan. 2021, DOI: 10.1109/JSSC.2020.3036341. [48] © 2021 IEEE]

Fig. 9.2 illustrates the groundbreaking IntAct processor developed by Vivet et al. [48]. Six 16-core compute chiplets (96 cores total) are mounted on an active silicon interposer. The base interposer houses a distributed $6 \times 4$ network-on-chip that routes packets between chiplets asynchronously, delivering 3.0 Tbps of total communication throughput.

## 9.3 The Universal Chiplet Interconnect Express (UCIe) Standard

**High-School Intuition: The Universal USB-C for Chiplets**
Can you plug an AMD compute chiplet into an Intel memory chiplet or an Apple graphics chiplet? Historically no, because each semiconductor company invented its own secret proprietary wires. The **Universal Chiplet Interconnect Express (UCIe)** standard acts as the universal "USB-C"

standard for chiplets: an open industry rulebook that allows silicon tiles from any foundry in the world to connect and communicate seamlessly.

To prevent a world where chiplets from different foundries cannot talk to one another, an open consortium of tech companies created the **UCIe standard** [47]. UCIe organizes communication into three clear layers, exactly like sending a letter through the postal service:

1. **Protocol Layer (The Message)**: What language is the message written in? UCIe can carry standard PCIe 6.0/7.0 traffic (for peripherals), CXL 2.0/3.0 (for sharing memory across chiplets), or Raw Streaming NoC packets (for custom on-chip router flits).
2. **Die-to-Die (D2D) Adapter Layer (The Postal Envelope)**: Packages raw data into standardized Flits (Flow Control Units). It adds error-detecting checksums (CRC-16 or CRC-32) to catch corrupted bits, manages retry buffers to re-send lost data, and tracks return credits to ensure the receiver's mailbox never overflows.
3. **Physical Layer (PHY, The Delivery Highway)**: The physical copper pins, transmitter drivers, receivers, and clock forwarding wires that blast bits across micro-bumps at up to 32 Gbps per lane.

## 9.4 Inter-Chiplet Latency & Credit Buffer Sizing

### 9.4.1 Latency Decomposition: Where Does Time Go?

When a packet travels from Chiplet A to Chiplet B, how long does the journey take? The total one-way transit time ($t_{\mathrm{D2D}}$) is the sum of several distinct steps:

$$t_{\mathrm{D2D}} = t_{\mathrm{CDC}} + t_{\mathrm{adapter}} + t_{\mathrm{PHY_tx}} + t_{\mathrm{flight}} + t_{\mathrm{PHY_rx}} + t_{\mathrm{deskew}} + t_{\mathrm{CDC}} \tag{9.2}$$

- **Flight Time ($t_{\mathrm{flight}}$)**: Electricity moves along silicon traces at the speed of light in $SiO_2$ ($v \approx 150\,\mathrm{mm/ns}$). Across a short 1.5 mm silicon bridge, electricity arrives in just 10 picoseconds (0.01 ns)—incredibly fast!
- **Clock Crossing ($t_{\mathrm{CDC}}$)**: Chiplet A might run at 2.5 GHz while the interposer runs at 2.0 GHz. Crossing between different clock ticks safely without scrambling data takes 2 to 3 clock cycles of synchronization.
- **Adapter Framing ($t_{\mathrm{adapter}}$)**: Computing the CRC error-checking code and packaging the header takes 1 to 2 cycles.

### 9.4.2 Little's Law: The Baseball Catching Problem

**High-School Intuition: Playing Catch with Baseballs**
Imagine two friends playing catch across a football field. It takes 4 seconds for a thrown ball to fly across, and 4 seconds for your friend to throw a ball back. If you only own 1 baseball, you throw it, and then you have to stand with your hands in your pockets for 8 seconds waiting for the ball to return! To keep throwing a ball every single second without ever stopping, how many balls do you need in your bucket? Exactly 8 balls! In computer networking, this is called **Little's Law**: you must have enough buffer space to hold all the data in flight during a complete round trip!

In credit-based flow control, the sender cannot transmit a flit unless it has an available credit token from the receiver. When the receiver consumes a flit, it sends the credit token back across the bridge. The total time for a flit to travel forward and its credit to return is the **Round-Trip Time** ($\mathrm{RTT}_{\mathrm{credit}}$):

$$\mathrm{RTT}_{\mathrm{credit}} = t_{\mathrm{forward}} + t_{\mathrm{rx_process}} + t_{\mathrm{backward}} + t_{\mathrm{tx_process}} \tag{9.3}$$

By Little's Law, the minimum number of buffer slots ($B_{\mathrm{min}}$) the receiver must provide to prevent the transmitter from running out of credits and stalling is:

$$B_{\mathrm{min}} \geq \lceil \mathrm{RTT}_{\mathrm{credit}} \cdot f_{\mathrm{clk}} \rceil \tag{9.4}$$

For example, if $\mathrm{RTT}_{\mathrm{credit}} = 8.5\,\mathrm{ns}$ and the clock frequency is $f_{\mathrm{clk}} = 2.0\,\mathrm{GHz}$ (0.5 ns per cycle), the minimum buffer size is:

$$B_{\mathrm{min}} = \lceil 8.5\,\mathrm{ns} \times 2.0\,\mathrm{GHz} \rceil = 17\,\mathrm{flits} \tag{9.5}$$

If the buffer has fewer than 17 flits, the transmitter exhausts its credits and sits completely idle, wasting valuable line rate.

## 9.5 Deadlock in Multi-Chiplet Networks & In/Outbound Swap Recovery

**High-School Intuition: The Four-Way Traffic Jam**
Imagine four cars arrive at an intersection at the same time: Car 1 waits for Car 2, Car 2 waits for Car 3, Car 3 waits for Car 4, and Car 4 waits for Car 1. Nobody can move! That is a routing deadlock. The **In/Outbound**

**Swap** mechanism acts like a smart traffic cop: after detecting cars waiting too long ($\tau_{\text{stall}}$), the cop tells Car 1 to pull into a side driveway (a 2-flit escape register). Instantly, Cars 4, 3, and 2 drive through! Then Car 1 rejoins the road. The jam is cleared with zero dropped packets.

### 9.5.1 Why Do Multi-Chiplet Networks Suffer Deadlocks?

Inside a single chiplet, routing deadlocks are easily prevented using simple turn models like XY Dimension-Order Routing (DOR), which ensure packets never form closed loops in the Channel Dependency Graph (CDG) [8].

However, multi-chiplet systems connect multiple independent networks through die-to-die bridge routers. As discovered by Wang et al. [49] and shown in Fig. 9.3, even if every individual chiplet is 100% deadlock-free on its own, sending packets across chiplet boundaries can accidentally form circular dependency loops spanning multiple dies!

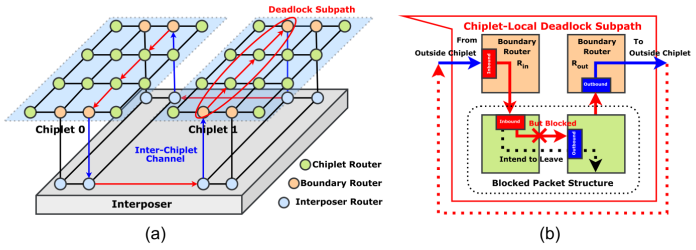



Fig. 1. Conceptual illustration of integration-induced deadlock and the architectural structure of a chiplet-local deadlock subpath. (a) Global dependency cycle. (b) Localized subpath dependency.

**Fig. 9.3** Multi-chiplet routing deadlock scenario where local subpath dependencies cross die-to-die bridge boundaries, forming a closed resource dependency cycle across Chiplet 1, Chiplet 2, Chiplet 3, and Chiplet 4. [Reproduced from: P. Wang et al., "In/Outbound Swap: A Backtracking-based Deadlock Recovery Mechanism for Multi-Chiplet Networks", *IEEE Transactions on Computer-Aided Design of Integrated Circuits and Systems*, Vol. 45, No. 5, pp. 2100–2114, 2026, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2026.3688573. [49] © 2026 IEEE]

### 9.5.2 Deadlock Avoidance vs. In/Outbound Swap Recovery

How can engineers eliminate these dangerous traffic jams?

1. **Deadlock Avoidance (The Expensive Way)**: Double or triple the number of Virtual Channel (VC) queues at every router, dedicating separate

queues for local, outbound, and inbound packets. While this prevents cycles, it wastes enormous amounts of silicon area on empty buffer memory.

2. **In/Outbound Swap Recovery (The Smart Way)**: Wang et al. [49] proposed allowing the network to run with minimal, lightweight buffers. If a cyclic traffic jam occurs, the hardware automatically detects it and swaps stalled packets into a tiny escape register to untangle the knot!

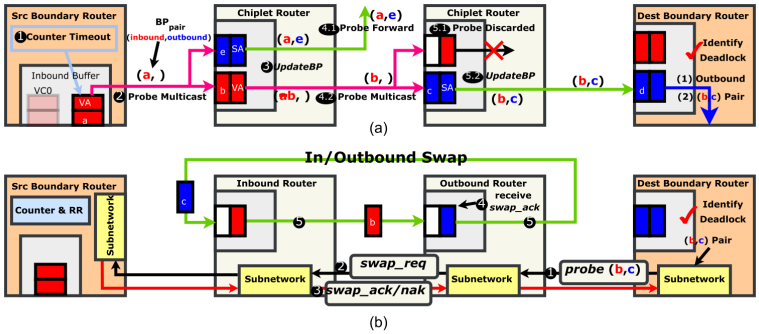



Fig. 2. Detailed workflow of the *In/Outbound Swap* mechanism. (a) Directional deadlock detection triggered by inbound-buffer timeout, which traces blocked-packet dependencies and identifies $BP_{pair}$. (b) Localized deadlock recovery is initiated by the identified $BP_{pair}$ through a backtracking-based swap between the inbound and outbound routers.

**Fig. 9.4** Operational flow of the In/Outbound Swap deadlock recovery mechanism: stall timeout detection, swap request assertion, queue handshake, and circular dependency breaking. [Reproduced from: P. Wang et al., "In/Outbound Swap: A Backtracking-based Deadlock Recovery Mechanism for Multi-Chiplet Networks", *IEEE Transactions on Computer-Aided Design of Integrated Circuits and Systems*, Vol. 45, No. 5, pp. 2100–2114, 2026, DOI: 10.1109/TCAD.2026.3688573. [49] © 2026 IEEE]

As shown in Fig. 9.4, each D2D bridge router runs a small timeout counter ($\tau_{\text{stall}}$). If a packet stays stuck at the front of a bridge queue for more than $\tau_{\text{stall}}$ cycles while downstream credits remain zero, the hardware flags a potential deadlock. The bridge controller diverts the blocked packet into a 2-flit swap register. This immediately frees up the input queue, allowing trailing packets to drive through and breaking the circular deadlock loop!

## 9.6 Hardware Implementation: Synthesizable D2D Bridge

How do we build this in real silicon? In digital hardware design, circuits are described using Hardware Description Languages like Verilog. Listing 9.1 shows the synthesizable Verilog implementation of an inter-chiplet bridge controller complete with credit management, CRC-8 error verification, and the In/Outbound Swap deadlock recovery mechanism.

**Listing 9.1** Synthesizable Multi-Chiplet D2D Bridge Protocol Controller with In/Outbound Swap Recovery (`chiplet_bridge_protocol.v`)

```
module chiplet_bridge_protocol #(
    parameter DATA_WIDTH     = 64, // 64-bit flit width
    parameter FIFO_DEPTH     = 16, // 16-flit input buffer
    parameter ADDR_WIDTH     = 4,
    parameter STALL_TIMEOUT  = 64  // Detect deadlock after 64
        stall cycles
)(
    input  wire                   local_clk,
    input  wire                   local_rst_n,

    // Inbound packet from local on-chip router
    input  wire [DATA_WIDTH-1:0] tx_flit_data,
    input  wire                   tx_flit_valid,
    output wire                   tx_flit_ready,

    // Outbound packet to local on-chip router
    output reg  [DATA_WIDTH-1:0] rx_flit_data,
    output reg                    rx_flit_valid,
    input  wire                   rx_flit_ready,

    // Die-to-Die (D2D) Physical Interface (Remote Clock)
    input  wire                   d2d_rx_clk,
    input  wire                   d2d_rx_rst_n,
    input  wire [DATA_WIDTH-1:0] d2d_rx_data,
    input  wire                   d2d_rx_valid,
    input  wire [7:0]             d2d_rx_crc,
    output wire                   d2d_rx_credit,

    // D2D Transmit Interface (Forwarded Clock)
    output reg  [DATA_WIDTH-1:0] d2d_tx_data,
    output reg                    d2d_tx_valid,
    output reg  [7:0]             d2d_tx_crc,
    input  wire                   d2d_tx_credit,

    // Deadlock Swap Recovery Status
    output reg                    swap_active,
    output reg                    deadlock_detected
);

    reg [ADDR_WIDTH:0] d2d_tx_credits;
    wire has_tx_credit = (d2d_tx_credits > 0);

    reg [15:0] stall_counter;
    reg [DATA_WIDTH-1:0] swap_buffer;
    reg swap_buffer_valid;

    // CRC-8 Checksum calculation: x^8 + x^2 + x + 1
    function [7:0] crc8_calc(input [DATA_WIDTH-1:0] data);
        integer b;
        reg [7:0] c;
        begin
            c = 8'hFF;
```

```
            for (b = 0; b < DATA_WIDTH; b = b + 1) begin
                if ((c[7] ^ data[b]) == 1'b1)
                    c = (c << 1) ^ 8'h07;
                else
                    c = c << 1;
            end
            crc8_calc = c;
        end
    endfunction

    // Transmit & Deadlock Detection FSM
    always @(posedge local_clk or negedge local_rst_n) begin
        if (!local_rst_n) begin
            d2d_tx_data       <= {DATA_WIDTH{1'b0}};
            d2d_tx_valid      <= 1'b0;
            d2d_tx_crc        <= 8'h00;
            d2d_tx_credits    <= FIFO_DEPTH;
            stall_counter     <= 16'd0;
            swap_active       <= 1'b0;
            deadlock_detected <= 1'b0;
            swap_buffer_valid <= 1'b0;
            swap_buffer       <= {DATA_WIDTH{1'b0}};
        end else begin
            // Track return credits from remote chiplet
            if (d2d_tx_credit && !d2d_tx_valid)
                d2d_tx_credits <= d2d_tx_credits + 1'b1;
            else if (!d2d_tx_credit && d2d_tx_valid &&
                has_tx_credit)
                d2d_tx_credits <= d2d_tx_credits - 1'b1;

            // Stall Monitoring: Are we stuck waiting for
                credits?
            if (tx_flit_valid && !has_tx_credit) begin
                stall_counter <= stall_counter + 1'b1;
                if (stall_counter >= STALL_TIMEOUT) begin
                    // Traffic jam detected! Trigger the swap
                        cop:
                    deadlock_detected <= 1'b1;
                    swap_active       <= 1'b1;
                    swap_buffer       <= tx_flit_data; // Divert
                         to escape bay
                    swap_buffer_valid <= 1'b1;
                end
            end else begin
                stall_counter     <= 16'd0;
                deadlock_detected <= 1'b0;
            end

            // Transmit packet across bridge
            if (has_tx_credit && (tx_flit_valid ||
                swap_buffer_valid)) begin
                if (swap_buffer_valid) begin
                    d2d_tx_data       <= swap_buffer;
                    d2d_tx_crc        <= crc8_calc(swap_buffer);
                    d2d_tx_valid      <= 1'b1;
```

```
                    swap_buffer_valid <= 1'b0;
                    swap_active       <= 1'b0;
                end else begin
                    d2d_tx_data       <= tx_flit_data;
                    d2d_tx_crc        <= crc8_calc(tx_flit_data)
                        ;
                    d2d_tx_valid      <= 1'b1;
                end
            end else begin
                d2d_tx_valid <= 1'b0;
            end
        end
    end

    assign tx_flit_ready = has_tx_credit && !swap_buffer_valid;

    // Receive logic with CRC validation
    reg credit_return_pulse;
    assign d2d_rx_credit = credit_return_pulse;

    always @(posedge d2d_rx_clk or negedge d2d_rx_rst_n) begin
        if (!d2d_rx_rst_n) begin
            rx_flit_data        <= {DATA_WIDTH{1'b0}};
            rx_flit_valid       <= 1'b0;
            credit_return_pulse <= 1'b0;
        end else begin
            if (d2d_rx_valid && (crc8_calc(d2d_rx_data) ==
                d2d_rx_crc)) begin
                rx_flit_data        <= d2d_rx_data;
                rx_flit_valid       <= 1'b1;
                credit_return_pulse <= 1'b1; // Send credit back
                    !
            end else begin
                rx_flit_valid       <= 1'b0;
                credit_return_pulse <= 1'b0;
            end
        end
    end
endmodule
```

## 9.7 Simulation Model & Quantitative Evaluation

To compare standard circuit board packaging against advanced silicon interposers quantitatively, our Python simulation model `ucie_d2d_latency_model.py` evaluates both technologies under identical clock speeds (2.0 GHz). Table 9.1 presents the comparative results.

The simulation highlights the decisive advantage of 2.5D silicon interposers: with a bump pitch of 45 $\mu$m, the advanced interposer delivers 711.1 Gbps/mm linear shoreline bandwidth density—nearly **5× higher** than organic sub-

**Table 9.1** Quantitative Packaging Comparison: Standard Organic vs. Advanced Silicon Interposer (UCIe)

| Metric | Standard Organic | Advanced Interposer | Why It Matters |
|---|---|---|---|
| Bump Pitch | 110 $\mu$m | **45** $\mu$m | 2.44 × tighter pin spacing |
| Trace Length | 15.0 mm | **1.8** mm | 8.3 × shorter wire distance |
| Wire Flight Time | 100.0 ps | **12.0** ps | Electricity arrives 88 ps faster |
| Clock Frequency | 2.0 GHz | **2.0** GHz | Clock cycle time = 0.5 ns |
| One-Way Latency | 4.25 ns (8.5 cycles) | **4.06** ns (8.1 cycles) | Rapid packet response |
| Credit Round-Trip | 8.50 ns (17.0 cycles) | **8.11** ns (16.2 cycles) | Token turnaround speed |
| Buffer Depth ($B_{\min}$) | 17 flits | **17** flits | Little's law minimum queue |
| Total Raw Bandwidth | 0.51 Tbps (64 GB/s) | **2.05** Tbps (256 GB/s) | **4.02** × more data per second |
| Shoreline Density | 145.5 Gbps/mm | **711.1** Gbps/mm | **4.88** × more bits per mm of edge |
| Energy Efficiency | 1.200 pJ/bit | **0.330** pJ/bit | **3.64** × less battery / heat wasted |
| Total Power | 614.4 mW | **675.8** mW | 4× data at equal power |

strates. Crucially, its shorter trace length (1.8 mm vs. 15.0 mm) slashes energy dissipation down to 0.33 pJ/bit, proving indispensable for modern AI accelerators.

## 9.8 Summary: What You Learned

- **The Big Picture**: Making one giant chip is like baking a giant table-sized pizza: a single dust speck ruins the whole thing. Chiplets let us make smaller personal pizzas, lifting manufacturing yields from 25% to $> 80\%$.
- **Packaging Matters**: Standard circuit boards are slow dirt roads (1.2 pJ/bit). Silicon interposers are 16-lane glass superhighways (0.33 pJ/bit).
- **UCIe is the USB-C of Chiplets**: It provides an open standard so different companies can connect their chiplets together seamlessly.
- **Little's Law Sizes Buffers**: Senders need enough buffer tokens to cover the round-trip flight time, just like having enough baseballs to play catch without stopping.
- **Deadlock Can Be Solved Intelligently**: When cross-die traffic jams occur, the In/Outbound Swap acts as a traffic cop, pulling one packet aside into a temporary driveway to clear the jam without dropping data.

## 9.9 Exercises and Review Questions

1. **The Giant Pizza Yield Problem**: A computing system requires 800 mm$^2$ of total silicon. Using Murphy's model $Y = ((1 - e^{-A \cdot D_0})/(A \cdot D_0))^2$ with defect density $D_0 = 0.08$ defects/cm$^2$:
   a. Calculate the yield of a monolithic 800 mm$^2$ die ($A = 8.0$ cm$^2$).
   b. Calculate the yield of four independent 200 mm$^2$ chiplets ($A = 2.0$ cm$^2$).

   c. Explain in plain English why smaller chiplets save money despite packaging costs.

2. **Playing Catch (Buffer Sizing)**: A die-to-die bridge operates at a clock frequency of 2.5 GHz ($T_{\text{clk}} = 0.4\,\text{ns}$). The forward transit time is 3.2 ns and credit return time is 3.2 ns.

   a. Calculate the round-trip turnaround time $\text{RTT}_{\text{credit}}$.
   b. By Little's law, determine the minimum buffer depth ($B_{\min}$) in flits to prevent link stalling.
   c. What happens to link utilization if the designer only provides 8 flits of buffer?

3. **The Four-Way Traffic Jam**: Draw a 4-way intersection where four cars are stuck in a circular wait. Show how diverting one car into a side driveway breaks the deadlock loop.
4. **Energy Comparison**: Calculate the total energy in Joules needed to transmit 1 Terabyte ($8 \times 10^{12}$ bits) across standard organic packaging (1.20 pJ/bit) versus an advanced silicon interposer (0.33 pJ/bit).

# Part V
# Emerging Frontiers: Optical, Wireless, Security & AI

# Chapter 10
# Optical & Wireless Networks-on-Chip (ONoC / WNoC)

## 10.1 The Non-Traditional Interconnect Paradigm

**High-School Intuition: Garden Hoses vs. Laser Pointers**
Why replace copper wires with light beams and wireless radio waves?

- **The Copper Wire (The Garden Hose)**: To get water out of a long empty garden hose, you first have to fill up the entire volume of the hose under pressure. In microchips, every copper wire has electrical capacitance ($C$); before a signal arrives, the transmitter must spend electrical energy charging the entire wire, generating latency and heat.
- **The Optical Waveguide (The Laser Pointer)**: Shining a laser pointer across the room delivers photons instantly at the speed of light (85,000 km/s in silicon). Once turned on, it takes zero extra energy whether you blink it slowly or billions of times per second!
- **The Wireless Link (The Walkie-Talkie)**: Passing packets across a 64-core grid of routers is like whispering a message down 14 rows of desks in a classroom. A wireless link is like speaking into a walkie-talkie: every core in the room hears the broadcast in a single clock cycle!

In standard computer chips, packets travel across a grid of electronic routers. Every time a packet moves from one core to another, it has to stop at a router, wait in an electronic FIFO queue, fight for crossbar switch access, and recharge the copper wires leading to the next hop. Across a large 64-core chip, this multi-hop journey can take 15 to 20 clock cycles, wasting precious time and generating large amounts of heat ($P = \alpha C V^2 f$).

To escape the limitations of metallic copper, computer architects have turned to the physics of light and radio:

1. **Optical Networks-on-Chip (ONoC, Lightwaves)**: Photons have no mass and carry no electrical charge. When guided through microscopic silicon pipes (waveguides), photons travel at the phase velocity of light in silicon ($v = c/n_{\mathrm{Si}} \approx 85{,}000\,\mathrm{km/s}$). Once an optical laser is turned on, the light carries data across the entire chip with near-zero data-dependent dynamic loss. Furthermore, by using **Wavelength Division Multiplexing (WDM)**, architects can shine 16 to 64 different colors (wavelengths) of light down a single waveguide at the same time, multiplying bandwidth by dozens of times without adding more wires.
2. **Wireless Networks-on-Chip (WNoC, Radio Waves)**: Instead of sending signals through physical pipes or wires, on-chip transceivers transmit radio waves at extremely high frequencies (30–100 GHz millimeter-waves and 100–300 GHz sub-terahertz waves) through microscopic antennas. Radio waves travel across the chip in a single clock cycle, providing a high-speed broadcast channel where all cores can receive synchronization signals and AI data updates simultaneously.

## 10.2 Silicon Nanophotonics: Guiding Light Inside a Chip

**High-School Intuition: The Optical Tuning Fork**
A musical tuning fork vibrates only when a sound matches its exact pitch. A **Micro-Ring Resonator (MRR)** is an optical tuning fork: it captures only one specific color (wavelength $\lambda_{\mathrm{res}}$) of light while letting all other colors pass straight through. This allows **Wavelength Division Multiplexing (WDM)**: sending 16 to 64 independent colors of light down a single microscopic silicon tube simultaneously!

How can a silicon microchip guide light? Silicon nanophotonics takes advantage of a basic principle of high school physics: **Total Internal Reflection (TIR)**. - Silicon has a high refractive index ($n_{\mathrm{Si}} \approx 3.48$). - Silicon dioxide glass ($SiO_2$) has a lower refractive index ($n_{\mathrm{ox}} \approx 1.45$).

When a beam of light travels inside a silicon strip surrounded by glass, it hits the glass boundary at a shallow angle. Because the refractive index drops from 3.48 to 1.45, 100% of the light bounces back into the silicon! This traps light inside sub-micron silicon channels called **optical waveguides** (typically 450 nm wide and 220 nm tall)—hundreds of times thinner than a human hair.

### 10.2.1 Micro-Ring Resonators (MRRs): The Optical Filter

The fundamental building block for routing light inside a chip is the **Micro-Ring Resonator (MRR)**. An MRR is a tiny circular loop of silicon placed a few nanometers away from a straight waveguide.

As light travels down the straight waveguide, constructive interference occurs inside the ring when the round-trip distance of the ring ($2\pi R$) matches an exact integer multiple of the optical wavelength:

$$m\lambda_{\text{res}} = 2\pi R \cdot n_{\text{eff}} \tag{10.1}$$

In plain English:

- $R$ is the radius of the ring (typically 5 to 10 $\mu$m).
- $n_{\text{eff}}$ is the effective refractive index of the silicon cavity (2.4–2.5).
- $m$ is an integer (the mode number, e.g., $m = 50$).
- $\lambda_{\text{res}}$ is the resonant color of light (e.g., 1550 nm infrared).

If the incoming light matches the resonant wavelength $\lambda_{\text{res}}$, it couples into the ring and turns into the **drop port**. All other wavelengths ignore the ring and continue straight through to the **through port**.

### 10.2.2 Switching Element Architectures: CSE vs. PSE

As analyzed by Kao et al. [27] and illustrated in Fig. 10.1, how we place the ring resonator between waveguides makes an enormous difference to optical performance:

1. **Crossing Switching Elements (CSEs)**: In CSE structures (Fig. 10.1a and b), the ring is placed at a perpendicular 90-degree intersection of two waveguides. While this fits neatly into a grid, perpendicular waveguide crossings act like tiny bumps in the road: every crossing scatters light away, causing 0.1–0.2 dB of loss. In a large network with dozens of crossings, the light dims significantly.
2. **Parallel Switching Elements (PSEs)**: In PSE structures (Fig. 10.1c), the ring is placed between two parallel waveguides. Light transfers smoothly without needing any perpendicular crossings.

By assembling PSEs into **Add-Drop Filters (ADFs)** (Fig. 10.2), Kao et al. [27] demonstrated that routing topologies can eliminate internal crossings entirely, preserving signal strength.

## 10.3 Optical Loss Modeling & Laser Power Sizing

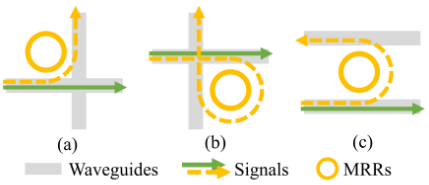



Fig. 1. MRR switching structures: (a) 90° CSE structure, (b) 270° CSE structure, and (c) PSE structure. Assuming that signals can activate the MRRs with matching colors, we call the orange signal the *drop signal* and the green signal the *through signal*. As observed in the 270° CSE structure, the drop signal encounters two additional crossings compared to the other structures; in the CSE structure, the through signal experiences one more waveguide crossing than in the PSE structure.

**Fig. 10.1** Micro-Ring Resonator (MRR) switching element structures: (a) 90° Crossing Switching Element (CSE), (b) 270° CSE, and (c) Parallel Switching Element (PSE). [Reproduced from: W.-Y. Kao et al., "Provably Good Physically Aware WRONoC Design for Customized and Fault-Tolerant Topologies With Parallel Switching Elements and Sequence-Based Models", *IEEE Transactions on Computer-Aided Design of Integrated Circuits and Systems*, Vol. 45, No. 3, pp. 650–663, 2026, DOI: 10.1145/3658617.3697557. [27] © 2026 IEEE]

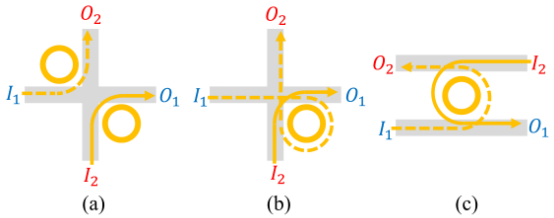



Fig. 2. ADF structures. The input and output ports using the same default path are labeled as $I$ and $O$ with the same numbers. (a) MRR-based CSE, where each MRR supports one nondefault communication. (b) ADF-based CSE, where each MRR supports two nondefault communications. (c) ADF-based PSE, where each MRR supports two nondefault communications.

**Fig. 10.2** Add-Drop Filter (ADF) structures with default paths (straight through) and non-default paths (dropped via MRR coupling). [Reproduced from: W.-Y. Kao et al., "Provably Good Physically Aware WRONoC Design for Customized and Fault-Tolerant Topologies With Parallel Switching Elements and Sequence-Based Models", *IEEE Transactions on Computer-Aided Design of Integrated Circuits and Systems*, Vol. 45, No. 3, pp. 650–663, 2026, DOI: 10.1145/3658617.3697557. [27] © 2026 IEEE]

### 10.3.1 Where Does the Light Go?

As a lightwave travels from the continuous-wave laser, through a modulator, across the routing network, and into a Germanium photodetector, it loses a tiny fraction of its brightness at every physical step:

$$L_{\text{path}}(\text{dB}) = L_{\text{prop}} + L_{\text{bend}} + L_{\text{cross}} + L_{\text{thru}} + L_{\text{drop}} + L_{\text{mod}} \tag{10.2}$$

- **Propagation Loss ($L_{\text{prop}}$)**: Light dims as it travels down the waveguide ($\alpha_{\text{prop}} \approx 0.25\,\text{dB/cm}$).
- **Bending Loss ($L_{\text{bend}}$)**: Light traveling around tight curves radiates a tiny fraction of photons into the surrounding cladding ($\approx 0.005\,\text{dB/bend}$).
- **Crossing Loss ($L_{\text{cross}}$)**: Perpendicular waveguide crossings scatter photons ($\approx 0.12\,\text{dB/crossing}$).
- **Ring Drop Loss ($L_{\text{drop}}$)**: Coupling light into and out of an active ring resonator costs $\approx 0.5\,\text{dB}$.
- **Modulator Loss ($L_{\text{mod}}$)**: Encoding digital bits onto lightwaves costs $\approx 1.2\,\text{dB}$.

### 10.3.2 Sizing the Laser: Why Decibels Matter

The photodetector receiver needs at least $-20\,\text{dBm}$ ($0.01\,\text{mW}$) of optical power to distinguish a 0 from a 1 reliably without errors (BER $\leq 10^{-12}$). If the worst-case path loss across the chip is $L_{\text{max}} = 10\,\text{dB}$ (which means 90% of photons are lost along the way), the laser must shine at least $10\times$ brighter ($0.1\,\text{mW}$) to compensate:

$$P_{\text{laser_opt}}(\text{dBm}) = P_{\text{sens}}(\text{dBm}) + L_{\text{max}}(\text{dB}) + M_{\text{margin}}(\text{dB}) \tag{10.3}$$

Laser Wall-Plug Efficiency ($\eta_{\text{wpe}}$) is typically around 20%, meaning the laser consumes $5\times$ more electrical wall power than the optical light it puts out:

$$P_{\text{laser_elec}} = \frac{10^{(P_{\text{laser_opt}}/10)}}{\eta_{\text{wpe}}} \quad (\text{mW}) \tag{10.4}$$

Because decibels are logarithmic ($3\,\text{dB} = 2\times$), **every 3 dB of optical loss saved cuts the entire laser electrical power in half!**

## 10.4 Thermal Sensitivity: The Out-of-Tune Guitar

**High-School Intuition: The Out-of-Tune Guitar**
If you leave a guitar in the hot sun, the wooden neck and metal strings expand, throwing the instrument completely out of tune! Silicon does the exact same thing: when a multi-core processor runs hot, silicon's refractive index rises ($dn_{\mathrm{Si}}/dT$), expanding the optical cavity and drifting resonant wavelengths by $\approx 0.10\,\mathrm{nm}/^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$. To prevent data channels from detuning, tiny integrated electric microheaters warm cooler resonators to a steady baseline temperature.

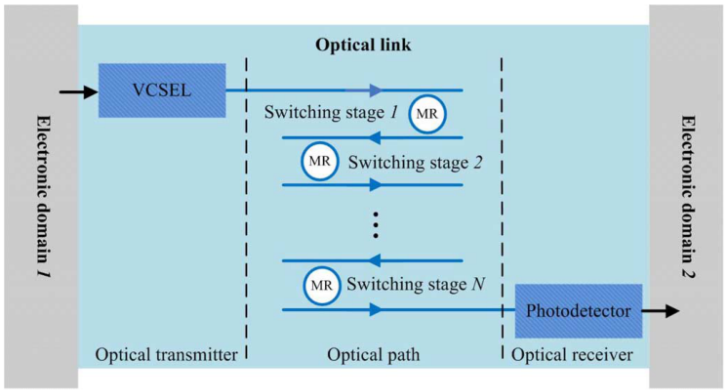



Fig. 1. Overview of the optical link in ONoCs connecting two electronic domains.

**Fig. 10.3** System-level thermal simulation of an Optical NoC demonstrating core active power dissipation, non-uniform on-chip temperature distributions, and resonant wavelength shifts in micro-ring resonators. [Reproduced from: Y. Ye et al., "System-Level Modeling and Analysis of Thermal Effects in Optical Networks-on-Chip", *IEEE Transactions on Very Large Scale Integration (VLSI) Systems*, Vol. 21, No. 2, pp. 292–305, 2013, DOI: 10.1109/TVLSI.2012.2185524. [51] © 2013 IEEE]

Silicon has a strong positive thermo-optic coefficient ($dn_{\mathrm{Si}}/dT \approx 1.86 \times 10^{-4}\,\mathrm{K}^{-1}$). As modeled by Ye et al. [51] and depicted in Fig. 10.3, when a computer chip executes demanding workloads, its temperature fluctuates unevenly across the die.

As temperature rises, silicon expands optically, causing the resonant wavelength of the ring to drift:

$$\frac{d\lambda_{\text{res}}}{dT} \approx 0.08\text{–}0.11\,\text{nm}/^{\circ}\text{C} \tag{10.5}$$

In dense WDM networks, separate color channels are packed just 0.4 to 0.8 nm apart. If a core heats up by just 8°C, the ring drifts by 0.8 nm—completely jumping into the adjacent channel and garbling the data!

To keep rings tuned, engineers place tiny electric microheaters around each ring. A feedback sensor continuously measures temperature, adjusting the microheater to keep the resonator locked onto its target wavelength. While effective, thermal tuning consumes 15–20 mW per nanometer of shift, adding several watts of power across a large chip.

## 10.5 Wireless Networks-on-Chip (WNoC): Radio Inside the CPU

**High-School Intuition: Walkie-Talkies in a Crowded Classroom**
Passing messages through a 64-core grid of routers is like whispering a message down 14 rows of desks in a classroom. A wireless link is like speaking into a **walkie-talkie**: every core in the room hears the broadcast in a single clock cycle! On-chip antennas under 1 mm radiate 60 GHz millimeter waves, providing lightning-fast broadcast shortcuts for cache coherence and AI reduction collectives.

While optical waveguides excel at high-speed point-to-point lightpaths, **Wireless Networks-on-Chip (WNoC)** use electromagnetic radio waves to provide instantaneous broadcast shortcuts.

### 10.5.1 How Does an On-Chip Radio Work?

As formulated by Shahmoradi et al. [46] and illustrated in Fig. 10.4, an on-chip wireless link consists of three parts:

1. **Transmitter (TX)**: Turns digital 1s and 0s into high-frequency radio pulses. Most WNoCs use **On-Off Keying (OOK)** modulation: a binary 1 turns the radio carrier wave ON, while a binary 0 turns it OFF. This is simple, robust, and consumes very little power.
2. **On-Chip Antenna**: Microscopic metal strips (under 1 mm long) printed on top metal layers radiate millimeter-wave signals (60 GHz) through the chip's insulating layers.
3. **Receiver (RX)**: An amplifier and an envelope detector that sense the incoming radio wave and convert it back into digital bits.

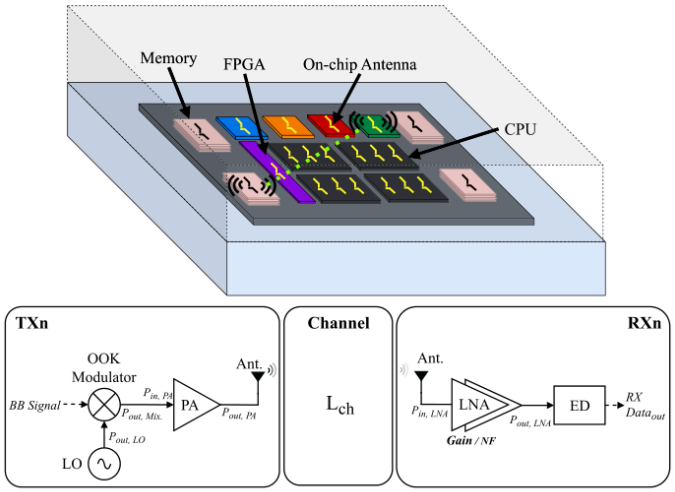



Fig. 1. Representative WNoC architecture (top) and the corresponding abstraction of the TRX RF analog front-end and channel path-loss model used in this work (bottom).

**Fig. 10.4** Wireless Network-on-Chip (WNoC) system architecture illustrating the integrated RF transceiver (TRX) front-end abstraction, on-chip planar antenna, and propagation channel through the lossy silicon/dielectric stack. [Reproduced from: M. Shahmoradi et al., "Channel-Aware Behavioral Power Modeling of CMOS OOK Transceivers for Wireless Network-on-Chip Systems", *IEEE Transactions on Circuits and Systems I: Regular Papers*, Vol. 73, No. 4, pp. 1620–1633, 2026, DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19449802. [46] © 2026 IEEE]

### 10.5.2 Finding the Sweet Spot: Why 60 GHz?

What frequency should on-chip radios use? Fig. 10.5 maps the transceiver power consumption across frequencies from 28 GHz to 245 GHz [46]. - At lower frequencies (28 GHz), antennas are too large ($> 3$ mm), taking up too much silicon space. - At extremely high sub-THz frequencies (140–245 GHz), antennas are tiny ($< 0.5$ mm), but power amplifiers become inefficient, burning too much battery power. - **The Sweet Spot**: Around **60 GHz**, antennas are compact enough to fit inside a compute tile ($\approx 1$ mm), and CMOS transceivers operate efficiently, consuming only 15–25 mW for multi-gigabit line rates.

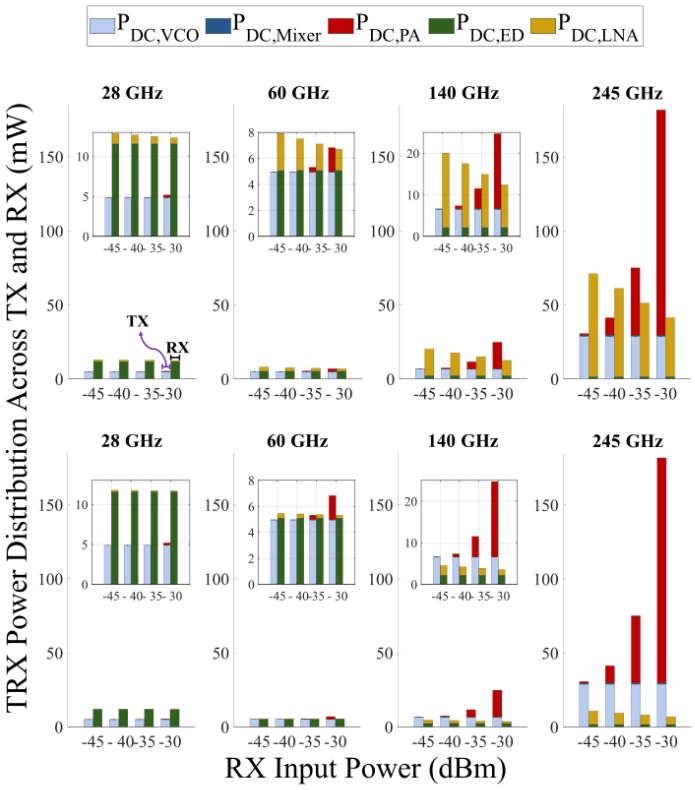



Fig. 11. TRX power breakdown as a function of receiver input power for different carrier frequencies, with fixed $P_{\text{in,PA}} = P_{\text{out,LNA}} = -10$ dBm. Top: NF = 7 dB, $R_b = 11$ Gbps. Bottom: NF = 15 dB, $R_b = 2.2$ Gbps.

**Fig. 10.5** Continuous contour maps of total RF transceiver power consumption versus carrier frequency and received power under stringent (NF = 7 dB) and relaxed (NF = 15 dB) receiver noise figures, highlighting optimal operating points across 28, 60, 140, and 245 GHz. [Reproduced from: M. Shahmoradi et al., "Channel-Aware Behavioral Power Modeling of CMOS OOK Transceivers for Wireless Network-on-Chip Systems", *IEEE Transactions on Circuits and Systems I: Regular Papers*, Vol. 73, No. 4, pp. 1620–1633, 2026, DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19449802. [46] © 2026 IEEE]

## 10.6 Hardware Implementation: Synthesizable Photonic MRR Switch

Listing 10.1 shows the synthesizable Verilog module implementing an electro-optic Micro-Ring Resonator controller with closed-loop proportional thermal resonance tracking and pulse-width modulated (PWM) microheater actuation.

**Listing 10.1** Synthesizable Photonic MRR Switch Controller with Closed-Loop Thermal Tuning (`photonic_mrr_switch.v`)

```
module photonic_mrr_switch #(
    parameter TEMP_WIDTH      = 10,      // 0.1 deg C LSB resolution
    parameter TARGET_TEMP     = 10'd550, // 55.0 deg C target resonance
    parameter PWM_WIDTH       = 8,       // 8-bit microheater DAC resolution
    parameter LOCK_TOLERANCE  = 10'd5    // +/- 0.5 deg C lock window
)(
    input  wire                    clk,
    input  wire                    rst_n,

    // Optical Switching Command
    input  wire                    switch_cmd,    // 0 = Through, 1 = Drop
    output reg                     optical_state, // Actuated optical routing state
    output reg                     switch_ready,  // Asserted when resonance is locked

    // Digital Thermal Sensor Feedback
    input  wire [TEMP_WIDTH-1:0]   measured_temp,
    input  wire                    temp_valid,

    // Microheater Control Outputs
    output reg  [PWM_WIDTH-1:0]    heater_power_val,
    output wire                    heater_pwm_pulse,
    output reg                     thermal_alarm
);

    reg [PWM_WIDTH-1:0] pwm_counter;

    // PWM Pulse Generator for Resistive Microheater
    assign heater_pwm_pulse = (pwm_counter < heater_power_val);

    always @(posedge clk or negedge rst_n) begin
        if (!rst_n) pwm_counter <= {PWM_WIDTH{1'b0}};
        else        pwm_counter <= pwm_counter + 1'b1;
    end

    // Proportional Thermal Resonance Tracking Loop: Keep the tuning fork on pitch!
    always @(posedge clk or negedge rst_n) begin
```

```
        if (!rst_n) begin
            heater_power_val <= 8'd128; // 50% initial duty
                cycle
            optical_state    <= 1'b0;
            switch_ready     <= 1'b0;
            thermal_alarm    <= 1'b0;
        end else begin
            if (temp_valid) begin
                if (measured_temp < TARGET_TEMP) begin
                    // Cavity cold: boost microheater actuation
                    if (heater_power_val < 8'd250)
                        heater_power_val <= heater_power_val +
                            8'd2;
                end else begin
                    // Cavity hot: reduce heater actuation
                    if (heater_power_val > 8'd5)
                        heater_power_val <= heater_power_val -
                            8'd2;
                end

                // Verify thermal locking within tolerance
                    window (+/- 0.5 deg C)
                if ((measured_temp >= (TARGET_TEMP -
                    LOCK_TOLERANCE)) &&
                    (measured_temp <= (TARGET_TEMP +
                        LOCK_TOLERANCE))) begin
                    switch_ready  <= 1'b1; // Locked and ready
                        to route light!
                    thermal_alarm <= 1'b0;
                end else begin
                    switch_ready  <= 1'b0;
                    if (measured_temp > (TARGET_TEMP + 10'd200))
                        thermal_alarm <= 1'b1;
                    else
                        thermal_alarm <= 1'b0;
                end
            end

            // Optical routing actuation: default safe to
                Through state if unlocked
            if (switch_ready) optical_state <= switch_cmd;
            else              optical_state <= 1'b0;
        end
    end
endmodule
```

## 10.7 Simulation Model & Numerical Verification

The Python model `onoc_optical_loss_sim.py` simulates end-to-end optical insertion loss, laser power, and thermal tuning in an $8 \times 8$ mesh ONoC (64 com-

pute nodes, 20 mm × 20 mm die area) comparing traditional Crossing Switching Elements (CSEs) against Parallel Switching Elements (PSEs). Table 10.1 summarizes the experimental metrics.

**Table 10.1** Comparative Evaluation: Crossing Switching Elements (CSE) vs. Parallel Switching Elements (PSE) in an 8 × 8 ONoC

| Metric | CSE Baseline | PSE (Kao et al.) | Key Architectural Impact |
|---|---|---|---|
| Waveguide Crossings | 62 | **24** | −**61.3**% fewer optical intersections |
| Active MRR Count | 192 | **112** | −**41.7**% fewer tuning resonators |
| Worst-Case Insertion Loss | 11.38 dB | **6.38** dB | −**5.00** dB optical signal boost |
| Required Optical Laser Power | 0.27 mW | **0.09** mW | **3.0**× lower laser power |
| Laser Electrical Wall Power | 1.37 mW | **0.43** mW | Sub-milliwatt continuous source |
| Thermal Tuning Power (15°C) | 5184.0 mW | **3024.0** mW | −**2.16** W lower heater dissipation |
| Total Subsystem Power | 5185.4 mW | **3024.4** mW | −**41.7**% overall energy reduction |

The simulation results confirm that by eliminating internal crossings, the PSE architecture reduces maximum insertion loss by 5.00 dB. Because optical laser power scales exponentially with decibel loss, this 5 dB reduction cuts optical source power requirements by 3×. Furthermore, reducing MRR usage from 192 to 112 directly slashes active thermal tuning dissipation from 5.18 W to 3.02 W, proving that physically aware topology synthesis is mandatory for practical optical networks.

## 10.8 Summary: What You Learned

- **Light Moves at Light Speed**: Optical NoCs send photons through microscopic silicon waveguides with zero data-dependent wire charging loss.
- **Micro-Ring Resonators Are Tuning Forks**: They select specific wavelengths of light out of a multi-color beam, enabling Wavelength Division Multiplexing (WDM).
- **Parallel Switching Saves Power**: Using parallel waveguides instead of crossing intersections saves 5 dB of optical loss, cutting laser power threefold.
- **Silicon Resonators Need Heating**: Heat shifts resonance by 0.1 nm/°C, so smart microheaters keep the resonators locked on pitch like tuning a guitar.
- **Wireless NoC is Walkie-Talkie for Chips**: 60 GHz on-chip radios broadcast messages to all 64 cores simultaneously in a single cycle.

## 10.9 Exercises and Review Questions

1. **The Optical Tuning Fork**: An optical cavity has radius $R = 6.0\,\mu\text{m}$ and effective refractive index $n_{\text{eff}} = 2.45$ at optical wavelength $\lambda_0 = 1550\,\text{nm}$.
   a. Calculate the optical round-trip path length $L = 2\pi R$.
   b. Determine the integer resonant mode order $m = L \cdot n_{\text{eff}}/\lambda_0$.
   c. Explain in plain English what happens if light of wavelength 1540 nm enters the waveguide.
2. **The Laser Flashlight**: An optical path has 3.5 cm of waveguide (0.25 dB/cm), 16 bends (0.005 dB/bend), 30 crossings (0.12 dB/crossing), 20 unselected MRRs (0.015 dB/thru), and 2 drop MRRs (0.50 dB/drop). Modulator loss is 1.5 dB and receiver sensitivity is $-21.0\,\text{dBm}$.
   a. Calculate the total end-to-end insertion loss $L_{\text{path}}$ in decibels.
   b. For a 3.0 dB operating margin, compute the required laser optical power in milliwatts.
   c. If laser wall-plug efficiency is $\eta_{\text{wpe}} = 18\%$, calculate the total electrical power consumed.
3. **The Hot CPU**: If chip temperature fluctuates by 20°C and $d\lambda/dT = 0.10\,\text{nm}/^\circ\text{C}$, compute the wavelength shift and the total power needed to stabilize 128 MRRs with 20.0 mW/nm microheaters.
4. **Walkie-Talkie vs. Whisper**: Why is an on-chip 60 GHz wireless broadcast faster for cache invalidation than sending 63 separate point-to-point electrical packets through a mesh network?

# Appendix A
# Open-Source NoC Frameworks, RTL Repositories & PDKs

## A.1 Synthesizable Verilog & SystemVerilog NoC Codebases

To facilitate reproducible experimentation, several landmark academic and industrial NoC architectures have been made open-source:

- **FlooNoC (ETH Zürich / University of Bologna)**: An open-source SystemVerilog Network-on-Chip supporting wide physical links, AXI4 parallel multistreaming, and AXI-Stream virtualization.
  - Repository: https://github.com/pulp-platform/floonoc
  - Key Reference: Fischer et al., *IEEE TVLSI 2025* [15].
- **HammerBlade Manycore (University of Washington / UCSD / Cornell)**: A complete open-source 2,048-core RISC-V compute fabric and Ruche network silicon implementation in 12nm FinFET.
  - Repository: https://github.com/bespoke-silicon-group/bsg_manycore
  - Key Reference: Gao et al., *IEEE TVLSI 2026* [19].
- **OpenPiton & Princeton Piton NoC**: A scalable manycore framework supporting SPARC and RISC-V with a 2D mesh packet-switched interconnect.
  - Repository: https://github.com/PrincetonUniversity/openpiton

## A.2 Open-Source Physical Design PDKs

Academic exploration of sub-14nm interconnect physics is supported by open-source process design kits:

- **FreePDK45**: 45nm predictive technology model with 10 metal layers.

- **ASAP7**: 7nm FinFET Predictive Process Design Kit developed by Arizona State University in collaboration with ARM.
- **SkyWater 130nm (SKY130)**: The first fully open-source manufacturable 130nm CMOS foundry PDK.

# Solutions to Checkpoint Questions

## Chapter 1: The Multi-Core Communication Crisis & Interconnect Physics

Question 1.1 **Answer: B**. According to the Elmore delay formulation (Eq. 1.4), the propagation delay of a shared wire is $\tau \approx 0.38 R_{wire} C_{wire} + R_{driver} \sum C_{tap} + \sum R_{wire} C_{tap}$. Because each attached core introduces transceiver parasitic capacitance ($C_{taps} \propto N$) and the physical wire length across the chip perimeter scales as $L \propto \sqrt{N}$, the total $RC$ product surges as $O(N^{3/2})$, resulting in severe frequency throttling for $N > 8$.

Question 1.2 **Answer: B**. The Mayadas-Shatzkes effect models electron scattering at polycrystalline grain boundaries in nanoscale metal lines. When wire trench width approaches the electron mean free path ($\lambda_0 \approx 39$ nm in bulk copper), grain boundary reflection ($R \approx 0.3$–$0.5$) and surface diffuse reflection combine with non-conductive barrier liners (Ta/TaN) to surge effective resistivity by $5\times$ to $15\times$ above bulk values, destroying global interconnect RC performance.

Question 1.3 **Answer: A**. An $N \times N$ crossbar requires $N^2$ crosspoint multiplexer switches and $2N \times W_{data}$ wiring tracks crossing the central layout. For $N = 128$, this dictates 16,384 crosspoints and thousands of parallel global wires, creating insurmountable physical routing track congestion and parasitic crosstalk in silicon layout.

## Chapter 2: Switching Techniques, Flow Control & Buffer Management

Question 2.1 **Answer: B**. Wormhole switching operates at the granularity of individual flits rather than entire packets. By allowing body flits to stream across established router paths behind the head flit, input buffer depth can be

reduced to as few as 1–4 flits, reducing router SRAM buffer area by 75%–93% compared to Store-and-Forward and Virtual Cut-Through.

Question 2.2 **Answer: B**. The credit turnaround loop Round-Trip Time is $RTT = t_{tx} + t_{flight_fwd} + t_{rx} + t_{flight_cred} = 4$ cycles. By the Fundamental Throughput Theorem (Eq. 2.7), sustaining 100% wire-rate throughput requires $B \geq RTT = 4$ flits. With $B = 2$, the transmitter exhausts its credits after 2 cycles and is forced to stall during cycles 3 and 4 while waiting for credit feedback, throttling link utilization to 40%–50%.

Question 2.3 **Answer: B**. In the SWIFT NoC, lightweight tokens travel ahead of data flits to reserve crossbar switch allocation in advance. When a token is granted, the incoming data flit cuts directly through the crossbar into the outgoing link without writing into or reading from input FIFO SRAM cells, saving up to 38% of dynamic router power at saturation.

## Chapter 3: High-Performance Router Microarchitecture & Arbitration

Question 3.1 **Answer: B**. The canonical synchronous 5-stage router pipeline comprises: Buffer Write (BW), Route Computation (RC), Virtual Channel Allocation (VA), Switch Allocation (SA), and Switch Traversal (ST), followed by inter-router Link Traversal (LT).

Question 3.2 **Answer: A**. When Client $k$ receives a grant ($G_k = 1$), row $k$ is cleared to zero ($M[k][j] = 0\ \forall j \neq k$) and column $k$ is set to one ($M[i][k] = 1\ \forall i \neq k$). This places client $k$ at the lowest priority relative to all other requesters, implementing an exact, single-cycle Least Recently Used (LRU) policy.

Question 3.3 **Answer: B**. Updating round-robin pointers in later iterations would cause output grant arbiters to synchronize into identical priority positions when traffic is heavy. Restricting pointer updates to the first iteration preserves pointer diversity (entropy), preventing cyclic grant lockouts and achieving 100% throughput under uniform traffic.

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